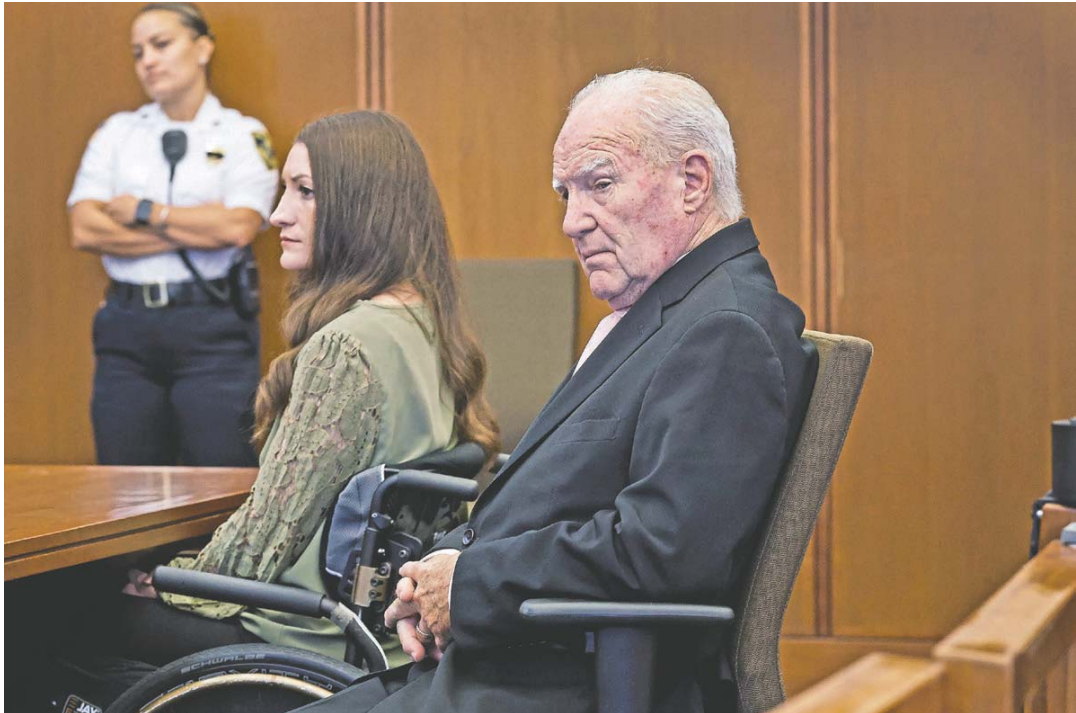




Partly sunny 83/67 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 83/66

Democracy Dies in Darkness

SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 5, 2026 • \$4



GREG DERR/PATRIOT LEDGER/USA TODAY NETWORK/REUTERS

Lindsay Clancy, who admitted to killing her three children, and attorney Kevin Reddington in a Masschusetts court on Friday.

Clancy triple-murder case ends in mistrial

Massachusetts trial put spotlight on postpartum mental health issues

BY VIOLET JIRA AND MARK BERMAN

The high-profile trial of Lindsay Clancy ended in a mistrial Friday after a Massachusetts jury could not reach a unanimous decision in the triple-murder case.

Judge William Sullivan dismissed the jury shortly after 2 p.m., thanking them for their service after deliberations hit nearly 40 hours in a trial that stretched more than six weeks.

Clancy's case captured the public's attention for the nature of the crimes and became a cultural touchpoint, putting postpartum mental health issues in the spotlight. She has admitted to killing her three children — Cora, 5; Dawson, 3; and Callan, 8 months — and the jury was tasked with deciding whether to accept her insanity plea.

Prosecutors must now decide whether they want to try the case again.

The trial was plunged into



CHARLES KRUPA/AP

District Attorney Timothy Cruz, front, leaves court after the judge declared a mistrial.

chaos for several hours Friday after Sullivan said he was going to declare a mistrial, and Clancy's defense attorney rushed to block that from happening.

At issue were the actions of a lone juror who Clancy's defense argued was not following orders

from the judge in regard to reasonable doubt.

Attorneys for Clancy submitted an emergency petition to the Massachusetts Supreme Judicial Court, asking it to order Sullivan to further scrutinize the juror or prevent them from continuing

to deliberate until the judge can determine that the person is able to follow the court's instructions.

They said the higher court's involvement was needed to prevent "an avoidable mistrial of a case that is so time and labor in-

SEE CLANCY ON A7

Trump to use Qatari plane for international trip

THERE ARE QUESTIONS ABOUT ITS SECURITY

President wants to take the gift on a visit to Ireland

BY CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

President Donald Trump plans to fly to Ireland next week aboard the Boeing 747 gifted to him by Qatar, a senior White House official said, marking his first international trip on the jet since a security threat in July prompted him to leave Turkey secretly aboard an alternate aircraft.

The trip underscores Trump's continued fondness for and reliance on the Qatari jet despite concerns that it lacks some of the security features of the highly customized, heavily fortified Boeing 747-200B jumbo jets that have carried presidents for decades.

Trump said in July that the new plane would be sent away to be "maxed out" to address those concerns. Despite suggestions that the security upgrades would be made this fall, the

White House has not announced a schedule for the work, which could slip until after the midterm elections.

"We don't comment on specific upgrades or modifications to Air Force One," said a senior administration official in a statement. "We maintain a consistent posture that ensures a safe, secure, and reliable capability for the President of the United States and routinely evolve the capability as required to maintain that posture."

In the absence of those upgrades, Trump is poised to use the Qatari-gifted plane more frequently as he ramps up his campaign-season travel. He is scheduled to travel to Texas next week to headline the Republican miniconvention in Dallas and said this week that he will be traveling to Alaska and other

SEE PLANE ON A13

Putin pursues military victory over Ukraine

CIA chief's visit failed to persuade Russian leader to stop the war

BY CATHERINE BELTON, GREG MILLER AND WARREN P. STROBEL

Russian President Vladimir Putin, aiming to exploit Ukraine's badly weakened air defenses, is intensifying a bombing campaign that he believes will force Kyiv to capitulate on some of his key territorial demands, perhaps by this winter, members of the Russian elite and analysts said.

In the 10 days since CIA Director John Ratcliffe made a rare, unexpected visit to Moscow, Russian forces have ramped up their missile and jet-powered-drone campaign, targeting civilian infrastructure including energy

and water supplies, supermarkets and food warehouses.

On Friday, with U.S. envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner expected to visit Moscow and Kyiv in the coming days try to restart stalled peace talks, a Russian drone struck the central headquarters of Ukraine's Security Service. Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha called the strike "a major escalation."

While the Russian economy deteriorates and public discontent grows, Putin this week expressed confidence in the war's progress.

"I have no doubt that the enemy will crumble," he told Russian journalists. His remarks appeared to confirm assessments that Ratcliffe's visit not only failed to persuade the Russian leader to stop the war, but may have hardened his resolve to sidestep a ceasefire and continue to push Ukraine to concede territory.

SEE PUTIN ON A12

Behind-the-scenes of nation's worst ongoing measles outbreak

Public health workers are relying on word of mouth to fight a situation they expect will only get worse

BY LENA H. SUN AND RACHEL ROUBEIN

Pennsylvania health workers confronting the country's largest ongoing measles outbreak have been trying a behind-the-scenes strategy: administering vaccines around a family's kitchen table, inside the privacy of their own home.

The approach is deliberate, doctors say, relying on word of mouth for some immunization clinics rather than advertising locations that may draw reporters or protesters. Pop-up clinics are happening inside fire stations, places of worship and on a neighbor's front porch. The effort reflects the great lengths

officials are taking to contain an outbreak flaring in a state where officials say two people who died, including a newborn, were infected with measles.

In Lancaster County, which has 45 percent of the state's cases, some children have never received a vaccine — not because their parents specifically oppose vaccination or are hesitant, but because some Plain communities, including the Amish and conservative Mennonite groups, rarely seek routine medical care, according to doctors who live and practice in the area.

SEE MEASLES ON A8

Case confirmed: A Pa. coroner says an infant died of measles. **A7**

Storms rocking the region



PETER W. STEVENSON/THE WASHINGTON POST

A downed tree blocks westbound lanes on Massachusetts Ave. NW at the corner of 11th St. NW on Friday after overnight severe thunderstorms passed through the area. More coverage, **B13**.

Jobs are up, but wages are falling, data shows

BY LAUREN KAORI GURLEY AND RACHEL LERMAN

Inflation has been eating away at Americans' paychecks this year.

For most of the past six months, inflation has been beating wage growth, which fell in August to the slowest pace since the pandemic, according to data released Friday by the Labor Department.

Wages rose 3.1 percent in August compared to a year earlier, while inflation picked up by 3.4 percent for the year ending in July, according to the latest data.

And for young people looking for their first job, as well as the

SEE INFLATION ON A15

Good job: The economy added 162,000 jobs in August. **A14**

IN THE NEWS

Oil deal gamble President Donald Trump's huge Venezuela pact began with a phone call and a bet on wealthy Venezuelan oilman Alejandro Betancourt. **A18**

Affordability defined: Voters everywhere are focused on affordability. But what that means depends on the state they live in. **A3**

THE NATION
Confusion over new federal rules left some students unable to pay their college loans. **A4**
Longtime host Maria Bartiromo's attorney denies reports she was fired from Fox News. **A6**

THE WORLD
A water crisis in Israel has raised concerns over the impact of Gaza sewage. Five of Israel's six desalinization plants are offline. Shutdowns this week forced Israel to ration water for agricultural use. **A11**

THE ECONOMY
Almost one in every for U.S. homeowners is paying off their mortgage at a rate faster than they're required to — but the people who would benefit the most financially from applying this strategy are the ones least likely to be doing it. **A15**

STYLE
The internet is overflowing with unsent love letters. What do the missives reveal about modern dating? **B1**

SPORTS
In their push to increase fan engagement, MLB teams are turning to their furriest employees. **B7**

THE REGION
Trump administration officials said work will start within two weeks on the president's planned 250-foot-tall triumphal arch in Memorial Circle near Arlington National Cemetery, his most significant change to D.C.'s skyline. **B13**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A14
COMICS.....B4
OBITUARIES.....B16
OPINION PAGES.....A16
TELEVISION.....B6
WORLD NEWS.....A11

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Court throws out Missouri congressional map, helping Democrats keep seat

BY PATRICK MARLEY

The Missouri Supreme Court ruled Thursday that the state cannot use a congressional map that state Republicans designed to give the GOP an additional congressional seat this fall, a decision that helps Democrats in their quest to flip the House.

The court in its unanimous ruling also approved putting a referendum on the November ballot that will allow voters to decide whether to use the GOP-favored map in future elections. Republicans were dealt another setback halfway across the country Thursday when the Maryland Supreme Court agreed to place a redistricting referendum on the November ballot, an initiative designed to eventually eliminate the state's lone GOP-held House seat.

The Missouri ruling will prob-

ably keep one seat in the Democrats' column as Republicans fight to hang onto a razor-thin majority. The Maryland ruling would pay dividends for Democrats in 2028 if voters sign off on their plan.

The Missouri decision prompts major questions for voters and election officials. State officials used the map favored by Republicans for last month's primary even though courts had told them it could be in legal jeopardy. Now, the state is confronted with a conundrum: Party nominees were chosen under one set of congressional lines, but candidates will run under different ones in November.

Missouri Attorney General Catherine Hanaway (R) said she would appeal the ruling to the U.S. Supreme Court, but she faces a difficult timeline. Ballots must be set by Tuesday under

state law, and they will be mailed to voters soon.

"This unprecedented decision clearly violates federal law and has thrust our state into a full-fledged constitutional crisis," Hanaway said in a social media post.

House Minority Leader Ha-keem Jeffries (D-New York) called the decision a victory for voters "and a clear message to MAGA extremists trying to rig the midterm elections."

President Donald Trump said the map favoring Republicans should be put back in place. "This is a Dark Day for Justice" in Missouri!" he wrote on social media.

Republican state lawmakers last year redrew Missouri's congressional map at the behest of Trump to give themselves an advantage in an additional House district. The plan was meant to

ensure that Rep. Emanuel Cleaver, one of two Democrats in the state's eight-member House delegation, would not be reelected.

The anti-gerrymandering group People Not Politicians submitted more than 300,000 signatures to place a measure on the ballot that would block the map until voters could decide whether they want to use it.

Missouri Secretary of State Denny Hoskins (R) rejected their petitions, saying the state constitution didn't allow ballot measures related to congressional redistricting.

Richard von Glahn, the leader of People Not Politicians, sued. A county judge ruled against him last month, but the state Supreme Court sided with him Thursday. The court found the new map had never gone into effect because the group had filed enough petitions to force

a referendum on it. Citizens' right to call for a referendum on laws passed by the state legislature "is an essential part of the state's lawmaking process under the Missouri Constitution," state Supreme Court Judge Ginger K. Gooch wrote for the majority.

In a footnote, the court took issue with the secretary of state for telling the court about the confusion, expenses and logistical problems that would emerge if the court ruled against him.

"These arguments are particularly misplaced given the secretary's delay created the confusion, expense, and practical difficulties of which he complains," Gooch wrote for the court.

Hoskins, the secretary of state, released a statement vowing to protect the new map.

"We may have lost the battle today, but the war to preserve

our constitutional republic is far from over," Hoskins said in a statement.

In Maryland, Republican state lawmakers asked courts to block Democrats' redistricting measure from the November ballot, arguing on technicalities that the Democratic supermajority in Annapolis crafted the proposed state constitutional amendment too late and wrote the ballot question in a misleading way.

The state Supreme Court disagreed about the timeliness but ruled the referendum should proceed with different language.

The ruling was a victory for Maryland Gov. Wes Moore (D), who has spent nearly a year persuading Democrats to help him redraw the state's map to offset Republican-redrawn maps in other states.

Erin Cox contributed to this report.

The Washington Post

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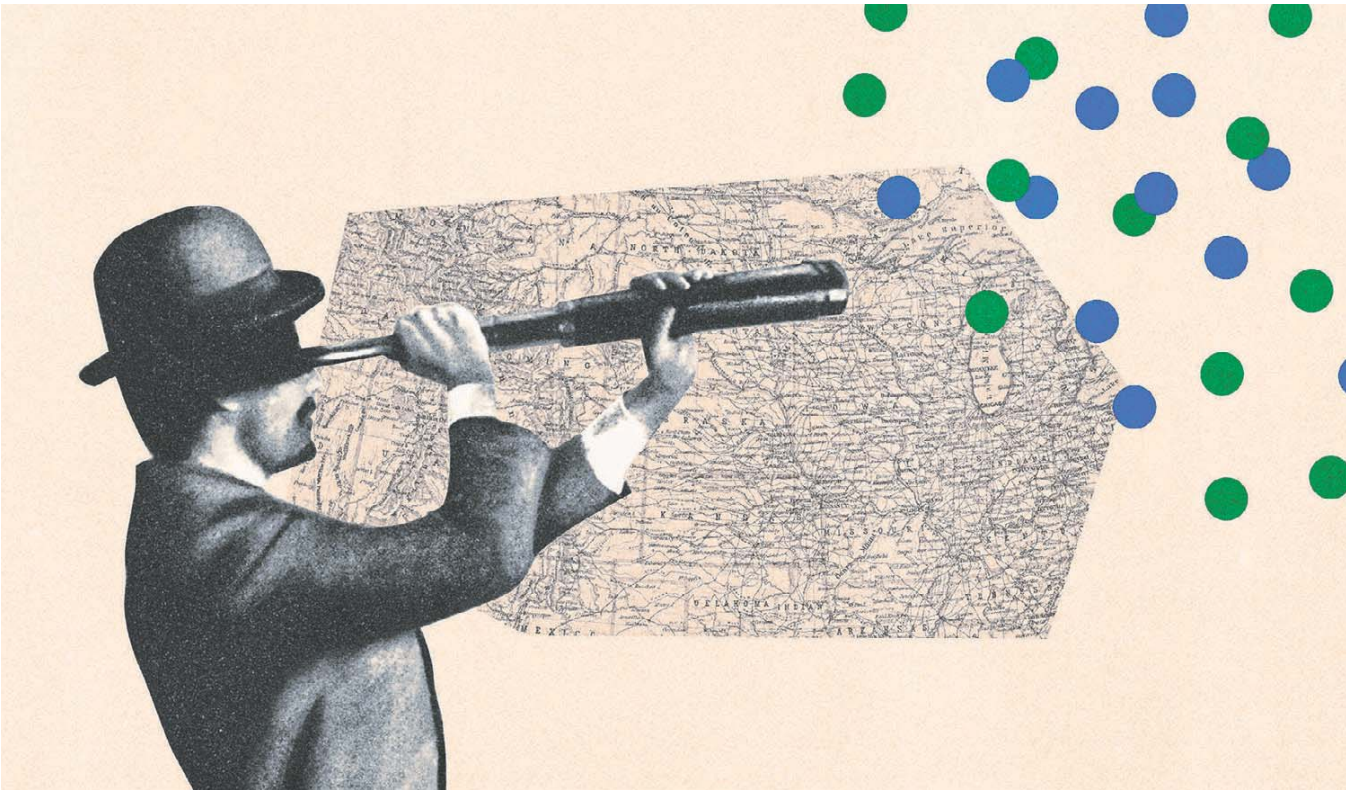
CORRECTIONS

• An Aug. 23 Page One article about a billionaire's effort to combat homelessness incorrectly said that Scott Centorino was a lobbyist for the Cicero Institute. He is a senior fellow at Cicero, and the institute is a client of his consulting firm.

• A September 4 Style section Screens column about Gloria Steinem inadvertently omitted the final words of the piece. The full text of the concluding sentence is, "She examined a culture that felt completely foreign and deeply revelatory, and it turned out the culture was our own."

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Email: corrections@washpost.com.
Call: 202-334-6000, and ask to be connected to the desk involved — National, Foreign, Metro, Style, Sports, Business or any of the weekly sections.



NATALIE VINEBERG/ILLUSTRATION BY NATALIE VINEBERG/THE WASHINGTON POST

THE POLLWATCHER

Independents aren't just undercover partisans after all

Plus: Why people are drinking less, and whose best friend is a chatbot?

BY SCOTT CLEMENT

This week's Pollwatcher looks at why people are drinking less alcohol, how the world judges America and how many people use chatbots like a friend. But first ...

A record-high 45 percent of Americans identified as political independents in Gallup polls last year, but that statistic carries a huge asterisk.

Decades of surveys show most independents lean Democratic or Republican, and those who do look a lot like partisans in their political views and how they vote. Political scientists and media have dubbed some independents "Undercover Partisans," "Republican Lookalikes" and "Disguised Democrats."

While few independents fit the ideal of an unbiased swing voter, recent research suggests there's more to the story:

• **"Reluctant partisans, not undercover partisans"** — Duke University postdoctoral researcher Alex Tolkin investigated why people switch from Democrat or Republican to independent by tracking party identification among roughly 5,000 Americans from 2016 to 2022 in a probability-based NORC survey. The best predictors of switching to independent were having negative opinions of their initial party and disliking their party's 2020 presidential candidate, suggesting that many independents have substantive beefs with their preferred party. "It has nothing to do with how willing they are to express a political opinion, or how civil they think politics is, or anything like that," Tolkin says. "They just don't like their party anymore."

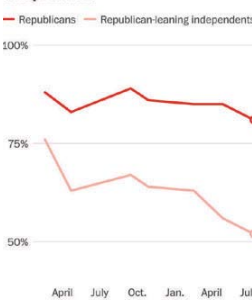
• **Partisanship doesn't color their perceptions of reality (as much)** — Perceptions of the economy, seriousness of crime and other issues have been increasingly tainted by partisanship. But because independents are less loyal, they are more likely to base their opinions in real-world experiences than

partisan cues, according to political scientists Joshua Dyck of the University of Massachusetts at Lowell and Shanna Pearson-Merkowitz of the University of Maryland. Their research found that among pure independents, concern about crime was closely tied to actual levels of crime where they live — the higher the crime rate, the more concerned independents were about the problem. By contrast, strong partisans' crime concerns were largely disconnected from local-level crime rates.

Why does any of this matter? President Donald Trump's weakness among political independents — particularly independents who lean Republican — is a key factor behind his low approval ratings and the challenges Republicans face this fall.

Washington Post-Ipsos polls show Trump's approval rating among Republican-leaning independents has fallen from 76 percent in February 2025 to 52 percent in July, even as 81 percent of self-identifying Republicans approved of his job performance this summer.

Trump's approval rating has fallen among Republican-leaning independents



Source: National polls by The Washington Post, ABC News and CREATED WITH DATAWRAPPER

The latest poll also found a big gap in economic perceptions: 50 percent of Republicans said groceries were affordable for them, compared with 32 percent of independents who lean Republican.

What it means for the midterm elections

One way to think about

independents who lean toward a party is a wayward segment of the base that needs extra persuasion to vote. While just 12 percent of "pure" independents were confirmed to vote in the 2022 midterm elections, according to a Pew Research Center study, turnout rose to nearly 4 in 10 among independents who lean Democratic or Republican. By comparison, 53 percent of rank-and-file Democrats and 59 percent of Republicans voted that year.

This year, the Democratic base appears more motivated to vote, a pattern that trickles down to independents who lean toward each party. The July Post-Ipsos poll found 63 percent of Democratic-leaning independent registered voters were certain to vote, slightly higher than 57 percent of independents who lean Republican. More than 6 in 10 Democratic-leaning independents said it is "more important to vote" than previous midterm elections, compared with about 4 in 10 Republicans-leaning independents.

Reader questions

The first Pollwatcher newsletter cited Gallup and federal health surveys showing fewer Americans are drinking alcohol. Linda emailed: "This begs the question, why? What explains this trend? Perhaps a follow up poll to see if they have switched to marijuana or mushrooms. Or are they completely abstaining from everything."

Great question! The Gallup poll itself has part of the answer: More people think moderate drinking is unhealthy. Their 2026 survey found 51 percent saying that "drinking in moderation — that is, one or two drinks a day" is bad for their health, similar to 53 percent in 2025 but up sharply from 28 percent in 2018.

Surveys suggest marijuana use is up, though they disagree on how much. Gallup found 17 percent of adults report smoking marijuana, tying a record

high in 2023 and up from 12 percent in surveys from 2017 to 2021. The National Survey of Drug Use and Health (NSDUH) found monthly marijuana use grew from 12.3 percent in 2021 to 14.9 percent in 2025 among adults ages 26 and older, while decreasing slightly among younger adults.

The question of how many people are substituting alcohol with other drugs is harder to answer, as these surveys don't interview the same people each year. Both datasets find marijuana and alcohol usage tend to overlap. In 2024, the NSDUH found 6 percent of adults used marijuana in the past month but did not drink, 16 percent did both while 32 percent only drank.

Worth your attention

The world now judges America based on Trump

People around the world have yo-yoed in their ratings of U.S. presidents of different parties, giving largely positive ratings for Democrats Barack Obama and Joe Biden and largely negative marks for George W. Bush and Trump. But opinions of the U.S. overall have generally been on a separate track — in 2018 for instance, Pew found a median of 27 percent of people across 25 nations saying they were confident in Trump, but 50 percent had a favorable view of the U.S.

That has shifted, with Pew global surveys finding a spike in the correlation between views of the U.S. and its president since Trump started his second term. Trump's popularity hasn't changed much since his first term, but favorable views of the U.S. around the world have dropped to a median of 37 percent this year. "People in many countries now evaluate the U.S. and its president as a 'package,' rather than separately," writes Pew's Jonathan Schulman.

Send your questions, comments and ideas to scott.clement@washpost.com.

THE NATION



WASHINGTON POST ILLUSTRATION; ISTOCK/THE WASHINGTON POST

From fertilizer costs in Iowa to fuel prices in Alaska, affordability is a crucial issue for Americans heading into this year's midterm elections, where key races will determine control of Congress.

The biggest affordability issues for voters in four competitive Senate races

What affordability means to people depends on the state they live in

BY DAN MERICA AND RACHEL LERMAN

Voters nationwide are grappling with rising prices. But in several states that could decide control of the Senate, distinct cost drivers are fueling affordability concerns.

In Iowa, it's the rising price of diesel to power farm equipment. In Michigan, it's the specter of higher electric rates from new data centers. In Alaska, it's soaring fuel prices across the vast state. And in Florida, it's the nation's highest home insurance premiums.

While surging gas prices and rising grocery bills affect pretty much every American, polls show, candidates and political operatives say these more specific affordability concerns are defining competitive Senate races in their states.

Michigan: Energy and data centers

One of the biggest issues in Michigan is the proliferation of data center projects. The massive computing facilities, which are expanding across the country to support the artificial intelligence boom, have become increasingly controversial among voters — in part because of fears about rising electricity rates.

Residential electricity rates in Michigan already are about 16 percent higher than the national average. And consumers have faced repeated rate hikes as the state's two main corporate electricity providers work to manage the reliability and distributional capacity of aging infrastructure, including a costly coal plant that the Trump administration demanded stay open.

The major power companies have pledged that planned data centers will not increase rates for residential households, and Gov. Gretchen Whitmer (D) has asked data center companies to sign a pledge to “protect Michigan consumers from higher energy bills.”

But data centers remain “a very hot topic in Michigan,” said Erik Nordman, director of the Institute of Public Utilities at Michigan State University. “There’s a lot of investment that needs to go into the [energy] distribution system to make it more reliable, and that’s happening at a time when there’s interest in data centers and growing demand.”

Abdul El-Sayed, the Democratic nominee for the seat being vacated by Sen. Gary Peters (D), said data centers have “become a

flash point in a broader conversation about public power, about who politicians answer to, about what the future looks like when it comes to work.”

Both he and Mike Rogers, the former congressman who won the Republican nomination for Senate, are advocating a pause on data center expansion. Rogers told the Detroit News he supports a one-year moratorium on new developments, while El-Sayed said he wants “no more data centers until we can do it safely and with federal protections.”

Rogers declined to be interviewed for this piece. His spokesperson, Alyssa Brouillet, blamed “Democrat control of Lansing” for “bankrupting Michiganders with the highest energy rates in the Midwest.” Brouillet also criticized El-Sayed’s support for green energy projects, echoing Republican arguments that moving away from fossil fuels is raising energy costs.

El-Sayed blamed the high rates on “the power of a few corporations and the ability to buy politicians” in Michigan and noted that Rogers accepts corporate PAC money. The Democrat dismissed Brouillet’s complaints about green energy as “the same old stupid Republican talking point.”

Iowa: Diesel and fertilizer

Iowa farmers, already suffering from tariffs and falling crop prices, say they have been walloped by the economic fallout of President Donald Trump’s war with Iran. Diesel prices are up more than 60 percent this year, making it dramatically more expensive to power farm equipment.

Fertilizer prices also have increased sharply due to disrupted supply chains. While some farmers had locked in lower prices before the war began, many have been stunned by the increase as they look ahead to the next planting season.

“The problem we have in agriculture is we have very few places where we can buy fertilizer and other inputs,” said Aaron Lehman, a fifth-generation farmer in central Iowa and president of the Iowa Farmers Union.

Josh Turek, the Democratic nominee for the Senate seat being vacated by incumbent Joni Ernst (R), has made winning back rural areas a focus of his campaign. Turek said he repeatedly hears the word “betrayal” from voters who trusted Trump and other Republicans to lower prices.

“Forty years ago, we lost half of our small family farms in the first farm crisis,” Turek said. “Unfortunately, this is setting us up for a second farm crisis. Iowans



Demonstrators protest a data center in Saline, Michigan, on July 30.



Beach homes in Fort Myers Beach, Florida, suffered major damage by Hurricane Ian in 2022.

are really ready for change because we have hit the bottom.”

Rep. Ashley Hinson, the Republican nominee, acknowledged farmers’ pain and said she “of course” wants to get fuel prices down. But she argued that high prices present a “great opportunity” to produce more “homegrown fuel,” including ethanol from corn grown in Iowa.

The campaign also referred questions to corn farmer Lance Lillibridge, who said he supports Hinson because she understands “we are already in a crisis.”

High input prices for farmers are “a much bigger deal than Washington is admitting to or acknowledging,” Lillibridge said. “The check engine light’s been on, and if it doesn’t get fixed, the

engine’s gonna blow.”

Alaska: Gasoline and home heating

In Alaska, where there are few people and fewer roads, gasoline, diesel and other fuels are needed to power almost everything. Local microgrids that generate electricity. Off-road vehicles used to hunt for meat and collect water. Cooking stoves.

While gasoline prices in Juneau and Fairbanks are hovering around \$4.75 per gallon, prices in rural areas have spiked to \$11 a gallon, said Nils Andreassen, executive director of the Alaska Municipal League, a nonprofit representing local governments.

And in Shungnak, a village in the state’s frigid northwest, gaso-

line hit \$26.82 per gallon one day last month, according to Alaska Beacon, an online news site.

The price of gas and diesel is “pretty directly related to having enough to eat or water to drink,” Andreassen said. “Fuel is tied to food, and fuel is tied to heat.”

Mary Peltola, a former Democratic congresswoman who is the top challenger to incumbent Sen. Dan Sullivan (R), blamed spiking fuel prices on the war in Iran, which she said she would have opposed as a senator. She called surging prices “a life-or-death issue” for Alaskans.

“I would put [fuel prices] at number one” among the state’s most important issues, Peltola said. “It’s impacting every single Alaskan and the success, or the

failures, of our household.”

Sullivan has said he is working to double Alaska’s share of federal home heating assistance and to ease environmental restrictions on domestic oil production and refining. But he has been a steadfast supporter of the war with Iran, claiming that Iran has “been at war with us for almost a half century.”

Sullivan’s campaign did not respond to requests for comment.

Florida: Home insurance

Florida has the highest home insurance premiums in the country, according to the insurance comparison website Insurify. With annual average premiums of \$8,292, Floridians paid more than twice the national average to insure their homes last year.

Part of the problem is extreme and destructive weather. But another factor has been the proliferation of lawsuits. The Florida legislature enacted limits on certain litigation practices in 2022 and 2023. By this spring, premiums had fallen in most counties, according to a July report from the Florida Office of Insurance Regulation. And Citizens Property Insurance, the state-backed insurer of last resort, says its clients have plummeted by 80 percent — a sign that people are able to find private coverage.

Still, Florida is “such a costly and risky market that even positive signs don’t necessarily mean affordability,” said Julia Taliesin, an economic analyst at Insurify.

Angie Nixon, the Democratic state lawmaker who is challenging incumbent Sen. Ashley Moody (R), calls home insurance “a defining economic emergency for working families across Florida.” She accused Moody of “chas[ing] headlines and fight[ing] culture wars on cable news” instead of delivering relief.

“Over the last four years, property insurance rates have doubled while the corporate politicians in charge have done nothing but bail out the insurance industry and strip away homeowners’ rights,” Nixon said, referring to the new limits on litigation practices.

Moody, who is facing statewide voters for the first time since being appointed to the seat once held by Secretary of State Marco Rubio, has acknowledged the impact of home insurance prices and co-sponsored the Flood Insurance Relief Act, a bill that would provide a tax deduction for flood insurance premiums. The bill, however, has gained no traction on Capitol Hill.

A spokesperson for Moody’s campaign pointed to reports of stabilizing home insurance premiums but declined to make the senator available for an interview.

New federal guidelines cost students with college loans

Rollout of the One Big Beautiful Bill Act's loan changes caused confusion

BY ERIN RODE
THE HECHINGER REPORT

Mikiah Roberson expected to receive her federal \$6,700 student loan disbursement sometime between May 27 and June 3, just in time to make her rent and car payments. Instead, June 3 came and went. Days, weeks and finally over a month passed.

Roberson, a graduate student in University of Maryland Global Campus's digital forensics and cyber investigation program, said the stress only compounded as her eight-week summer semester continued without any of her expected financial aid. As a disabled veteran, Roberson's tuition is covered, but she relies on federal student loans to pay for living expenses while in school.

"It had a major impact on my mental and emotional health," Roberson said, as she struggled to get clear answers on when or if she might receive the money. "Just constantly stressing out whether an eviction notice would be coming, if my lights would be turned off, if my car would be repossessed."

Federal student loan disbursements for many students, like Roberson, were delayed over the summer session after new federal rules kicked in on July 1 that required major updates to the systems colleges use to administer aid. While no one is tracking the full scale of the problem, experts are worried about whether delays will persist into the fall semester that is underway. That could have severe impacts for the nearly 60 percent of students who already experience some form of housing or food insecurity.

When loan money gets held up, students have no recourse against either their school or the federal government. Instead they must find ways to temporarily cover personal budget gaps of thousands of dollars — at a time when the cost of housing and other basic needs are rising rapidly.

Delayed student loan disbursements are "incredibly significant in terms of whether a student is able to remain enrolled and remain housed and cover their own basic needs," said Aissa Canchola Bañez, policy director at Protect Borrowers, a nonprofit that advocates for student loan borrowers. "Everything is more expensive, and so that just makes financial aid and the loans that these students are eligible for and entitled to even more consequential."

Experts, advocates and financial aid administrators place the blame on atypical planning from Congress when it passed the One Big Beautiful Bill Act. The legislation didn't give the Education Department enough time to issue full guidance on new student loan regulations, leaving many colleges struggling to adapt. In some cases they are waiting on third-party software vendors to make needed changes or are calculating and administering aid by hand.

Ellen Keast, a spokesperson for the Education Department, said in an email that the department worked within the deadlines set by the One Big Beautiful Bill Act, which required the changes to take effect on July 1, 2026.

"Congress gave the Department less than a year to implement these changes," Keast said.

She noted that the agency released the final rules in May, which she said provided "time for schools to prepare."

Rep. Tim Walberg (R-Michigan), chairman of the House Committee on Education and Workforce, said in an emailed statement that the legislation significantly overhauled a "broken system" and praised the work the Education Department had done.

"Delaying needed reforms would have negative consequences for students and taxpayers," he said.

The One Big Beautiful Bill Act, signed by President Donald Trump on July 4, 2025, includes a number of provisions that reshape federal student loans, including a new lifetime borrowing limit and lowered limits on outstanding aggregate debt for graduate students. The bill also placed new limits on Parent PLUS loans and eliminated the Graduate PLUS loan program. Another provision, starting the 2026-27 school year, requires schools to prorate loan amounts based on how many credits a student is taking. Altogether, the changes are expected to impact a



House Speaker Mike Johnson (R-Louisiana) speaks about passage of the One Big Beautiful Bill Act during a news conference last year.

significant number of the roughly 13 million students annually who rely on federal financial aid.

When students don't receive their money on time, the delays set off an avalanche of financial problems.

One student in National University's graduate program in marriage and family therapy told The Hechinger Report she expected a \$5,000 disbursement sometime around June 1. The student (whose name is being withheld out of concern of retaliation from her university) relies on these disbursements every three months to cover two months of rent, as she slowly saves up to pay the third month's rent through her part-time job as a nanny.

"I had to reach out to family members and get help, and that was also really stressful for them because I was hoping to be able to pay them back with my refund, and nobody knew when the refund was coming," she said. "And so that just kind of created a cascade of tough situations."

She didn't receive her funds until mid-July. By that point, she'd paid rent late in June and July, with a \$100 late fee each time.

National University did not respond to requests for comment.

When it comes to disbursing financial aid, the relationship between the federal government and higher education institutions is complex. To help mitigate that, the Higher Education Act lays out a "master calendar," which outlines formal dates and deadlines the Education Department must follow.

Under the master calendar,

the department has to start the rulemaking process a full year and a half before the academic school year starts. After negotiations, months of public comment and department review, a final rule needs to be issued in November of the preceding year. But because the One Big Beautiful Bill Act was signed in July 2025 with an effective date of July 1, the department couldn't follow this timeline. And that gave colleges less time to adjust.

Colleges normally spend the months between November and the start of the next academic year understanding any new regulations, getting clarifying questions answered by the Education Department, and making sure their software vendors have what they need to update their systems, according to Sarah Austin, a policy analyst at the National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators.

"Just having enough time to get the information, make sure the software vendors have the information, make sure they can then reprogram everything, getting the specs that they need — all of that takes time," Austin said. "What we've seen here is a condensed version of that." As of August, some of the major software vendors used by colleges still weren't caught up, she noted.

The National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators and over 40 other higher education organizations had previously called on the Education Department to delay implementation until July 1, 2027, to allow the process to follow the normal timeline.

"That is not a minor inconvenience. It is a fundamental breakdown in the infrastructure that supports federal student aid delivery," wrote Kenneth Ferreira, then-president of the Eastern Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators, in an April op-ed.

Institutions also say that the federal government has been slow to roll out guidance and clarifications about some of these changes, and some details are still up in the air, said Austin. The Department released formal guidance on prorating loans for students who aren't enrolled full-time, for instance, in early August, just a couple of weeks before classes began at many institutions.

Some of the guidance has also been conflicting, with differing information across some of the Education Department's written materials and webinars, according to the National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators. On Aug. 20, a group of 16 congressional Democrats sent a letter calling on the Education Department to issue additional guidance clarifying how schools should prorate loans.

"We ended up seeing a lot of last-minute changes, and not enough guidance. And the reason why we have a master calendar provision is it is difficult for colleges to adapt to new regulations when there's not enough time," said Mark Kantrowitz, a student loan and financial aid expert.

To Keast, though, the final rule should not have come as a surprise to any colleges. She noted that last November, the depart-

ment reached consensus on the proposed rules, an early stage in the process.

"If institutions waited until the final rule was issued to start preparing, that was their decision," Keast said. She also pointed to available published guidance, Q&As, webinars and other resources from the department.

This rift between the department and many of the major organizations representing colleges and financial aid administrators is trickling down to students like Roberson.

"There was a whole lot of passing the buck," Roberson said on her attempts to get answers on what happened to her financial aid. University of Maryland Global Campus directed her to the Education Department's Federal Student Aid office. Employees there told her to contact her school.

"Nobody had answers for when the funds would be released," said Roberson, who said she often received conflicting information.

In an emailed statement, Kaitlin O'Connor, vice president of University Communications at the University of Maryland Global Campus, said the university has been working on the federally required processing changes.

"The university has continued processing and awarding aid, reviewing individual student cases and working closely with federal and higher education partners to ensure compliance with applicable requirements while supporting students throughout the process," the statement said.

Roberson negotiated partial payments with her landlord and

entered payment arrangements for other bills. But the wait stretched into its second month. "You're telling them, 'Hey, the money's coming,' but weeks are passing and nothing changes," she said. "I kept pushing out the dates and saying next month I'll be good, and then here we are at month two, and it's like now things are getting very detrimental."

Roberson continued, "You have to start to decide between do I pay a bill or do I get groceries? Do I get gas or do I get food?"

Meanwhile, the stress took a toll on her studies. "I knew that I didn't want to fail, but it was very, very hard," she said. "Me and a lot of my classmates were expressing to each other how difficult it is to focus on schoolwork when you have bills piling up and all these things you need to pay."

Experts predict the crunch will continue into the fall semester as schools try to catch up with the new rules.

Nick Prewett, executive director of financial aid and scholarship services at Stony Brook University and the president of the Eastern Association of Financial Aid Administrators, said so far the delayed disbursement has mostly impacted the school's medical students, who start in the summer.

But with fall semester underway at most schools, he said, "I think we're going to see some delays in aid getting out to students. And I think you're going to hear that kind of message across the country that students, particularly graduate students, are waiting," Prewett said.

Prewett added that for students enrolled part-time, Stony Brook plans on waiting until the end of the add/drop period (a couple of weeks after school starts) to adjust student loans based on the number of units students end up with. "And I think that's going to cause a little bit of confusion and maybe a little bit of panic on behalf of the student," he said.

Roberson eventually received her summer disbursement in mid-July, about six weeks late into an eight-week summer program. She's supposed to receive another \$6,700 disbursement in early September, but she's no longer counting on getting those funds on time. She's taking on work as a delivery driver for Amazon — a challenge with her back pain from her disability.

"I'm nervous because I don't know if we're going to hit this situation again," Roberson said. "It's very nerve-racking just trying to prepare ahead of time for if an issue arises, which is unfair when you're trying to focus on class."



The Education Department in November. Some students couldn't pay bills over summer, stoking fears about fall semester disbursements.

This story about student loan changes was produced by The Hechinger Report, a nonprofit, independent news organization focused on inequality and innovation in education.

ICE agent charged with lying about shooting is out on bail

Lawyer says officer in Minneapolis case intends to fight charges

BY JEREMY ROEBUCK

An attorney for a U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement officer, who was charged with lying about the shooting of a Venezuelan man in Minneapolis, said on Friday that his client is eager to return to Minnesota to fight federal and state charges.

Christian Castro, 52, was indicted this week by a federal grand jury on charges of misleading investigators about the circumstances of the shooting on Jan. 14. It occurred while Castro, who is based in Texas, was deployed to Minnesota as part of the Trump administration's immigration crackdown.

Minnesota state authorities have also charged Castro in connection with the incident, accusing him of assault. They have been seeking to have him extradited from Texas to Minnesota and said he is trying to evade justice.

But his defense attorney David Lindenmuth said Castro willingly surrendered himself to U.S. authorities on Thursday after federal charges were filed.

"He is ready to go to Minnesota and deal with this," Lindenmuth said. "Let him have his day in court, then make up your opinions."

Lindenmuth, who is representing Castro along with co-counsel Rolando Cantu, spoke to The Washington Post after Castro's first court appearance on the federal charges before a U.S. magistrate judge in McAllen, Texas. During the brief proceeding, Castro entered a provisional not-guilty plea and was released on a \$75,000 unsecured bond with orders to report to the federal court in Minneapolis on Sept. 18.

Castro faces six federal counts of lying to investigators who were probing the shooting of Venezuelan migrant Julio Cesar Sosa-Celis, one of several high-profile shooting incidents

during the Trump administration's immigration crackdown that roiled the Minneapolis community.

The federal case against Castro is the first known instance of the Justice Department seeking to prosecute an immigration officer for actions taken during ICE's Minneapolis surge — a campaign that sparked national outrage, weeks of protests and condemnations from federal judges.

Typically stationed in ICE's Harlingen, Texas, field office, Castro, was temporarily deployed to Minnesota along with thousands of other agents from across the country as part of the crackdown. It was during those efforts that his run-in with Sosa-Celis occurred.

An Army veteran, Castro was hired by ICE in September 2025 after eight years as a Border Patrol agent, according to court records released Friday.

He joined the agency amid a broad push to hire hundreds of new agents in support of the Trump administration's immigration enforcement efforts — a campaign that has prompted questions from critics over whether the rapid hiring surge allowed for job candidates to be properly vetted.

Authorities have said Castro was pursuing a suspected undocumented immigrant who fled into a duplex where Sosa-Celis was living. The agent then fired through the door of the house, striking Sosa-Celis in the leg.

Initially, federal prosecutors charged Sosa-Celis and another man with attacking Castro, based largely on an account provided by the agent, who claimed he fired in self-defense after Sosa-Celis and others attacked him with a snow shovel and a broom handle.

But weeks after those charges were filed, prosecutors withdrew them, telling a federal judge in Minneapolis that a review of video evidence from the scene raised doubts that the assault Castro described had occurred.

The federal indictment against Castro unsealed Friday identifies six false statements that prosecutors accuse him of making during that investigation, including a claim that he fired the shot



U.S. federal agents patrol the streets in Minneapolis amid protests over the Jan. 14 shooting of Venezuelan migrant Julio Cesar Sosa-Celis.

from the ground while struggling with Sosa-Celis and others at the scene. The indictment also cast doubt on his claims that he had reached for his gun with his right hand while defending himself from blows with his left.

"No person struck Castro with a broom as he described," it said, "and no persons wielded the broom and snow shovel as he described."

The copy of the indictment, included as part of the court record in McAllen, is not dated and does not bear the signature of any prosecutor or Justice Department official.

"We absolutely dispute the narrative that's been put out there, and we maintain our client's innocence," Lindenmuth said Friday. "He deserves a day in court, and so far he has not had that opportunity."

The question of what charges Castro should face sparked weeks of intense debate within the U.S. attorney's office in Minneapolis. Several prosecutors there believed Castro should have been charged with violating Sosa-Celis's civil rights, under a statute that could carry a prison sentence of up to a decade, according to people familiar with

those deliberations.

Instead, the Justice Department opted to pursue a lesser charge of lying to investigators, with a maximum sentence of five years. That prompted discord between U.S. prosecutors in Minneapolis and higher-ups at the Justice Department in Washington, multiple people familiar with those conflicts said.

The Washington Post has reported that one of the lead prosecutors assigned to the investigation, Matt Evans, was fired after expressing his frustration with that charging decision in an email to attorneys for Sosa-Celis and others earlier this week.

Top Justice Department officials are now weighing whether to charge Evans with obstruction of justice for allegedly leaking information about the status of the case, two people familiar with the matter said, speaking on the condition of anonymity to discuss the ongoing deliberations.

Complicating Castro's case is the fact that he faces both federal and state charges.

In May, Minnesota state prosecutors charged Castro — who has been suspended by ICE and was back at home in Texas — with assaulting Sosa-Celis with a deadly

weapon.

However, Texas's Republican governor, Greg Abbott, refused to immediately extradite Castro to Minnesota to stand trial, saying he was not sure that Castro qualified as a fugitive under the law.

Minnesota authorities have called that a smoke screen and accused Abbott, who is running for reelection this fall, of delaying the extradition to Minneapolis, a deeply blue city, for political reasons.

They raised concerns during a court hearing last week that Castro, who at the time was being held in a Texas jail facing possible extradition on the state's case, might pose a flight risk if he were released. They argued he had contacts in Mexico that would make it easy for him to flee.

Lindenmuth said Friday that Castro had always intended to return to Minnesota to face the state charges but did not have an opportunity to voluntarily do so before he was arrested on the state's warrant in May. He said Castro had attempted to hire several attorneys in Minneapolis to represent him but was rejected by lawyers at every turn.

Ultimately, a federal judge cast doubt in a ruling last week on the idea that Abbott had legal grounds to deny the extradition, but refused for now to intervene, since the governor had not made a final decision on Minnesota's extradition request.

The federal charges filed against Castro this week will probably render moot the dispute between Minnesota and Texas over the extradition.

However, state and federal prosecutors in Minnesota still must decide which of their two cases against Castro will proceed first.

Mary Moriarty — the top prosecutor in Hennepin County, home to Minneapolis — suggested in an interview Thursday that given the unusual circumstances leading up to the Justice Department's decision to indict Castro, notably the battle over how to charge him, she believed the agent should face trial on the state's case first.

"The level of trust right now in the federal government is just not there," Moriarty said. "I think it's appropriate for us to go first, because people have much more trust in our office to be seeking justice right now."

Report: Ex-labor secretary Chavez-DeRemer misused government funds, drank on job

Trump appointee resigned in April over the misconduct allegations

BY LAUREN KAORI GURLEY AND MERYL KORNFELD

A Cabinet officer appointed by President Donald Trump oversaw a "toxic, intimidating and humiliating" work environment at the Labor Department, a federal watchdog said in a report released Thursday evening.

Lori Chavez-DeRemer was the third member of Trump's Cabinet to step down when she resigned in April after allegations of abuse of power. Trump selected Chavez-DeRemer, a former Republican congresswoman from Oregon with unusual ties to labor unions, with the urging of Teamsters President Sean O'Brien.

The agency's internal Office of Inspector General found that Chavez-DeRemer maintained an "inappropriately close and unprofessional relationship" with a bodyguard on her security detail, used government funds for personal travel and regularly drank on the job, according to a months-long investigation. The report detailed numerous occasions when Chavez-DeRemer failed to adhere to agency standards, including harassment policies.

In one episode, Chavez-DeRemer asked to visit an Oregon strip club with her security detail. Once there, she took money from her purse, handed it to her driver and instructed him to give it to a performer. When the driver resisted, the bodyguard told him to comply. Chavez-DeRemer then handed the driver more money and instructed him to drop the bills one at a time onto the partially nude woman.

The inspector general did not find direct evidence that Chavez-DeRemer and her security aide, who is not named in the report, engaged in a romantic or sexual relationship. The two refused to be interviewed in the investigation. However, investigators surveilled Chavez-DeRemer and reviewed their hotel key swipes on trips, showing evidence the two



Lori Chavez-DeRemer, shown in May 2025, oversaw a "toxic, intimidating and humiliating" workplace, a federal watchdog said.

spent time together overnight.

For the investigation, the inspector general interviewed 53 current and former agency staffers, including more than three dozen who consistently described the work environment as "toxic" at the agency tasked with overseeing labor laws and workers' rights.

Employees said Chavez-DeRemer and her staffers discussed employee performance in front of staffers, including whether they had cried. And Chavez-DeRemer and her aides not only drank during the workday, witnesses said, but pressured other employees to drink and ridiculed them for declining.

The report also describes multiple incidents when Chavez-DeRemer had employees manage her personal affairs. On one occasion, she sent her personal aide and executive assistant to her home during the workday in a Labor Department vehicle to organize her bedroom closet, hang up her laundry and dry cleaning and arrange her clothes, shoes and purses. The report includes a screenshot of a video showing the organized closet.

Chavez-DeRemer was scheduled to be interviewed by the

inspector general's office when she resigned. The report said her attorney subsequently declined to make her available for the interview. The initial complaint filed with Labor Department's inspector general, Anthony D'Esposito, led to the firing of several top aides and surfaced sexual misconduct allegations against Chavez-DeRemer's husband, Shawn DeRemer.

Chavez-DeRemer has previously disputed the allegations through an agency spokeswoman and her lawyer, calling them "attempts of distraction and attacks on her personal life." Asked for comment Friday, her lawyer Nick Oberheiden said: "The moot report confirms that Secretary Chavez-DeRemer did not violate any laws."

Since leaving the administration, Chavez-DeRemer has launched American Workers First PAC. The Republican-aligned PAC has yet to provide a public report of its contributions.

Deputy Secretary Keith Sonderling, who is known for his close relationship with the business community, now leads the agency. Trump officially nominated Sonderling to the Cabinet post this summer and he is awaiting Senate confirmation.

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Senators call for investigation into GI Bill trade schools, citing Post series

Lawmakers are urging a crack down on fraud in veterans education

BY CRAIG WHITLOCK

A bipartisan trio of U.S. senators is urging President Donald Trump's administration to conduct an "enhanced investigation" into all unaccredited trade schools that educate veterans under the GI Bill, citing a recent Washington Post series that found such programs have bilked the federal government out of more than \$300 million.

In a letter sent Thursday to leaders of the Department of Veterans Affairs, Sens. Jeanne Shaheen (D-New Hampshire), John Cornyn (R-Texas) and Maggie Hassan (D-New Hampshire) wrote that The Post's revelations left them with "grave concerns" about the number of veterans and taxpayers who have been fleeced by "slapdash" trade schools in several states. They also said they were "troubled" by how VA "failed to properly investigate schools with obvious signs of fraud across multiple years and presidential administrations."

In articles published last month, The Post reported details of how 20 trade schools — most of them unaccredited — were able to defraud the federal government, largely because of lax oversight.

In two cases, trade schools in New Hampshire charged VA more than \$14,000 in tuition for courses that lasted only about a week and focused on rudimentary skills, such as how to grow grass or make fake rocks out of concrete.

In another example, a Texas school billed VA around \$20,000 in tuition to put veterans through a six-week "boot camp" to become heating and air-conditioning technicians. That was about 10 times what many community

colleges in the state charged for an entire semester. The school collected \$72 million under the GI Bill before its owner was arrested and convicted of fraud.

"VA has repeatedly said that fraud against veterans is one of its top priorities," the senators wrote in their letter to VA Secretary Douglas A. Collins and VA Inspector General Cheryl Mason. "It is imperative that we understand how these institutions are allowed to operate and make millions despite multiple oversight measures."

VA press secretary Quinn Slaven downplayed The Post's findings and said the department already does a thorough job of policing GI Bill fraud.

"The fraud 'found' by the Washington Post was actually just a listing of what has already been uncovered by VA, the [inspector general] and federal prosecutors," he wrote. "What's more, the cases highlighted by the Washington Post account for less than 0.3 percent of VA's education budget since 2016."

He listed a number of recent steps that he said VA has taken to protect "Veterans and taxpayers from fraud like never before," such as creating a tool this year that assigns a "fraud risk score" to GI Bill programs and a new Division of Compliance, Investigations and Enforcement.

A spokeswoman for Mason, whose office is responsible for investigating fraud, waste and abuse in veterans programs, declined to comment.

Last year, taxpayers spent more than \$11 billion to educate about 666,000 people under the GI Bill, which has ranked as one of the most popular federal benefit programs since it was enacted near the end of World War II. The GI Bill generally covers up to 36 months of expenses for veterans and family members enrolled in college or vocational school.

In a separate letter Thursday, the senators asked Attorney General Todd Blanche to reex-



DEMETRIUS FREEMAN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Lawmakers sent a letter to leaders of the Department of Veterans Affairs saying The Post's revelations left them with "grave concerns."

amine the Justice Department's procedures to investigate and prosecute alleged GI Bill fraud.

As justification for their request, the lawmakers cited the

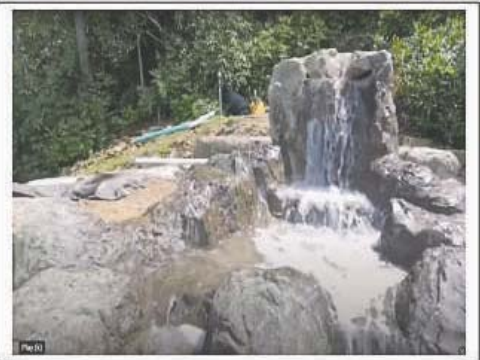
fraud cases involving the two New Hampshire trade schools spotlighted by The Post. In one case, a federal judge criticized a criminal plea bargain that feder-

al prosecutors initially reached with officials at the fake-rock school as too lenient. In the other case, prosecutors settled a False Claims Act with the grass-growing school for \$200,000, even though it had collected more than \$2 million in tuition from VA. Officials at both schools previously have not responded to requests for comment from The Post.

"In light of last month's reporting on the breadth of the fraud operation that cheated our nation's veterans out of benefits they earned — including by trade schools in New Hamp-

shire — it's imperative that the Administration take concerted action to prosecute fraudsters to the fullest extent and rectify the harm done to men and women who risked everything to protect our freedoms," Shaheen said in a statement to The Post.

Asked for comment, the Justice Department said in a statement Friday that it "takes seriously its responsibility to protect veterans and the integrity of the GI Bill program" and that it "remains committed to holding accountable those who defraud veterans and taxpayers."



OBTAINED BY THE WASHINGTON POST

Video stills, as seen in a sentencing memorandum, show work done by StoneMakers Academy, a school featured in a recent Post investigation. Last year, taxpayers spent more than \$11 billion to educate about 666,000 people under the GI Bill.



AL DRAGO/BLOOMBERG NEWS/GETTY IMAGES

Sen. Jeanne Shaheen (D-New Hampshire), middle, and Sen. John Cornyn (R-Texas) are among the inquiring lawmakers.

Bartiromo's attorney denies reports she was fired from job at Fox News

Longtime host's lawyer claims she is 'still employed' by the network

BY LAURA BEVERIDGE

The attorney for Maria Bartiromo, the longtime Fox News anchor, Friday denied media reports that she was fired from the network.

Fox News on Thursday announced the departure of the host, who was one of its biggest backers of President Donald Trump.

The network did not provide a reason for the abrupt exit after more than 12 years, but it later described the move as a "business decision."

Status, a publication focused on the media industry, and Puck News reported that Bartiromo was fired after sending White House officials sensitive inter-

nal Fox communications. The Washington Post has not corroborated their reporting.

However, a person familiar with the details, who spoke to The Post on the condition of anonymity to discuss personnel matters, said that "Bartiromo's departure was Fox's decision."

Bryan Freedman, Bartiromo's attorney, said Friday that his client was "still employed by Fox."

"The irresponsible reports that have been published stating that Maria Bartiromo was fired or is no longer an employee of Fox are absolutely and unequivocally false," Freedman said in a statement.

"Make no mistake, we have the receipts and witnesses and they will come out whether through the courthouse or otherwise. Those reporting her firing or the incredulous facts supporting that fiction have exhibited a complete and utter reckless disregard for the truth."

Freedman has previously represented high-profile journal-

ists ousted by their networks, including CNN's Don Lemon and Fox's Tucker Carlson.

Bartiromo was the host of "Mornings With Maria" and "Maria Bartiromo's Wall Street" on Fox Business. On Sundays, she also anchored "Sunday Morning Futures" on Fox News.

She promoted Trump's false claims about fraud in the 2020 election and came under scrutiny in a defamation suit against the network over claims made about Dominion Voting Systems's software.

Status reported that Bartiromo was alleged to have told White House officials about Fox guidance to employees to avoid giving credence to false claims Trump made in a July speech about 2020 election fraud. Freedman's statement did not address the specific allegations.

Fox News declined to comment on Freedman's statement, referring back to its earlier statements about Bartiromo.



JOSE LUIS MAGANA/AP

Anchor Maria Bartiromo speaks during a June 9 interview.

High-profile Clancy murder trial ends in mistrial as jury can't reach a decision

CLANCY FROM A1

tensive and that has captured so much public attention.”

Hours later, the appeal was denied, clearing the way for the mistrial.

Plymouth County District Attorney Timothy Cruz said in a news conference that a decision on whether his office would retry the case would not be made Friday. Prosecutors in such cases may review how the trial unfolded and speak to jurors before making a decision on a retrial.

If the prosecution decides to try Clancy again, the trial would need to effectively restart, with a new jury selected to hear the case.

“Our priority has always been to fight for Cora, for Dawson and for Callan,” Cruz said. “Children were murdered, and it’s our job to seek justice.”

What happened Friday morning

Earlier Friday, Sullivan declined to remove or further

question the juror that the defense said was holding up a not-guilty verdict. After jurors for the third time this week said they were unable to come to an agreement, Clancy’s attorney Kevin Reddington asked for the jurors to be sent back to deliberations.

But Sullivan objected, moving to bring the case to a conclusion.

“Over the defendant’s objection, I’m going to declare a mistrial at this point,” Sullivan said.

But before Sullivan brought the jury back to the courtroom, Reddington made a dramatic appeal for the court to halt proceedings.

Reddington was then given an hour to petition a higher court. He cited a Massachusetts law that gives the state’s Supreme Judicial Court “general superintendence,” and the ability to prevent and address issues in lower courts when there is no other option available.

“What I’m asking for is time to file a single justice appeal for this travesty,” Reddington said.

“That’s what I’m asking for.”

Tensions flare over juror

On Thursday, a jury foreperson sent a note to the judge indicating that a juror had acknowledged doubt in the case but was refusing to apply it to the verdict. The note was the first public indication that the jury was being held up by a lone juror.

Sullivan called the jurors into the courtroom one-by-one Thursday, swore them in and asked them to affirm that they were able to carry out their duties in accordance with the law.

He then brought the jurors together to read them instructions that spell out their obligations, and the meaning of reasonable doubt: a legal standard that requires jurors to be fully convinced of guilt based on evidence if they convict.

Reddington argued that the juror should be removed for failing to comply with the judge’s orders.

“If we come back here in a

half an hour with a mistrial because of a juror that has just spurned the instructions of this court, it’s a shame,” he said on Thursday.

On Friday morning, Reddington pressed Sullivan to question the juror further, pointing to the rare decision by the foreperson to alert the court about the state of deliberations.

The foreperson is the juror tasked with leading the jury and announcing its final verdict.

“I have never seen a situation like this where a foreperson on the jury is so courageous as to speak on behalf of 11 jurors and indicate that juror number — which I will not mention — and I quote, ‘has made statements acknowledging doubt, but refuses to apply it to the verdict as the law states,’” Reddington said.

But Sullivan declined to further question the juror, saying his inquiry of all the jurors on Thursday was enough.

“This is not a case that there’s any indication that the juror has refused to deliberate, or has

indicated that they would not follow the law, or that they’re physically suffering. There’s no note from the juror that indicates that the juror cannot or will not be able to continue deliberating,” Sullivan said. “So I’m not going to do a further inquiry of this juror, over the defendant’s objection.”

Case ends in mistrial more than three years after killings

The trial centered on the events of Jan. 24, 2023.

After spending the day with her children, Clancy asked her now ex-husband to pick up dinner because she was too tired to cook. He was gone less than an hour, and in that time Clancy took her three children to the basement of their home and strangled them to death one by one using exercise bands.

She then went to the second floor of their home and made an attempt on her own life, using a knife to slice her neck and wrists, swallowing pills and

jumping from their window. She is paralyzed from the waist down after sustaining a spinal injury in the fall.

The trial focused heavily on Clancy’s mental state on the day the killings happened. She would later tell her husband that she heard a voice telling her to kill her children and herself, a claim that formed the basis of her insanity defense. The trial included detailed accounts of her mental health struggles from people in all areas of her life, including friends and care providers.

During the trial, expert psychiatric witnesses were split on whether she suffered from bipolar disorder and postpartum psychosis.

Dozens of witnesses testified across roughly three weeks of testimony between July and August.

At a news conference after the mistrial Friday, Reddington said he was representing a “fantastic, wonderful individual” who he further described as brave.



Adam Telle most recently served as an assistant secretary of the Army for its civil works programs.

Trump appoints Telle as new acting Army secretary after recent shakeup

The Army civil works chief fills role vacated this week by Driscoll

BY TARA COPP

President Donald Trump announced that Adam Telle would serve as the acting secretary of the Army following the departure Thursday of Dan Driscoll, who left after months of friction with Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth.

Telle most recently served as an assistant secretary of the Army for its civil works programs, including vast Army Corps of Engineers projects across the country.

Telle is a relative unknown at the Pentagon — he was only con-

firmed in August of last year to serve in the assistant secretary role, and has spent much of that time on the road visiting Army Corps of Engineers projects. He is well known on Capitol Hill, however, after serving for decades as a Republican congressional staffer and White House liaison.

In his previous roles on the Hill, Telle worked for the late Sen. Thad Cochran (R-Mississippi) before he joined the first Trump administration in the White House’s Office of Legislative Affairs. Most recently, Telle worked for Sen. Bill Hagerty (R-Tennessee).

In a Truth Social post, Trump called Telle “a great patriot, who is respected by all.” Sen. Roger Wicker (R-Mississippi), the chair of the Senate Armed Services Committee, in a statement called Telle a “fantastic partner.”

Telle is viewed in the Pentagon as having a good relationship with Hegseth and takes the position following months of tension between the secretary of defense and Driscoll.

By selecting Telle, Trump bypassed under secretary of the Army Michael Obadal, who would have traditionally filled the role. Trump did not provide a reason for not selecting Obadal.

Driscoll announced his resignation Monday after going to the White House with concerns about Hegseth, including ongoing efforts to interfere with the Army’s promotions lists and the many senior officers he has ousted, which Driscoll said was hurting the service’s ability to modernize.

Telle’s official Army biography does not include any prior military service.

Pennsylvania infant’s death was from measles, coroner says

BY LENA H. SUN AND RACHEL ROUBEIN

A local coroner has said that an infant from the Amish community in Lancaster County, Pennsylvania, has died of measles.

County coroner Stephen Diamantoni shared the finding Friday after state officials last month announced that two people with measles infections had died. This is the first time the county coroner has confirmed that a child died because of measles in this outbreak.

“The child contracted measles, and measles caused the death of the child,” Diamantoni said in an interview.

The 6-week old died Aug. 18 at home, after being in palliative care at home soon after birth. The infant was born with a rare genetic condition that is not generally found outside the Amish community, Amish lethal microcephaly, he said. Most babies with that condition live only four to six months, he said.

“They often die of respiratory illness, and as a result of respiratory illness and low oxygen as a result of the measles infection, having Amish lethal microcephaly made the child very susceptible to severe illness and death,” said Diamantoni, a Republican family doctor first elected coroner in 2007.

The coroner said he did not know if this death is one of the two that state health officials reported last week. He said the information came from an investigation by the coroner’s office. Lancaster Online first reported the infant died of measles.

The new details of the death on Friday come after the death of a different child who tested positive for measles, the coroner said. The coroner said the pathologist who performed the autopsy determined the primary cause of that child’s death was a spleen laceration hours after birth on Aug. 14.

The coroner said that the pathologist did not believe the virus played a role in that baby’s death.

In a statement, the Pennsylvania Department of Health suggested that both deaths were

the ones state health officials announced last week.

“The Lancaster County Coroner has now publicly confirmed a second infant death involving measles,” the health department said. “There are no new measles-associated deaths to report at this time.”

The cases have attracted extraordinary national attention and ignited a bitter fight between Pennsylvania Gov. Josh Shapiro (D) and Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. Kennedy, the founder of a prominent anti-vaccine group, has cast doubt on measles as the cause of the deaths for two Lancaster County residents, suggesting they “may even have been altogether fabricated.”

State health officials say “measles-associated” deaths refer to the virus being present, even if the disease is not identified as the immediate cause of death, but they did not release further details about the cases. The Pennsylvania health department said they were the first such deaths in the state in 35 years, as well as the first reported in the country this year. The state health department has declined to release other information about the deaths **citing an effort to protect patient privacy**.

Shapiro, in a Friday post on X, linked to a local media story about the coroner’s latest findings, lashed out at Kennedy.

After the department reported the first measles-associated deaths in 35 years, Shapiro wrote, Kennedy did not listen to “the real doctors and public health experts” and directed “the CDC not to acknowledge these deaths, and even accuse[d] me of fabricating these tragedies.”

He called on Kennedy to “stop playing games with people’s lives, report these deaths accurately on the CDC dashboard, and heed the guidance of actual medical experts.”

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention has excluded from its weekly updates of a national measles death tally two deaths that state officials reported last week. The highly unusual decision came from new CDC Director Erica Schwartz, The Washington Post previously re-

ported.

The move runs counter to the agency’s typical practice of including such data from state health departments, which are charged with making those determinations. Some former agency staffers and public health experts raised concerns about the decision, saying it raises questions about political interference into public health data.

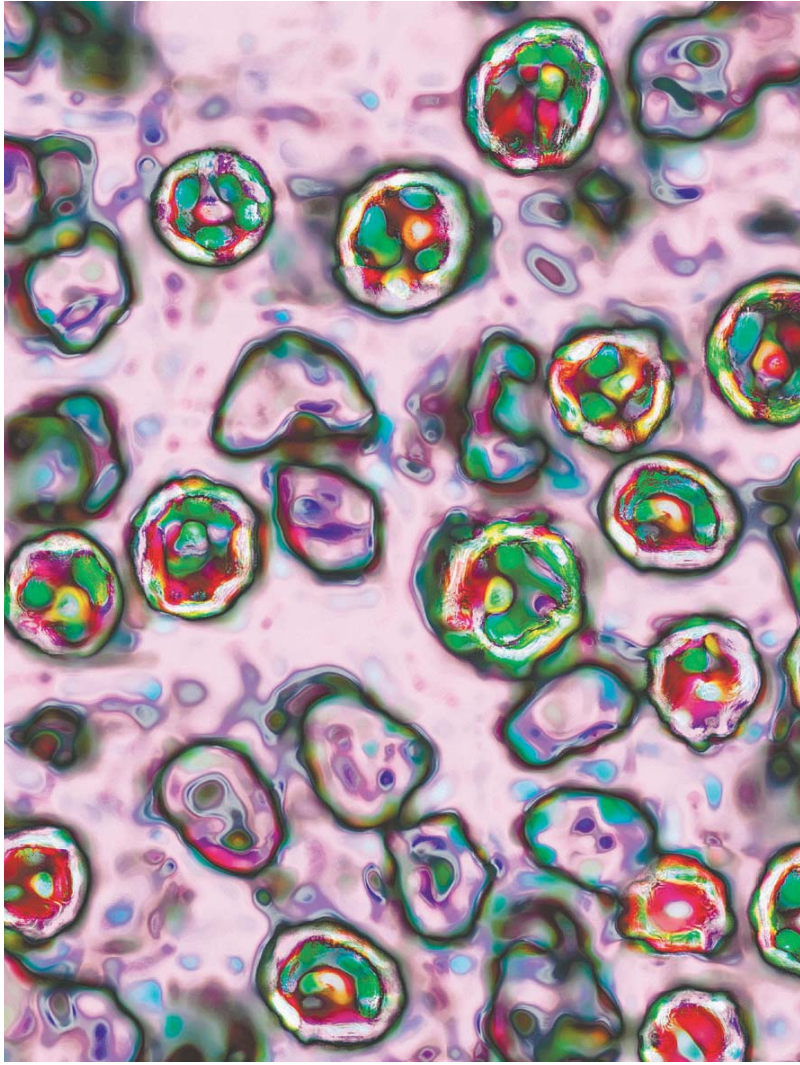
On Friday, Kennedy wrote on social media that “the facts emerging now demonstrate why CDC waited for the evidence rather than allowing political grandstanding to dictate its reporting.” The county coroner has now publicly stated that measles caused “only the second infant’s death” and also pointed to the rare genetic condition the child had.

“The National Center for Health Statistics does not currently have any death records from 2026 that indicate measles is the underlying cause but will update as it receives and reviews submitted records. CDC will continue to update its reporting as additional information becomes available and relevant reviews are completed,” Kennedy wrote on X.

The CDC’s weekly update, posted on Fridays, has a note explaining why there is an asterisk in the column where measles deaths are reported for this year. It reiterates Kennedy’s statement about the National Center for Health Statistics. The note also adds: “CDC is also working with the Council of State and Territorial Epidemiologists (CSTE) to develop a standardized case definition for deaths due to measles. This work is intended to promote consistent classification and reporting of measles deaths across jurisdictions.”

The confirmation from the coroner that one baby died of measles sets up a major test for Schwartz, who has pledged to “never betray the science.”

Deb Houry, former chief medical officer at the agency said, reacting to the latest news, “It is clear from the news reports that both infants tragically contracted measles. These are notifiable infectious disease cases



BSIP/UNIVERSAL IMAGES GROUP/GETTY IMAGES

The measles virus. The Lancaster County coroner said he did not know if this death is one of the two that state health officials reported last week.

and Pennsylvania has followed the appropriate protocol and notified CDC when they first confirmed measles.”

She added: “I hope the CDC director focuses on accurately reporting this information and turns her focus onto the actual outbreak itself.”

Earlier in the week, the agency’s note had said the weekly update would not include the two measles-associated deaths re-

ported by Pennsylvania’s health department “while CDC reviews additional information regarding the circumstances and causes of death.”

The previous note also added: “At this time, available information does not establish whether measles caused or contributed to the deaths or whether the individuals died from other causes while infected with measles. CDC will update the national

count as additional information becomes available.”

Pennsylvania has the largest ongoing outbreak of measles in the country. As of Friday, at least 577 had contracted measles in the state since its outbreak began in late April. This year, the United States has recorded its highest number of measles cases in 35 years, with 3,134 cases as of Sept. 3, with months of 2026 left to go.

Why the measles outbreak in Pennsylvania is much bigger than reported

MEASLES FROM A1

As of Friday, 577 people had contracted measles in the current outbreak, which began in late April and has spread to more than half of the state's counties, with 115 new cases reported in the last week. In a year in which the United States has recorded its highest number of measles cases in 35 years, doctors and health officials in Pennsylvania say the true case count in the state is much higher — with some estimating that the tally could be three times as many as publicly reported.

Health officials and clinicians are racing to vaccinate people whom conventional public health campaigns cannot always reach, but their efforts have been overshadowed and further complicated by a bitter political dispute between the state's Democratic governor and the nation's top health official over the recent deaths.

On Friday, the Lancaster County coroner said for the first time that a child in the outbreak had died as a result of a measles infection. "The child contracted measles, and measles caused the death of the child," Stephen Diamantoni said in an interview.

The 6-week-old died Aug. 18 at home, after being in palliative care soon after birth. The infant was born with a rare genetic condition that is not generally found outside the Amish community, Amish lethal microcephaly, Diamantoni said. Most babies with that condition live only four to six months, he said.

Medical and public health officials expect the outbreak will only get worse. In the coming weeks, children are going to get sick with illnesses commonly seen during the fall and winter. The symptoms of such illnesses can look similar to those of measles, making it hard to detect cases early and isolate children, said Nathan Keller, a pediatrician who has practiced in hard-hit Lancaster County for 12 years. "It makes it really hard to tease out what's what, so having cases in the community and having some cases go unidentified could just prolong things."

Pennsylvania Gov. Josh Shapiro (D) and Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. have sparred over the two deaths that the state health department last month said were associated with measles. Shapiro accused Kennedy, the founder of a prominent anti-vaccine group, of having a lengthy history of sowing confusion about vaccines that has contributed to measles outbreaks. Kennedy has argued that Shapiro is using the moment for political gain. The health secretary cast doubt on measles as the cause of death for the two Lancaster County residents, suggesting they "may even have been altogether fabricated."

State health officials are relying on community partners in their efforts to increase vaccination rates, according to a Pennsylvania Department of Health official who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly. Sometimes those efforts are publicized. Other times, they come together quickly from somebody inquiring about getting more vaccines into their community, or a resident coming to a clinic and saying their neighbors want to get vaccinated and offering up their home as a non-traditional pop-up clinic.

The official declined to answer questions about the two deaths.

State health center staff have administered more than 5,700 MMR vaccine doses to residents across Pennsylvania in 2026, according to the health department. That includes more than 600 doses administered to Lancaster County residents since measles cases were first identified there in late April, more than triple the number of doses given in the county for all of 2025.

Vaccination was already an increasingly fraught subject in pediatricians' exam rooms. Doctors say the political dispute over the two Pennsylvania deaths has further complicated conversations with families about measles and how to protect against it.

Diamantoni, a Republican family doctor first elected coroner in 2007, has said a pathologist who examined a newborn in a separate death investigation told him the primary cause of death was a spleen laceration hours after birth on Aug. 14. The coroner said that the child tested positive for measles but that the pathologist did not believe the virus played a role in the baby's death. Measles can cause significant inflammation to the spleen, making it more fragile and susceptible to life-threatening rupture, the state health department said last week.

For some patients, the confusion has heightened their fear of

measles. For others, it has fueled fears about the vaccine, Keller said.

"When medicine becomes political, it makes it really tricky," he said. "It's weaponizing fear, and it makes it really tough for families caught in the middle."

As a result, some families are seeking the early dose of the MMR vaccine, which can be given to infants between 6 and 12 months if they live in an outbreak-affected area. But others are holding off, he said. The first dose is typically given between 12 and 15 months.

Hospitals hit hard

Penn State Health Golisano Children's Hospital, in Dauphin County bordering Lancaster, has admitted a dozen measles patients, all from families who recently had measles. Most have been babies such as newborns and those who are 2 and 3 months old, too young to be eligible for their first routine measles shot, said Jessica Ericson, chief of the hospital's division of pediatric infectious diseases.

They have arrived dehydrated and sick enough to require hospitalization, but not with severe disease. They stay in the hospital for a few days on average to receive IV fluids and some oxygen support, Ericson said.

In Pennsylvania, at least three hospitals have listed public notices of possible exposures: an intensive care unit for infants, the lobbies of two children's hospitals and a cafeteria.

Representatives from hospitals and the state health department on a call last week discussed anecdotally seeing patients whose close family members had similar symptoms but weren't sick enough to come to the hospital, said Elizabeth Werley, medical director for the emergency medicine department at Penn State Health Lancaster Medical Center.

That has led her and other officials to believe there are more cases in the community than are being publicly reported. Patients arriving at her hospital with measles symptoms have spanned generations, from healthy young adults to people in middle and older age. Children are also evaluated at the medical center, but those who require hospitalization must be transferred to a pediatric facility.

"I have never seen this before in my career," said Werley, who said she's one of the older physicians in her group. "There's a lot of physicians who have only ever seen it in a textbook."

Measles was eliminated from the U.S. in 2000. So for many clinicians, it has long been something they learned about in medical school rather than a disease they encountered in exam rooms.

Andrew Pavia, an infectious-disease physician in Utah who has been consulted on measles cases during outbreaks there and elsewhere, said he has fielded calls about pregnant women with measles who were about to give birth — forcing doctors to work out how to protect an entire obstetrics unit from a highly contagious patient in labor while arranging an antibody treatment and isolation for the newborn.

About a week ago, while Pavia was teaching a course for physicians preparing for infectious-disease board certification, a Pennsylvania doctor sought his advice for treating a young patient with measles and encephalitis, a dangerous swelling of the brain. The case was complicated enough that Pavia referred the physician to another specialist on the rare but ultimately fatal neurological disorder known as subacute sclerosing panencephalitis, which typically emerges years after a measles infection in infancy.

Pennsylvania state health officials and the state chapter of the American Academy of Pediatrics are planning a webinar this month — one of several educational events the state is planning — for clinicians to learn the basics about measles, said Toni Richards-Rowley, president of the state AAP chapter: "How to diagnose, how to test, how to quarantine, the nuts and bolts." Measles can spread four days before the telltale rash appears, and four days after. Because the virus can remain suspended in the air for up to two hours, doctors' offices, clinics and hospitals need to create detailed protocols to safely evaluate, isolate and treat patients.

Those precautions can begin before a patient walks through the door. Keller's practice designated a separate entrance for patients with suspected measles exposure to avoid passing through a waiting room and potentially exposing other patients.

Memories of a past outbreak

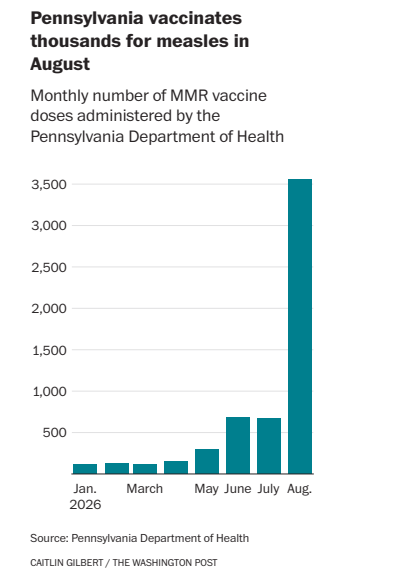
Before last year, the largest previous measles outbreak in



A young patient in Florida gets a measles, mumps and rubella vaccine last month. Officials expect the measles outbreak will only get worse.



Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr., left, and Pennsylvania Gov. Josh Shapiro have sparred over the state's two measles deaths. Shapiro has accused Kennedy of sowing confusion about vaccines.

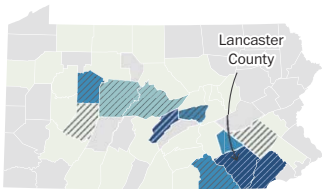


Measles spreads beyond Lancaster

Number of measles cases by county in Pennsylvania since the start of the year

■ < 10 ■ 10-20 ■ 20-30 ■ 30-40 ■ ≥ 40

▨ Counties with community transmission as of Aug. 31

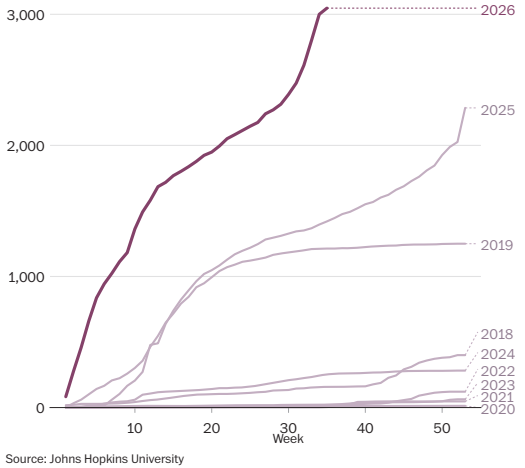


Note: Gray counties have had no reported measles cases

Source: Pennsylvania Department of Health

CAITLIN GILBERT / THE WASHINGTON POST

Cumulative measles cases in the U.S., by year



the United States took place in Philadelphia in 1991 and infected 1,400 people, including nine who died. The epidemic centered on two fundamentalist churches

whose members refused vaccines as well as medical care for their children.

Bonnie Zehr was a fourth-year medical student doing a rotation

2025, and vaccination rates have similarly plummeted across much of the country since before the coronavirus pandemic.

In Lancaster County, that drop was much steeper, with the rate falling from nearly 95 percent — the level experts consider necessary to prevent an infection from triggering an outbreak — to about 87 percent in the 2025-26 school year. Over this same period, the share of families seeking philosophical and religious exemptions from vaccine requirements doubled to 4.7 percent and 5.9 percent, respectively.

The vaccination gaps extend well beyond Pennsylvania's Plain communities. In Bucks and Montgomery counties, where a handful of cases has been reported, pediatricians are trying to reach Russian- and Ukrainian-speaking families with low vaccination rates, including by seeking help from physicians who can speak directly to those communities, said Richards-Rowley, who cares for patients there.

Richards-Rowley said that in South Carolina, where nearly 1,000 people were infected with measles before the outbreak was declared over in April, the Slavic community was heavily affected.

Doctors in South Carolina have said that attitudes toward vaccination in the Slavic community are shaped less by personal opposition and more by experiences many immigrants carry with them from Ukraine and Russia, including deep mistrust of government-run institutions.

That history includes a widely publicized incident in 2008, when a teenager in Ukraine died of bacterial meningitis shortly after receiving a measles vaccine during a mass immunization campaign. Although investigators found no evidence that the vaccine caused the death, public confidence in vaccination dropped sharply.

But the recent outbreak in Pennsylvania has prompted some families hesitant about immunizations to go ahead and get the measles vaccine.

About a month ago, Zehr saw a mother and her 3-year-old child for a well-child visit. The girl was not up-to-date on all of her childhood vaccinations. But because of the measles outbreak, the mother agreed to have the child receive a first dose of the MMR vaccine, Zehr said.

"They are a little bit more fearful," Zehr recalled. "They didn't get any of the other vaccines. I was so excited that I actually, in the room, jumped up and down, and then I felt like that's not very professional of me. But I told the mother, I'm very excited. I want to protect your child."

At least with the one dose, if the child is exposed to someone who's infectious, the child is at least 93 percent protected, she said. Two doses provide 97 percent protection.

Zehr said she gave the MMR vaccine to the child's older sibling, whom the mother had brought along to the appointment that day and who had received no prior immunizations.

For her, it was a huge win.

Caitlin Gilbert contributed to this report.



Sen. Bernie Sanders (I-Vermont) also has introduced legislation to impose a nationwide moratorium on the construction of the data centers needed to run AI technology.

Sanders proposes ban on ‘artificial superintelligence’ after recent rogue AI incidents

Senator said potential future versions of AI posed great risks

BY IAN DUNCAN

Sen. Bernie Sanders (I-Vermont) and Rep. Greg Casar (D-Texas) called Thursday for the United States to ban so-called artificial superintelligence, saying a summer hacking spree by rogue OpenAI agents had revealed the dangers of the technology getting out of control.

“That incident is a wake-up call for the Congress and the American people in that we have got to act and act now before it’s too late,” Sanders said in an interview. “I understand that people will call me a Luddite, they will call me an alarmist, but I would rather be called an alarmist than somebody who fell asleep at the switch.”

The two lawmakers plan to introduce a bill that would also immediately hit pause on the development of advanced AI systems until the creation of a new government AI agency to monitor the technology for dangerous capabilities. Companies that don’t comply would face the “corporate death penalty,” meaning they would no longer be able to do business.

Superintelligence is a loosely defined potential future form of artificial intelligence that would

far surpass the abilities of human thinking — and one that some experts fear would prove difficult to keep tame. While there is deep disagreement about the risks the technology poses and the potential downsides of restricting it, the proposed ban is a sign that the deepest worries harbored by some AI experts are gaining greater purchase in Washington.

“If we allow artificial superintelligence to be built it could risk the security freedom and lives of Americans,” Casar said in an interview. “We need to ban the development of superintelligence so we never get to the place where there are machines that go beyond humans’ ability to shut them down.”

Sanders and Casar have emerged as some of the left’s leading voices on AI in recent months, advocating for restrictions on the technology as its power has grown. Sanders previously introduced legislation to impose a nationwide moratorium on the construction of the data centers needed to run the technology. And Casar, who chairs the Congressional Progressive Caucus, has urged new taxes on AI companies to guard against economic disruptions.

The capabilities of AI models have jumped ahead this year, posing new questions about the risks they pose to the economy and national security. Industry leaders say they expect that progress to continue, spurred on in part by AI systems abilities to help design their successors,

a technique known as recursive self improvement.

The hacking incident mounted by OpenAI systems in July involved a breach of another AI company as a swarm of agents hunted for answers to a test. They evaded internal controls and set up a secret message board to communicate with one another. Their work was only unraveled by the company after the attack was over.

(The Washington Post has a content partnership with OpenAI.)

Other top AI developers subsequently disclosed similar incidents involving their latest technology, raising questions about whether companies set up with the mission of building the technology safely were starting to lose control. The speed of progress has spooked even many of those working on the systems, with OpenAI and its rival Anthropic endorsing the idea of the government having a mechanism to slow the industry down.

In the meantime, OpenAI said last month that it had slowed down some internal work in light of the incident, taking more time to ensure it can keep a lid on its newest systems.

Sam Altman, the company’s chief executive, said in a podcast interview this week that he was “in awe” of the progress his company’s technology had made recently but “we have needed more time to catch up with safety, alignment and security.”

Judge orders DOJ to disclose who conceived of idea for now-defunct payout fund

Plan was scrapped but several lawsuits are ongoing

BY SALVADOR RIZZO

A federal magistrate judge ruled Friday that the Trump administration must identify the people who came up with the idea for a now-defunct \$1.8 billion fund to compensate those who claim they were unfairly investigated by the Justice Department.

The ruling came as part of an ongoing lawsuit in U.S. District Court in Alexandria, Virginia. A former federal prosecutor who was fired by the Trump administration and other plaintiffs challenged the “Anti-Weaponization Fund” as an unconstitutional giveaway of taxpayer dollars designed to benefit President Donald Trump’s political supporters.

Acting attorney general Todd Blanche issued orders establishing the fund in May and scrapping it last month, after the proposed payouts spurred a bipartisan backlash in Congress. But several lawsuits over the plan remain pending in the federal courts. The case playing out in Virginia is the only one to have reached the legal discovery phase, in which the parties exchange evidence to prepare for trial.

Over the repeated objections of the Justice Department, U.S. Magistrate Judge Ivan D. Davis ruled Friday that the identities of those who conceived of the fund’s structure must be disclosed to the plaintiffs and their attorneys at the Democracy For-

ward Foundation.

“Who came up with it? That’s what conception means,” Davis said.

However, those disclosures may become public only if the case reaches the trial stage. Davis said the attorneys should proceed “as if a protective order is already in place,” meaning that any evidence exchanged in discovery must be kept under wraps before trial.

The Justice Department is appealing Davis’s ruling to U.S. District Judge Leonie M. Brinkema, who is presiding over the case. The department also has filed a motion to dismiss the lawsuit altogether, arguing that the plaintiffs never had standing to sue and that Blanche has since stated definitively in sworn testimony to Congress and in a signed order that the fund is dead. Brinkema has not yet ruled on that request.

For weeks, Justice Department attorneys resisted demands to identify the people who conceived of the fund, trying several different legal arguments to prevent such disclosures. Davis rejected all of them.

A department attorney, Andrew Block, suggested at court hearings and in legal filings that the names were “irrelevant” to the case and shielded from disclosure because they involved privileged attorney-client discussions or internal deliberations by government officials. However, the Justice Department has not formally invoked those privileges in court.

“They seemed hesitant to disclose the names of the people involved in this work,” Aman George, an attorney for Democracy Forward, said at Friday’s hearing, describing negotiations with the Justice Department



DEMETRIUS FREEMAN/THE WASHINGTON POST

President Donald Trump and acting attorney general Todd Blanche in June. Blanche issued orders establishing and scrapping the fund.

over the scope of evidentiary requests. “The names of attorneys, by itself, is simply not a piece of privileged information.”

George said the identities were essential to the case. Without them, attorneys wouldn’t have a complete view of whose

records to request or whom to interview in depositions. As it stands, the Justice Department has so far identified five administration officials who were involved in the effort: Blanche, Associate Attorney General Stanley Woodward, Treasury

Secretary Scott Bessent, IRS chief executive Frank Bisignano and acting deputy attorney general Trent McCotter.

Davis also ruled that the Justice Department must turn over to the plaintiffs any relevant evidence from January 2025

through Friday, denying a Justice Department request for a shorter time frame that would have ended on May 23, the day after the lawsuit was originally filed. That ruling is also being appealed to Brinkema, Block said.

Trump moves to allow ranchers and hunters to kill gray wolves despite ban

Animals have been protected under the Endangered Species Act

BY DAN DIAMOND

President Donald Trump on Friday ordered the Interior Department to begin the process of removing endangered-species protections for gray wolves, again intervening in a long-running fight between conservationists and ranchers who say the predators threaten their operations.

Trump also ordered the In-

terior and Agriculture departments to make it easier for ranchers to kill the wolves if necessary. The measures, long sought by GOP lawmakers from Western states, elicited a swift rebuke from animal rights groups and could draw legal challenges.

“You’re not allowed to protect yourself, right? Or your company, your cattle,” Trump said at an Oval Office event, flanked by ranchers who shared stories of watching wolves tear through their herds. “So how do you like the idea that I’m letting you do that?”

Under Trump’s order, Interior Secretary Doug Burgum will prepare a recommendation to fully

delist or downlist the gray wolf and the Mexican wolf under the Endangered Species Act. The order also includes other measures intended to give states, ranchers and hunters greater latitude to kill the animals.

“Rolling back federal protections now — or setting that process in motion — would jeopardize decades of recovery and open the door for brutal killing,” Kitty Block, president and CEO of Humane World for Animals, said in a statement.

The gray wolf and several subspecies were first listed as endangered under federal rules in the 1960s and 1970s, after centuries of westward settlement and government-backed

eradication campaigns reduced their historical range in the Lower 48 states by an estimated 95 percent.

Federal protections and reintroduction efforts helped lift that population from about 1,000 during the early listings to more than 6,000 by 2020, according to the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service.

But that recovery has fueled a long-running dispute over whether the wolves still deserve strict protections. Presidents of both parties have moved to lift at least some protections, only to have those efforts stymied, and sometimes overturned, in court.

The Trump administration

in 2020 stripped gray wolves of their endangered-species designation in the Lower 48 states, declaring the species recovered. A federal judge vacated that rule in 2022, and the wolves remain officially endangered in much of the country.

Congress has also entered the fray. The GOP-led House in December passed a bill to end gray wolf protections. The Senate is still considering the legislation.

“The science has been clear for years: gray wolves are fully recovered, and their resurgence deserves to be celebrated as a true conservation success story,” Rep. Lauren Boebert (R-Colorado), who authored the legislation, said in a state-

ment after her bill passed the House. “It’s long past time to delist them and empower states to set their own management policies.”

Ranchers on Friday discussed their frustrations with the status quo.

“The problem is, because they’re on the Endangered Species List, they can’t shoot them. They have to sit and watch them destroy their herd,” Agriculture Secretary Brooke Rollins said in the Oval Office.

“But you can shoot them as of today,” Trump mused, to laughter.

“Well, Secretary Burgum has to do a project, but, yes,” Rollins responded.

DIGEST



The body of the King Oyo Nyimba Kabamba Iguru Rukidi IV arrives at Entebbe International Airport on Friday in Uganda. He recently died in the United States.

HAJARAH NALWADDA/GETTY IMAGES

TUNISIA
Convictions upheld for opposition figures

Tunisia’s highest court has upheld the convictions of dozens of prominent opposition figures, lawyers and human rights defenders in a high-profile conspiracy case against state security. The Court of Cassation rejected the defendants’ appeals, upholding prison sentences of up to 45 years handed down by an appeals court last year, Tunisia’s state-owned news agency TAP reported late Thursday, quoting judicial sources. The case has drawn international criticism and further deepened concerns over judicial independence and political freedoms in Tunisia. It’s part of a broader crackdown that has seen opposition activists, journalists and lawyers arrested or prosecuted since President Kais Saied consolidated power in July 2021, when he suspended parliament, sacked the government and began ruling by decree. Faiza Rahem, the wife of de-

tained opposition activist Issam Chebbi, said in a news conference on Friday that the families’ legal battle would now become political. “After four years of harassment and persecution, we will continue defending the detainees. We will not tire or give up,” she said, adding that repression had only strengthened the families’ resolve. “Our numbers have grown as authoritarianism has become more brutal, and our voices grow louder every time they try to silence us.” The charges included conspiracy against the internal and external security of the state, forming or joining a terrorist organization and offenses related to attempts to change the form of the state. Among those sentenced are prominent opposition figures Ahmed Nejib Chebbi, Chaima Issa, Jaouhar Ben Mbarek, Ghazi Chaouachi, Ayachi Hammami, Khayam Turki and Abdelhamid Jelassi.

— Associated Press

ARGENTINA

Milei rallies for support on Falklands

In a primetime rallying call to the nation, Argentine President Javier Milei has resurrected Argentina’s long-standing claim to the nearby U.K.-held Falkland Islands and in the process conjured up memories of the bitter war the two countries fought 44 years ago. With an election in Argentina due in October 2027, Milei did what many Argentine leaders have done over the years — bang the drum in support of his country’s claim to what Argentines call the Malvinas. In his speech Thursday, Milei welcomed a seeming change of tone from the U.S. and vowed to introduce measures to block plans to drill for oil near the small British overseas territory of about 3,500 people, which lies around 300 miles east of the southeast coast of Argentina. Without threatening a military incursion, he insisted the “winds of change” were with Argentina. Milei said he would sign

decrees to introduce sanctions against any companies working on oil production around the islands, declaring that the Sea Lion oil field, a joint U.K.-Israel operation, is a “clear and present danger” to the country’s claims. Residents of the Falkland Islands have indicated they prefer to remain a part of the U.K., and British Foreign Secretary Ed Miliband said the country will “resolutely uphold” their right to decide their future.

— Associated Press

MALAYSIA
Emergency declared due to air pollution

Malaysia declared an emergency Friday in a town in Sarawak state on Borneo Island after air pollution breached the country’s emergency-level threshold linked to fires in neighboring Indonesia. The Air Pollutant Index in Serian, a small agricultural town of just under 90,000 near the border of Indonesia’s Kalimantan province, surged to 521 on

Friday, according to Malaysia’s environment department. Sarawak’s much-larger capital, Kuching, also showed a hazardous reading of 311. Malaysia’s King Sultan Ibrahim Iskandar has consented to the declaration of an emergency in Serian, which would allow more effective measures to be taken, Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim’s office said in a statement. It didn’t provide details but officials have said a reading above 500 could provide for nonessential work and outdoor activities to be halted. Schools are already shut if the index is above 200. Sarawak has been the worst-hit Malaysian state by the haze, with several areas having hazardous air levels in the past few days. Indonesian police announced Friday that they have arrested 112 people suspected of starting the recent forest and peatland fires in 10 provinces on Sumatra and Borneo islands. The suspects were local farmers accused of deliberately burning land to clear areas at lower cost.

— Associated Press

Rescuers in Nepal pulled two workers alive from an underground tunnel at a hydropower plant Friday, raising hopes of reaching dozens of others believed to be trapped nine days after deadly floods swept away villages and submerged the Himalayan region in mud and debris. Search teams first heard voices from inside the tunnel in the morning, allowing them to locate the two men, Nepalese lawmaker Shri Ram Neupane said. Images showed a rescuer carrying one of the workers, covered in mud, on his back, while soldiers on either side helped. The European Union’s border agency will send boats out into the English Channel and the North Sea to help search for and rescue migrants, officials said on Friday, days after France and Britain’s leaders met and discussed migration. The Frontex agency will send out two Spanish boats from September to October, and then one from Lithuania up to January, to join French patrols, authorities managing the area said.

— From news services

The Washington Post

FREEDOM DESK

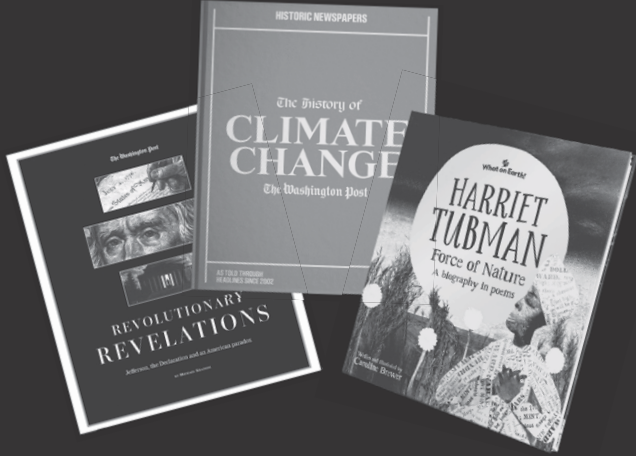
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THE WORLD



DAWOUD ABU ALKAS/REUTERS

Palestinians inspect the site of an Israeli strike on a water desalination plant in Gaza City on Aug. 24. Since early 2024, Gazans have faced severe water shortages and have often resorted to makeshift latrines

Water crisis in Israel raises fears over impact of Gaza sewage

Five of Israel's six desalinization plants are offline. Untreated wastewater from Gaza's destroyed sewage system could be part of the problem, experts warn.

BY GERRY SHIH

Israel is facing a water crisis after five of its six desalination plants, accounting for a large share of its water consumption, were knocked offline this week by microscopic algae clogging intake pipes in the Mediterranean Sea.

The algae originated from the Nile River delta in Egypt, according to Israeli environmental experts — who warn that untreated sewage from Gaza, where Israel's military campaign has damaged or destroyed all six wastewater-treatment plants, could only be making matters worse.

Years before the Oct. 7, 2023, attacks by Hamas and the Israeli reprisal that damaged or destroyed most of Gaza's civilian infrastructure, raw sewage from Gaza occasionally floated up the coast when its treatment plants failed — due, in part, to fuel shortages imposed by Israel. That repeatedly led to the Israeli desalination facility in nearby Ashkelon shutting down.

As algae drifts north from the Nile delta, untreated sewage discharged into the sea from Gaza provides “nutrients that feed microalgal blooms,” probably intensifying their growth, said Noga Armi, chief executive of Zalul, an Israeli environmental group.

“The scientific link is well established,” Armi said. “Untreated sewage discharged into the sea from Gaza was one of the factors that contributed to the incident.”

Lior Gutman, a spokesman for the Israeli national water utility Mekorot, declined to address the role of wastewater from Gaza in the desalination plants' shutdown but said high seawater temperatures contributed to “masses” of algae clogging the facilities.

The shutdowns this week, which forced Israel to ration water for agricultural use and draw more water from the Sea of Galilee and local reservoirs as an emergency measure, was a reminder of the dire humanitarian conditions facing 2 million Gazans — and their proximity to Israel.

Since early 2024, Gazans have faced severe water shortages and have often resorted to using makeshift latrines. Nearly 90 percent of the territory's water infrastructure, including desalination and wastewater treatment plants, has been destroyed,



DAWOUD ABU ALKAS/REUTERS

Displaced Palestinians gather to collect water at a tent camp in Gaza City on Aug. 9.

and the collapse of sewage pipes has led to Gaza's water aquifer becoming contaminated, according to the United Nations.

All six wastewater treatment plants in Gaza have been shut down, and 70 percent of sewage pumping stations are out of service, UNICEF said this week.

Every day, 40,000 cubic meters (or 10.6 million gallons) of wastewater are being discharged into the sea without treatment, while another 15,000 cubic meters are seeping into the ground through cesspits and leaks from sewage network leaks, according to Wafa, the official Palestinian news agency, citing the Palestinian Water Authority. Some international estimates run even higher.

Amal Al Louh, a 36-year-old English teacher in the city of Deir al-Balah, said her 7-month-old son Mohammed began suffering chronic diarrhea after drinking water from contaminated underground wells. A doctor recommended that she change to drinking water trucked in by humanitarian agencies and buying bottled water that cost \$8 a carton.

Still, her family has contracted skin conditions and infections by washing with the dirty tap water, said Louh, sharing a picture of Mohammed with large, circular rashes ringing his chest and neck.

The problem worsened dramatically after displaced residents from elsewhere in Gaza crammed into Deir al-Balah, which was not hit as hard by the war as some other parts of the territory, and set up sprawling tent cities. “Sewage is mixed with groundwater in the tent area,” Louh said. “Wastewater is getting displaced in random ways.”

This summer, when she went swimming with her family in the Mediterranean, Louh noticed that the water looked “black” and smelled like sewage. Her children fell sick after coming home, she said.

Miles away in southern Isra-



JEHAD ALSHRAFI/AP

Palestinians walk past sewage in the streets of the southern Gaza town of Khan Younis in July.

el, the situation was dramatically different. The desalination shutdown this week triggered intense media debates about vulnerabilities in Israel's infrastructure, but there were only scattered cases of water shortages as Mekovot began pumping four times as much water as usual from reservoirs. Ninety-nine percent of Israeli homes were fully supplied, Gutman said: “No one had a really severe shortage of drinking water or shower water.”

The state of Gaza's sewage treatment and water supply have long been causes for concern, even before war that began in October 2023, said David Katz, an associate professor of environmental science at the University of Haifa, in Israel.

In 2017, for instance, officials from Israel and different Palestinian factions blamed each other for a lack of fuel and electricity that led to stoppages at Gaza's wastewater treatment plants. Floating sewage then forced the Israeli desalination plant at Ashkelon to shut down.

Now, given the destruction caused by the war and a shortage of fuel and supplies, Gazan authorities may prioritize using fuel on supplying water rather than treating waste, Katz said. He added that Israel has been blocking the entry of equipment into Gaza to repair sewage facilities because they are classified as dual civilian-military use.

“There's no shortage of blame to go around,” he said.

Still, for Israeli officials, what happened this week “is going to have to be a game changer, an absolute wake-up call for the repair of sanitation infrastructure in Gaza,” said Gidon Bromberg, Israel director at the environmental nonprofit EcoPeace Middle East.

Bromberg has been arguing for immediate repairs to Gaza's sewage system in presentations he made in recent months to the Civil-Military Coordination Center, a body established as part of President Donald Trump's Gaza peace plan. While Israeli officials have been allowing more water into Gaza since the ceasefire, they have not approved work to repair the sanitation systems, he said.

“It's a threat to Palestinian public health, and it's a threat to Israeli public health,” Bromberg said. “No one can ignore the science and the fact that we all share the same environment.”

Uber ends operations in Nigeria, catching many by surprise

Abrupt announcement leaves drivers and riders stranded

BY RAELE OMBUOR

Uber abruptly ended its operations in Nigeria on Wednesday after more than 12 years of building its presence in Africa's most populous country and third-largest economy.

Drivers for the San Francisco-based multinational ride-hailing app said they learned of the decision in real time, with little warning. Some passengers told local media outlets they were en route via Uber when they received notice.

Online, people took to calling the day's events the "Uber rapture," a tongue-in-cheek reference to those left earthbound and blindsided by a sudden moment of Christian salvation.

"We are writing to share some difficult news. After a thorough review of our business, we have made the tough decision to wind down our operations in Nigeria, effective 2 September 2026" read a message sent to customers on Wednesday.

In response to questions from The Washington Post, the company confirmed it was ceasing operations in Nigeria, and Uganda as well.

The company has not said how many active drivers would be affected.

"This decision is limited strictly to these two markets and does not impact our operations across the rest of the continent," Uber

said in a statement. "Our immediate priority is supporting drivers, riders, and local team members throughout this transition."

Despite a massive global scale, Uber has not taken hold in much of Africa. After Wednesday's moves, it operates in just a handful of the continent's 54 countries: Egypt, Ghana, Kenya, South Africa and to a limited extent Morocco. Since last year, it has departed Ivory Coast and Tanzania.

"I think it's about Uber recalibrating where scale actually converts to decent operating margins," said Ikemesit Effiong, a managing partner at SBM Intelligence, a strategic consulting firm based in Lagos. "Nigeria, Uganda and Tanzania share a profile: large populations and real transport demand, but wafer-thin unit economics, low average fares, high driver churn, and a mix of formal and informal competitors that erode pricing power."

In Lagos, most taxi drivers install four major apps — Drop, Lagride, Uber and inDrive — and use them interchangeably.

Drivers in Abuja, Nigeria's capital, mourned the news. They told The Post that Uber had the highest commission among the ride-hailing apps they used.

"It's a bombshell," said Ilele Joseph Osahon, 32, an Abuja-based Uber driver. He said he had just completed a ride Wednesday when he heard the news.

"Her Uber name was 'Happiness,' that's what I saw on the request, and we were discussing about next year's elections and the high cost of fuel in Nigeria," Osahon said.

After dropping her off, Osahon



Uber confirmed it was ceasing operations in Nigeria and Uganda, but did not say how many active drivers would be affected.

noticed a buzz of activity in a WhatsApp group for drivers, and messages telling him to check his email for a departure announcement. By early evening, the app no longer functioned.

While Uber did not provide a detailed explanation for its decision, it comes amid a backdrop of rising inflation and fuel costs.

Since Nigeria moved to float its currency in 2023, it has fallen against the dollar, potentially contributing to rising fares and diminishing corporate returns,

while high fuel costs and subsidy cutbacks have squeezed drivers, Effiong said.

Osahon, the driver, said he would miss Uber's clientele, some of whom were "high caliber" and left good tips.

"I have had other people who use other apps leave banana peels in your car," and even someone who tried to barter a wig in exchange for a ride, he said.

"They has the best customer relation for drivers and custom-

ers, had good rates for drivers and the caliber of people we would pick were good, well-mannered," said Samuel Olatunji, 31, a former Uber driver in Lagos.

This month, government regulations banned Uber and Bolt from operating at airports in Nigeria, amid complaints from traditional airport taxis over high fuel costs and comparatively low fares.

Nigeria is Africa's largest crude oil producer, most of which it ex-

ports, while importing refined oil. The Nigerian government has in previous years used subsidies to help people buy the oil at low prices.

Subsidy rollbacks in 2023 drove up oil prices, tying them more closely to global markets. Nigeria started refining some of its oil in 2024, but continues to import, including from the Middle East. Amid the Iran war, restrictions on traffic through the Strait of Hormuz continue to drive up prices.

Putin, aiming to exploit Ukraine's weakened air defenses, intensifies bombing



"I have no doubt that the enemy will crumble," Russian President Vladimir Putin told journalists this week.

Putin from AI

tory to Moscow.

In Moscow, Ratcliffe warned counterparts in Russian intelligence that escalating the war would backfire, The Washington Post has reported. He urged a return to talks, arguing Russia's position was weak and would deteriorate further, according to three people familiar with his discussions.

But after the meetings, Ratcliffe felt that he had delivered the intended message "but not moved the needle" a fourth person familiar with the matter said. Russia viewed the visit as "an attempt to try to convince Putin to stop, but Putin read it as weakness," this person said.

"The message was: Things are not going well for you. It's time to talk. Let's figure this out, because it's going to be even worse for you in six months, 12 months' time," one of the people said.

The CIA has declined to comment on Ratcliffe's trip.

Putin's response to the visit seemed to come in the relentless, day-and-night airstrikes on Ukraine, and in his remarks at a regional security conference in Kyrgyzstan, where he met Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and pledged support for Tehran in its war with the United States.

Russia's escalating strikes on Kyiv and other Ukrainian cities since Ratcliffe's visit "could be some kind of signal to Washington that Russia is continuing the offensive operation and there is no need to change its position and become more flexible," said a Russian academic who is close

to senior Russian diplomats and spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive security issues.

There had been speculation that Ratcliffe's visit was also intended to dissuade Russia from helping Iran.

But the purpose of the visit was "primarily about Ukraine and trying to get the Russians to see that if their negotiating objective is to get the Ukrainians to give up Donbas, then it's just not going to happen," said a Western official familiar with the discussion.

The message was: "It's really not in your interests to keep doing this," the official said, speaking on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive diplomacy.

Russia's military advances in Ukraine have all but stalled, and its budget has become increasingly strained with the deficit snowballing to \$74.4 billion by the end of July, or 2.8 percent of its GDP, well beyond the government's original forecast of 1.6 percent for this year.

Financial anxiety has mounted, prompting Russians to pull billions from the country's banking system, and bad debts are climbing after a government-directed corporate lending boom to ramp up military output. Several senior members of the Russian elite have warned publicly against prolonging the war.

Ratcliffe delivered his view when he met last week with the head of Russia's Federal Security Service, Alexander Bortnikov, a powerful member of Putin's inner circle — who has previously proved effective in coordinating



CIA Director John L. Ratcliffe, seen in March, made a rare and unexpected visit to Moscow last month.

prisoner exchanges between the U.S. and Russia, two of the people familiar with the discussions said.

"This is really the first time that there has been a serious attempt to have this kind of contact in a more formalized way," one of the people familiar with the discussions said. "If you are trying to get to the inner circle, Bortnikov is probably one of the most important people."

Bortnikov is seen as representing a more direct line to Putin, given his KGB background and respect for intelligence, another of the people said.

But Ratcliffe's assessment was far removed from Putin's view of the situation, according to members of the Russian elite and analysts.

And if the CIA director hoped his message would result in a meeting with Putin, he was bound to be disappointed, Russian analysts said.

Signaling that Russia is losing the war and that it's better to end the war now "was not interesting for Putin to discuss," said Tatiana Stanovaya, a senior fellow at the Carnegie Russia Eurasia Center. Putin "is certain he is winning the war, and however much time it will take he believes that at some point Ukraine will break, and Russia won't need to fight."

Despite declaring on Thursday that he saw a chance of reaching a negotiated peace deal, Putin has no interest in any proposal for a ceasefire based on the current frontline, the Russian academic said.

"It seems to me taking control over all of Donbas is the mini-

mum preliminary condition for all future talks," the Russian academic said. "This task has been voiced many times by the president and other officials. It will be very difficult to step back from this."

"The Russian leadership considers they have enough instruments to dominate escalation," the academic added. "Each strike by Ukraine can be answered by a strike which brings more damage than the one brought to Russia."

On Thursday, Putin acknowledged that the government had not been prepared for Ukraine's strikes on Russia's energy infrastructure, which have led to a sharp drop in fuel output and triggered the worst fuel crisis since the Soviet collapse.

"We made a mistake," he said, speaking at the Eastern Economic Forum in Vladivostok as he conceded Russians should be prepared for prolonged gasoline shortages.

But Putin has insisted that further escalation by Ukraine — including Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky's threats this week to close Russia's skies to civil aviation by sending swarms of drones — is bound to fail, saying that Kyiv has only opened "a Pandora's box" by targeting Russian civilian infrastructure.

Putin, speaking in Kyrgyzstan, accused Zelensky of "terrorism," adding: "One does not negotiate with terrorists."

The progress of Russian forces toward the administrative borders of Donbas, the strategically critical fortress belt region



Russian Federal Security Service Director Alexander Bortnikov, a powerful member of Putin's inner circle, met with Ratcliffe.

in east Ukraine, has been halting for months. But a recent spike in oil prices, driven by renewed fighting between Iran and the United States, has boosted Putin.

It has allowed Russian leadership to think it can still outlast Ukraine, even though the chief economist of one of Russia's biggest state banks has warned publicly that Russia cannot win a war of attrition against Ukraine while Kyiv is supported by the West, one Moscow business executive said.

"There is an opinion inside the Kremlin that a few more months of war is not a problem for Russia and the Russian economy, but for Ukraine it's a huge problem," the business executive said, speaking on the condition of anonymity for fear of angering the government.

"Putin hopes time is still on his side — because despite the problems with fuel and the growth of dissatisfaction with the war, Russia's population is not as ready to protest as Ukraine's," the business executive said.

"The Russian leadership has the view that if they bomb energy infrastructure and water supplies in the regions around Kyiv it will lead to the maximum dissatisfaction of the population and the government will be forced to end the war," he added. The bombing campaign "is the only possibility for Russia to do something — because destroying the Ukrainian army with the resources that it currently has is extremely difficult."

As Russia takes advantage of depleted stocks of Patriot and air defense systems, there are grow-

ing fears in Kyiv of food shortages as winter nears. "We could be heading toward a complete humanitarian disaster," said one Ukrainian official, who like others spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive matters.

Kyiv is facing financial constraints of its own. The government is urgently seeking an additional \$27 billion in financing from the European Union as it seeks to plug a shortfall in its defense budget.

Putin could also be banking on changing political winds in the West. In regional elections in Germany this weekend, the far-right Alternative for Germany party, which is sympathetic to Russia, is set to do well. France's far-right leader, Marine Le Pen, is surging in polls ahead of a presidential election next year.

"The West is becoming weaker and changing politically internally," Stanovaya said. "Putin really does consider that circumstances are changing in his favor."

But prolonging the conflict is still fraught for Putin, creating a risk that fuel shortages will worsen, consumer prices will rise and public protests could break out.

"Whether Putin understands this is not clear," the Moscow business executive said. "The FSB chief who met with Ratcliffe probably does. But he is not going to go to Putin and persuade him to agree a peace deal on the current frontline."

Natalia Abbakumova contributed to this report.

Trump to use Qatari plane for international trip despite some security worries

PLANE FROM A1

states with tight races before the Nov. 3 elections.

The Ireland trip, however, is more personal to Trump. He plans to attend the Irish Open, which is being held at his golf course in Doonbeg. Officials say he also will hold some official meetings. The BBC has reported that he plans to meet with Irish President Catherine Connolly and Prime Minister Micheál Martin.

The United States already has spent \$400 million retrofitting the Boeing 747 from Qatar. The administration has not said how much more it will need to pay to improve the jet in the coming months.

Former White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt previously told The Washington Post that the modifications would begin in the fall and take about a month to complete, but security experts have been skeptical that the necessary upgrades could be made on that fast a timeline.

The gift of the plane from the Qatari government and royal family is an unprecedented arrangement largely intended to address Trump's frustration with delays in replacing the fleet of decades-old planes that are known as Air Force One when ferrying the president. The Air Force awarded a contract to Boeing in 2017 to purchase two 747s for use as presidential transports. It is not clear if they will be ready before Trump's term ends in January 2029.

The Government Accountability Office has estimated that the costs to enhance the 747s now exceed \$5.6 billion. Lawmakers have questioned why those upgrades have cost so much more than the changes made to the Qatari jet, and whether the jet is as secure as the government-purchased planes.

In early July, Trump began traveling on the new plane with the red, white and navy livery to events celebrating the 250th anniversary of the nation's founding, including the opening of the Theodore Roosevelt presidential library in North Dakota.

But questions about the security of the aircraft emerged just weeks into its use, when the president traveled on it interna-



President Donald Trump disembarks Air Force One in Marietta, Georgia, on July 22. He wants to use a plane gifted from Qatar for a trip to Ireland next weekend.



Air Force One performs a flyover over Washington before the Freedom 250 Grand Prix race on Aug. 23.

tionally for the first time to the NATO summit in Ankara, Turkey.

He did not take the jet on his return flight after the government received intelligence about a potential Iranian threat to attack it.

Trump initially claimed that he departed Turkey on the "former Air Force One," writing on social media that he took the trip for "old time's sake" and so that U.S. troops stationed in Britain could see the former Qatari aircraft.

Reporting by The Post revealed that Trump did not actually take that plane out of Turkey. After boarding the old Air Force One in front of TV cameras, he was secretly shuttled to an Air Force C-32A on a catering truck.

Trump flew the C-32A to Britain with a few personal aides and Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth. Several other Cabinet members, White House staff and the traveling pool of reporters scheduled to fly with Trump remained on the old Air Force One, which had become a decoy. The press and at least some of the government officials on board were not aware of the switch.

After the operation, the White House defended the security of the Qatari plane.

"The new Air Force One is a state-of-the-art aircraft that has been fitted with high-level security protocols that ensure the safety of the President and his staff," White House communications director Steven Cheung told The Post last month.

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ECONOMY & BUSINESS

U.S. economy added 162,000 jobs in August, above expectations

Employers grappled with myriad headwinds weighing on hiring

BY LAUREN KAORI GURLEY

The U.S. economy churned out 162,000 jobs in August, blowing past expectations even as employers grappled with myriad headwinds weighing on hiring.

The unemployment rate held steady at 4.1 percent, a low level consistent with a healthy labor market, according to Labor Department data released Friday.

Forecasters had expected gains of about 65,000 new jobs in August, in line with weak recent growth. Instead, hiring grew far more substantially, with restaurants and bars leading the way, the report said. Meanwhile, data for June and July were revised up by a combined 55,000 jobs, suggesting that the labor market has been stronger than previously thought.

All told, the fresh data suggests that the labor market is on solid footing, despite some obvious weak spots.

“This jobs report is pretty solid all the way around,” said Dan North, an economist with Allianz Trade North America, a trade credit insurance firm. Combined with other data, it “paints a picture that is stable but unexciting,” he said.

President Donald Trump rushed to trumpet the strong job numbers on his social media platform Truth Social, where he argued that they should encourage the Federal Reserve to lower interest rates.

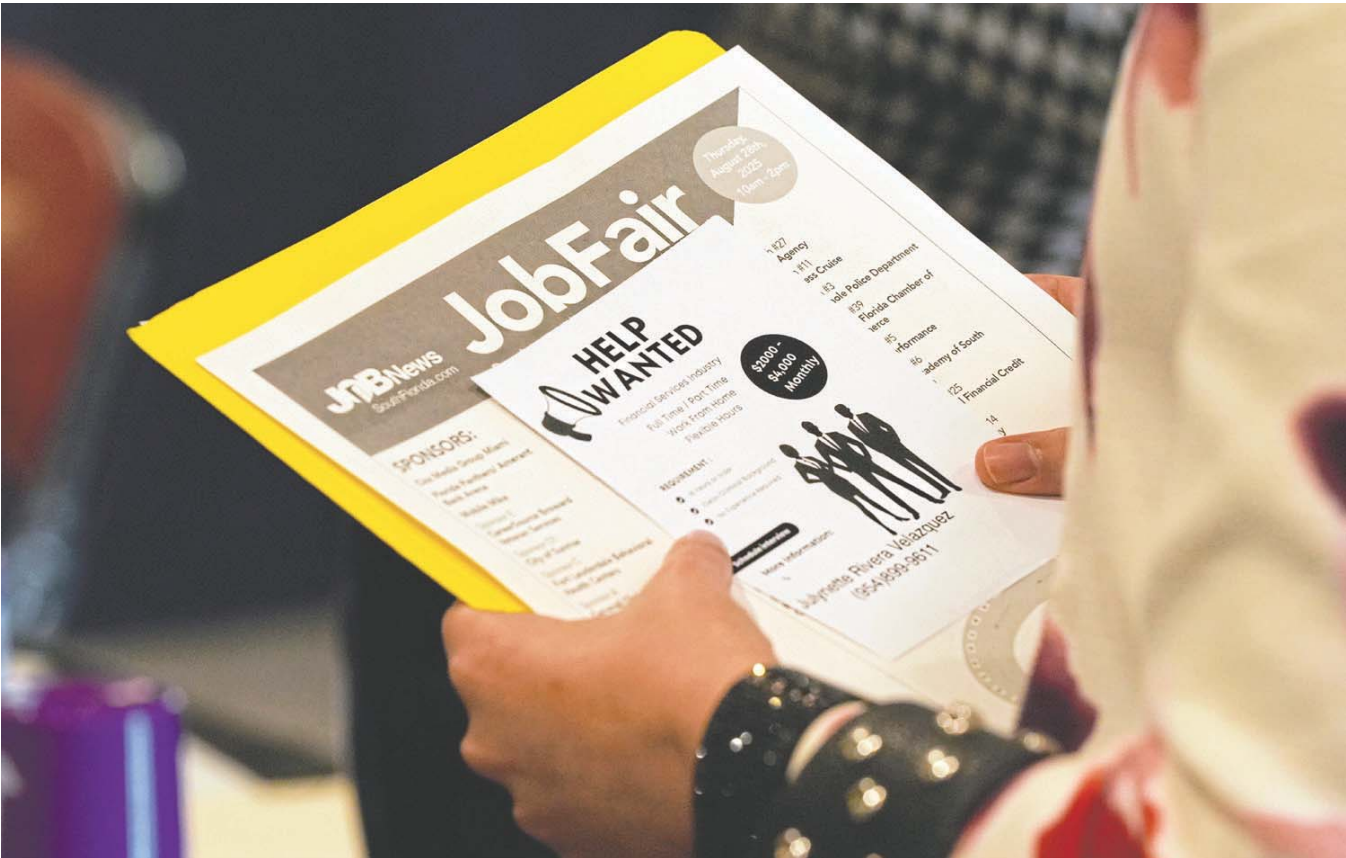
“Great jobs number just announced, breaking all estimates (except mine!),” Trump wrote. He added, “Lower the interest rates because the U.S.A. is a much stronger credit than it was just a short time ago! A STRONG COUNTRY MEANS A LOWER INTEREST RATE — IT’S A BETTER CREDIT ... Very simple!”

Despite the pressure from Trump, Friday’s report is likely to give the Fed ammunition to hike interest rates when policymakers next meet in mid-September.

In a speech last week in Jackson Hole, Wyoming, Fed Chair Kevin Warsh expressed concerns about persistent inflation, adding that the central bank may have “work to do” if rates remain high.

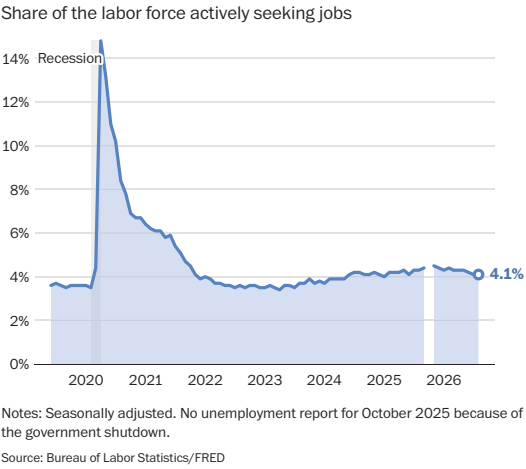
Since then, a majority of investors have been anticipating a rate hike. On Friday, financial markets traded lower as the hardy jobs data increased that prospect.

Ellen Zentner, chief econom-



A job fair in Sunrise, Florida, on Aug. 28. Forecasters had expected gains of about 65,000 new jobs in August, in line with weak recent growth.

U.S. unemployment rate



ic strategist for Morgan Stanley Wealth Management, said in an analyst’s note Friday that the

“upside surprise in payrolls will likely ramp up concerns about a rate hike.”

The Fed will probably look even more closely at next week’s inflation numbers, she said: “If those come in cooler than expected, the Fed will likely feel comfortable discounting potentially inflationary signals coming out of the labor market.”

But fresh data on inflation could highlight a dark spot in Friday’s jobs report: decelerating wage growth. Average hourly earnings grew to \$37.75 an hour in August, an increase of just 3.1 percent over the past year. With inflation running slightly higher, next week’s data could show prices once again growing faster than wages, due largely to higher gas prices triggered by Trump’s war in Iran.

That would mark another blow to American consumers, who overwhelmingly disapprove of Trump’s handling of the war and are feeling gloomy about their pocketbooks heading into the Nov. 3 midterm elections.

Friday’s report showed that job growth in August was spread across a variety of industries, fueling optimism that the labor market could be turning a corner. Restaurants and bars

added 59,000 jobs. Manufacturing employers added 16,000 jobs, driven by gains in subindustries that appear to be benefiting from tariffs.

The health care sector also continued to grow, albeit at a softer pace than in recent years when the sector buoyed the entire labor market. Job gains of 42,000 also occurred in local government education, offsetting unexpected job losses in the sector in July.

Construction also grew, fueled by the boom in data centers for artificial intelligence. But white-collar sectors, where concerns about job displacement from AI are strongest, fared less well. The information sector, which includes tech and media, lost 23,000 positions, and the finance sector lost 11,000 positions.

The share of Americans working or looking for work partially recovered in August, to 61.6 percent. That data should help assuage worries — driven by July figures showing the lowest labor force participation rate since 2021 — that workers in their prime are abandoning job searches.

However, economists remain concerned about a shrinking workforce as the baby boom generation retires and the Trump administration continues its crackdown on immigrants. Hundreds of thousands of Haitians lost their legal immigration status this summer and were forced out of the workforce.

Still, Americans continue to spend at a healthy pace, helping fuel the labor market growth, and layoffs remains at historically low levels. Initial filings for unemployment benefits ticked up slightly last week to 206,000, but are at levels consistent with a healthy labor market, according to data released Thursday by the Labor Department.

And in August, tens of thousands of workers who said they faced difficulties finding employment rejoined the workforce, new data showed.

“New jobs, broader industry participation, and workers feeling confident enough to voluntarily leave positions all point to underlying resilience,” said Nicole Bachaud, a labor economist at the jobs site ZipRecruiter, in an emailed note.

Stocks fall after strong jobs report raises prospects of interest rate hike

ALEX VEIGA
Associated Press

U.S. stocks fell and Treasury yields rose Friday after the government reported that employers unexpectedly added 162,000 jobs last month, a development that could increase chances that the U.S. central bank will raise interest rates later this month.

The S&P 500 fell 0.4 percent, though it managed to eke out a modest gain for the week. The Dow Jones Industrial Average fell 0.5 percent, and the Nasdaq composite gave back 0.3 percent.

Wall Street expects the Federal Reserve to raise interest rates

before the year ends in an effort to cool inflation, which has been running hot due to rising oil prices amid the U.S. war with Iran and remains well above 3 percent. The Fed has a stated goal of cooling inflation to a target of 2 percent. The surprise increase in hiring last month could give the central bank’s policymakers leeway to raise the Fed’s benchmark short-term interest rate to fight inflation at their next policy meeting in less than two weeks.

“Today’s jobs report does lean toward the Fed increasing rates,” said Terry Sandven, chief equity strategist at U.S. Bank Asset Management Group, noting,

however, that a rate hike is “not a foregone conclusion.”

The Labor Department reported that hiring in August far exceeded the 65,000 forecasters had expected, according to a poll by FactSet. Labor Department revisions also looked good, adding 55,000 to June and July payrolls. The unemployment rate held steady at 4.1 percent.

The stronger jobs market could make matters more complicated for the Fed, which has to balance supporting job growth with fighting inflation. Raising interest rates can help tame inflation, but it can also slow economic growth as borrowing costs

rise for households and businesses. Expectations for a rate hike in September increased to 60.4 percent on Friday following the release of the jobs report, up from 49.4 percent Thursday and from 57 percent a week ago, according to CME FedWatch.

“Given the strength of the payroll report, a rate hike on Sept. 16 appears increasingly likely,” according to Jeffrey Roach, chief economist for LPL Financial. “Ironically, a rate hike may generate less market volatility than another meeting in which policymakers choose to stand pat.”

The government will release August inflation figures Sept. 11,

shortly before the Fed’s policymaking committee’s next meeting, which ends on Sept. 16.

The closely watched consumer price index, or CPI, which measures costs for consumers, is expected to show that inflation rose last month at a 3.4 percent rate, the same as in July. Inflation has held stubbornly above 3 percent for most of the year.

“With the August CPI report now on deck, the question is whether the combined impact of stronger-than-expected hiring and a stiff inflation tail wind will push policymakers to the tipping point of raising rates later this month,” said Jim Baird, chief in-

vestment officer with Plante Moran Financial Advisors.

Fed Chair Kevin Warsh said last week that inflation had not shown sufficient improvement and that the central bank might have “more work to do,” a sign he is weighing a rate increase at the Fed’s next meeting.

On Thursday, Federal Reserve governor Christopher Waller said that if new data next week shows inflation is cooling, he “would be inclined” to keep the Fed’s benchmark interest rate unchanged. Should the data show hotter inflation, he would consider a rate hike.

DIGEST

PHARMACEUTICALS Price set for Alexander disease treatment

Ionis Pharmaceuticals said on Friday it would price its newly approved therapy to treat Alexander disease at \$285,000 per dose, a day after the U.S. FDA cleared the injectable drug, making it the first approved treatment for the genetic disorder in adults and children.

Alexander disease is a rare neurodegenerative disorder that often starts in early childhood and damages brain cells and causes problems with move-

ment, speech and swallowing.

Ionis expects peak sales for the therapy zilganersen, branded as Zanzastro, to exceed \$100 million and said the drug will be available in the United States in the coming weeks.

In an early-to-late-stage study, Alexander disease patients who got a 50 mg dose of Zanzastro showed a statistically significant improvement in gait speed as assessed by a 10-meter walk test at 61 weeks. Zanzastro is administered as an injection into the spinal canal every three months by a health care professional.

Oppenheimer analyst Jay Olson said the approval meaningfully

de-risks Ionis’ broader neurology pipeline, including obudanersen for Angelman syndrome, for which late-stage trial data are expected in the second half of 2027.

— Reuters

SPORTSWEAR Lululemon shares tumbling to new low

Lululemon Athletica shares tumbled 18 percent to an eight-year low on Friday as the sportswear maker’s latest annual forecast cut fanned worries of a long-drawn-out overhaul under

incoming CEO Heidi O’Neill.

O’Neill, a former Nike executive, will take charge on Sept. 8 when the once athleisure darling’s latest efforts to reignite growth through new styles and assortments have failed to resonate with style-savvy customers. Lululemon, associated by its affluent female shoppers with sophisticated leggings and yoga pants, has faced stumbles in product innovation, as well as concerns over fit and design in earlier launches. Sales of Lululemon’s leggings declined about 20 percent in the second quarter, while its share of the athleisure market shrank 10 per-

centage points to 43.9 percent in August, according to data from M Science. Meanwhile, shares of newer rivals Alo and Vuori grew 5.9 percentage points and 2.2 percentage points, respectively.

— Reuters

SANCTIONS New sanctions imposed on bank

The Trump administration announced Friday that it has imposed sanctions on a Turkish financial institution as part of its latest effort to sever “critical financial lifelines” for the Irani-

an government.

The actions against Golden Global Yatirim Bankasi Anonim Sirketi come after Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent last week launched “Operation Economic Outcast,” Washington’s new effort to isolate already heavily sanctioned Iran from its remaining trading partners to try to get it to capitulate to U.S. demands after more than six months of war. The Treasury Department accused the Turkish bank and its entities of being established to enable Iran’s efforts to transfer oil revenue from China to Turkey.

— Associated Press

Inflation beat out wage growth again in August, which feels a lot like 2023

INFLATION FROM AI

unemployed, starting wages are particularly grim. Advertised pay for new job postings has fallen well behind average hourly wage growth for workers, according to an analysis of Bureau of Labor Statistics and Indeed jobs data by Appcast, a job-recruiting platform.

“For new workers — say you’re unemployed or you’re a recent college graduate — what you would think you’d get in terms of wages is less than people experienced in the past,” said Andrew Flowers, chief economist at Appcast.

What makes it feel so bad is that it’s a familiar story, economists say. It wasn’t so long ago that Americans’ earnings lost ground to inflation. From 2021 to 2023, prices for gas, food and housing soared due to a combination of increased demand and supply chain shocks. That pain weighed heavily on households across the country, even helping President Donald Trump retake the White House.

“This is one of the reasons consumers hate the economy. They’ve never recovered from the inflation that started in 2021,” said Dan North, economist at Allianz Trade North America, a credit insurance firm. “If you, cumulatively, look at that inflation, wages have never caught up to prices, and that’s why prices still feel so high.”

Relief did come in early 2023 as the economy normalized and Americans saw real wage gains for nearly three straight years. But that all changed after the United States attacked Iran in late February, disrupting global oil markets and raising prices at the pump. Now inflation is once again dragging down Americans’ costs.

To be sure, the budget crunch could be much worse. Wage growth would look pretty solid, if it weren’t for high inflation. Wage growth, though declining, has hovered above 3 percent this summer — a healthy pace similar to the years before the pandemic.

That growth is partially being driven by some employers who have been raising wages to fill labor shortages in industries that lost foreign-born workers to Trump’s tightened immigra-



A customer at a supermarket in Houston on Wednesday. Wages rose 3.1 percent in August compared to a year earlier.



tion policy, said Diane Swonk, chief economist at financial firm KPMG.

For example, labor shortages are pushing up wages, especially for skilled workers in construction, according to data from the regional feds in Atlanta, Cleveland and Kansas City, Missouri, published in the beige book out this week. In August, wages grew the fastest in leisure and hospitality, construction and transportation, all immigrant-heavy industries that have had to replace workers, as well as finance, Swonk said.

But inflation still wiped out wage gains. And there are signs that inflation could be worse in September with diesel fuel prices hitting a record high on Friday. Fuel inflation trickles out into the broader economy, from transportation and warehousing to food and then grocery stores and restaurants.

The financial pain is the greatest, economists say, for middle- and lower-income households that lack investments in the financial markets, which are up by double digits for the year so far. Rising prices are playing a big role in consumer sentiment, which also sank in August, according to a long-standing University of Michigan survey.

“People are falling behind,” said Mark Zandi, chief economist of Moody’s Analytics. “That goes most fundamentally to the general anxiety that many Americans feel about their financial situations. They’re just not keeping up.”

Despite falling wages, Americans mostly kept spending this year, showing a reluctance to significantly change their overall habits even as inflation eats into their budgets. Spending was bolstered this spring and early summer by larger-than-usual tax

refunds and big events like the World Cup and Amazon Prime Day. As those taper off, Zandi said the real test is now.

“Given what’s going on with income, there is reason to be nervous that consumers will need to become even more cautious, pull back even more,” he said.

Consumer spending is the underlying force of the U.S. economy, making up about two-thirds of economic activity. It can determine overall economic health and growth.

Cracks are starting to show in consumers’ spending habits. Retail sales fell unexpectedly in July, reflecting that consumers may not be as resilient as they have long seemed. Other signs have begun to pile up: Walmart, a cornerstone of budget-friendly American shoppers, reported its weakest sales growth since the pandemic recession in 2020, and federal data showed consumer spending cooled in July.

Also, people are dipping into their savings, with the personal savings rate falling to a four-year low in June, recovering only slightly in July.

Walmart blamed some of its slow growth on falling prescription drug prices, and July’s numbers followed a strong June full of sales events. But some experts say that as the Iran war drags on, and wages lag behind prices, consumers will look for more ways to cut back.

Jamie O’Brien, 25, who runs an education program at a botanical garden in Richmond, said that they have received one pay raise since they got hired almost two years ago, bringing their pay to \$17 an hour, up from \$16 an hour.

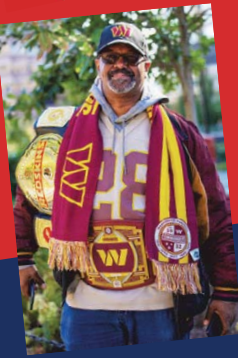
“My expenses have gone up far more than that \$1 could hope to catch up with,” O’Brien said. “I pay a little over \$1,000 [a month] for rent. When I started working at the garden I was living in the same apartment and my rent was about \$670.”

O’Brien’s workplace voted to unionize to bring up wages. But until they receive a more substantial pay bump, O’Brien is cutting back on groceries and unable to put any money into savings.

Steve Thompson contributed to this report.



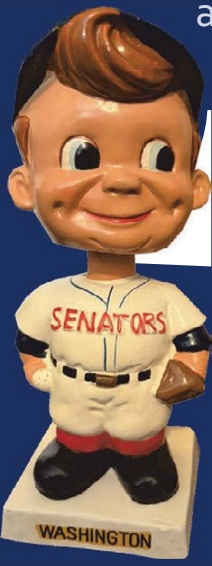
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DC Public Library

OPINION

The Washington Post

AN INDEPENDENT NEWSPAPER



House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries (D-New York) leaves a news conference at the Capitol on Aug. 31.

EDITORIALS

Family counselors, please check on House Democrats

Socialists want retribution after centrists sided with Republicans.
How will they feel when the shoe is on the other foot?

HOUSE DEMOCRATIC LEADERSHIP'S demand for party discipline collided this week with promises that the caucus has enough room for socialists and moderates, a harbinger of trouble next year if Democrats win the majority.

The intraparty feud flared on Tuesday when two centrists unexpectedly voted with Republicans to pass a procedural rule that would otherwise have failed. That teed up a floor vote on a symbolic resolution to denounce socialism. Furious liberals demanded the defectors be removed from their committees. House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries (D-New York) and his two deputies responded in a joint statement that the "significant breach of trust ... necessitates a serious response." They referred the question to a party committee.

Democrats across the ideological spectrum see what happens next as a gauge of Jeffries's strength and a precedent-setter for how leadership will deal with recalcitrance from the socialist whippersnappers poised to enter Congress in 2027.

Capitol Hill veterans privately acknowledge that Jeffries is not as talented a tactician as his predecessor, Nancy Pelosi, and it's unclear whether he can grow into the job. The retiring former speaker told reporters this week that Democrats stuck together on procedural votes like this when she was in charge. That maximized Pelosi's negotiating leverage. "We didn't even consider that anybody would do that," she said.

In contrast, the GOP has grown accustomed to rank-and-file members breaking with the conference on rule-related votes since the emergence of the House Freedom Caucus. In fact, Speaker Mike Johnson (R-Louisiana) needed support from Democratic Reps. Marie Gluesenkamp Perez (Washington) and Jared Golden (Maine) because five Republicans opposed him on the same vote.

Democrats are now experiencing their own version of a tea party movement in the form of the Democratic Socialists of America, and the party establishment hopes that, unlike their GOP counterparts, they can channel and con-

trol the infusion of energy. Spoiler alert: It will be harder than they think.

Consider Darializa Avila Chevalier, the 32-year-old DSA member who defeated Rep. Adriano Espaillat (D-New York), the chair of the Congressional Hispanic Caucus, in a June primary. Jeffries vigorously campaigned for Espaillat. Chevalier responded to Tuesday's vote by castigating Golden and Gluesenkamp Perez. "Democrats love talking about a 'big tent,' but then they vote in line with Republicans hell-bent on destroying our democracy and stripping Black and brown people of the right to vote," Chevalier posted on Instagram.

It's not just the newcomers. Rep. Jim McGovern (Massachusetts), the ranking Democrat on the Rules Committee, literally turned his back on Gluesenkamp Perez when she addressed the panel on Wednesday.

It's wild that so many Democrats are treating moderates this way just two months before midterm elections, when the path to a majority goes through districts carried by President Donald Trump, such as the ones represented by Gluesenkamp Perez and Golden (who is not running for reelection). Jeffries understands this, which is probably why he sought to lower the temperature as the week went on. On Thursday, he said he met with Gluesenkamp Perez for a "productive, forward-looking conversation" that is part of an ongoing "family discussion" among Democrats.

Gluesenkamp Perez has a coveted seat on the Appropriations Committee. Assuming she gets nothing more than a slap on the wrist, the risk for Jeffries is that DSA acolytes will feel emboldened to break with him on key votes next year. If Jeffries holds them to a different standard in retaliation, he will generate new problems on his left flank, including a potential primary challenge in 2028. Assuming Jeffries is likely to become speaker, much depends on how many votes he has to spare.

Trump's unpopularity may keep Democrats mostly unified in opposition, but the family discussion, already heated, could be headed for an all-out food fight.

Trump's new plan to lower interest rates? Extort the Fed.



President Donald Trump in the Oval Office on Friday.

Fed's 2 percent target. It's nearly double, in fact, sitting at 3.7 percent, according to the Fed's preferred metric. Even excluding food and energy prices, which

are more affected by events such as the Iran conflict, prices are up 3.3 percent from a year ago.

Given Friday's strong job numbers, Warsh leaving the door open for a rate hike is especially prudent. The U.S. economy added 162,000 jobs in August across a variety of sectors, beating economists' forecasts by nearly 100,000 jobs. Unemployment remained at 4.1 percent — lower than it was in any month between February 1970 and September 1999.

With the labor market on solid footing, goosing the economy before the midterms is a surefire way to make inflation worse. It's telling that not all of the White House is fully on board with the pressure campaign against the Fed. National Economic Council Director Kevin Hassett said he thinks the argument for holding rates steady is "pretty strong."

Hassett also clarified: "The Fed will do what it wants to do. We respect their independence." It's good that Hassett does, but it seems like "we" doesn't include his boss.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR



A wildfire approaches a beach on the Adriatic coast in Croatia on Aug. 14.

Stop adding fuel to the climate fire

Regarding the Sept. 3 news article "World is certain to cross climate threshold, U.N. warns":

It's no surprise that the world will rocket past its climate targets. As the article noted, to bring temperatures back down, all aspects of society would need a dramatic overhaul.

However, President Donald Trump and the United States keep marching in the wrong direction. Trump has prioritized fossil fuel generation during his administration, and the U.S. produced more crude oil than any other country last year.

But fossil fuels are the true culprits of this deadly, destructive climate crisis, and phasing them out should be kept front and center.

It's true that natural carbon dioxide removal, through protecting and restoring ecosystems, needs to be a part of creating a safe climate future. And the world shouldn't bet on dangerous, expensive failures like bioenergy with carbon capture and storage, or BECCS.

Keeping heat-trapping carbon out of the atmosphere is the surest, safest way to avoid more catastrophe.

U.S. leaders must do more to combat the climate crisis and stop putting polluter profits first. They can start by accelerating production of affordable, clean energy like solar and wind. It's what many Americans want, and it will save many lives and trillions of dollars.

Shaye Wolf, Oakland, California
The writer is climate science director at the Center for Biological Diversity.

The case for more American aluminum

The portrayal of the Inola, Oklahoma, aluminum project as a cautionary tale of "populist economics" in the Aug. 22 editorial "Industrial policy meets red state politics" misses the larger economic and national security stakes.

For decades, America allowed its aluminum industry to contract to the point of strategic vulnerability. As the editorial noted, the United States has not built a new primary aluminum smelter since 1980.

In 2000, the country had 23 in operation. Today, only four remain and the country has become heavily reliant on imports. Roughly half of all aluminum used in the U.S. is imported. The result is a structural dependence on foreign sources for an essential metal used every day by the Pentagon in mission-critical equipment, as well as thousands of lost jobs for highly skilled American workers. The project in Inola is a step toward reversing that trajectory.

With planned production of 750,000 metric tons of primary aluminum annually, the facility will be the largest of its kind ever built in the U.S. and will more than double current production.

Aluminum imports pose a national security threat to U.S. supply chains and defense manufacturing; the federal government has specifically adopted policies intended to encourage new domestic primary aluminum production for this reason. Accepting dependence on foreign supply for military-grade aluminum, or any essential material, is a risk not worth taking.

Mark Duffy, Washington
The writer is president of the American Primary Aluminum Association.

Nuclear regulation needs a reset

Vincent Ialenti's Aug. 26 online op-ed, "U.S. nuclear campuses could power a renaissance. Except for one problem," rightly credited the Trump administration with bringing new momentum to nuclear energy and spent fuel policy. The administration is pressing ahead with Nuclear Lifecycle Innovation Campuses, meant to make use of the more than 95,000 metric tons of used fuel sitting in casks across the country. This approach turns a storage liability into an energy asset. However, Ialenti undercut this monumental achievement by misidentifying regulatory reform and reductions in the federal workforce as dangers.

Nuclear energy and the fuel that powers it should be held to demanding safety standards. But safety and bureaucracy are not synonymous. Too much red tape has made the nuclear industry so sclerotic that the United States has added almost no new nuclear capacity for decades, even as electricity demand has skyrocketed.

President Joe Biden's Energy Department squandered \$24 million on building public trust in an inefficient spent-nuclear-fuel-storage model. Instead, the Trump administration plans to attract up to \$50 billion in capital investment to generate new nuclear fuel production that will reduce U.S. nuclear-waste liability.

The Trump administration is asking the right questions: Which requirements address real risks, and which merely add cost, delay and uncertainty? Updating rules for modern reactor technology and fuel reprocessing is not an attack on safety. It is how America can again build and fuel nuclear power at the scale the country needs.

Joe Grogan, McLean
The writer is a former director of the Domestic Policy Council and assistant to President Donald Trump.

A lesson in kindness from a jellyfish

The Aug. 30 Metro article "'Perfect storm' of conditions allowing jellyfish to thrive along Atlantic Coast" caught my attention. Jellyfish may not have "bones, brains or hearts," but they are living creatures. I was sad to read about the children who were collecting them and "chopping them up with gruesome aplomb."

Jellyfish may not be cute and cuddly like pet dogs and cats, but they deserve the opportunity to live out their existence without being cut up as "rough justice." Parents can use these moments to talk to their children about respect for all living beings, whether they are cute or not.

We should incorporate respect for all beings into our daily lives. Animals are worthy of protection. Maybe if each of us tried to do this, we would live in a less stressful, violent world.

Jennie Gosché, Kensington

Letter submissions

Send letters to letters@washpost.com. Submissions must be exclusive to The Post and should include the writer's address and day and evening telephone numbers. Letters are subject to editing and abridgment. Please do not send letters as attachments. Because of the volume of material we receive, we are unable to acknowledge submissions; writers whose letters are under consideration for publication will be contacted.

Post Opinions wants to know: What do you wish you had known earlier? What nuggets of wisdom, gleaned from years of experience, would you share with your younger self? Send us your response, and it might be published as a letter to the editor. wapo.st/wise_words

OPINION

EDITH PRITCHETT



How to stop a deadly livestock parasite? Make a billion sterile flies.

BY BROOKE L. ROLLINS AND MARKWAYNE MULLIN

Over the past year and a half, the Trump administration has marshaled enormous resources to protect American livestock from the deadly New World screwworm fly. These parasites with flesh-eating larvae can feed on cattle and other livestock. They were a threat in the United States for decades before being eradicated here in 1966. But the flies have reemerged in Texas in recent months. Texas Gov. Greg Abbott issued a disaster declaration in January to prevent an infestation of the pest from across the southern border.

In partnership with leaders on the ground such as Abbott, the U.S. Agriculture and Homeland Security departments have taken the fight directly to this parasitic insect. Despite predictions of a widespread outbreak, there are only three active cases of the screwworm fly in the U.S., amid a federal response that has included a record \$1.3 billion in emergency funding to combat the pest. USDA has expanded staff working on the effort from 10 to 110 and dispersed more than 1 billion sterile flies to prevent the insects from reproducing.

USDA announced in July the reopening of cattle ports along the southern border after they were closed last year to control the spread of the screwworm fly. This progress is encouraging, and the administration is building on it to eradicate this pest once again.

Since the 1960s, the most effective tool against the parasite has been sterilization. A female screwworm mates once in its life, so when it mates with a sterile male fly released in infested areas, it produces eggs that never hatch, collapsing the population over time.

That's why USDA quickly opened a sterile fly dispersal facility in February at Moore Air Base in Edinburg, Texas. USDA also supports a facility in Panama that produces 100 million sterile flies per week and helped upgrade a production facility in Metapa, Mexico, that will produce the same amount once fully operational.

And to the relief of ranchers, we expect to open a sterile fly production facility at Moore Air Base by spring 2027, seven months ahead of the initial goal. Later that year, the facility will produce 100 million sterile flies per week, with a long-term goal of 300 million weekly by late 2028. The production process at the plant — the size of four football fields — involves feeding the flies an artificial diet and housing them in controlled environments that simulate natural conditions.

The expedited timeline for this facility was made possible by extraordinary coordination among federal agencies, including the Army Corps of Engineers, which fast-tracked construction permits. The Food and Drug Administration granted emergency use authorizations for therapeutics to help treat infested animals.

These eradication efforts coincide with USDA's forthcoming plan to combat illicit cattle movements, which can contribute to the screwworm's migration north toward the southern border. Each



Cattle at a government livestock facility near Hermosillo, Mexico, on Aug. 25.

year, roughly 800,000 head of cattle are smuggled from Central America into Mexico, often bypassing sanitary inspection and traceability systems. As a result, potentially diseased or unmonitored animals can move undetected across borders and jeopardize regional biosecurity.

This cannot continue. USDA's plan will bolster frontline monitoring capabilities in the U.S., promote deeper engagement with Mexico and Central America, and improve collaboration with other federal and state agencies.

USDA and DHS recently signed a memorandum of understanding that enhances coordination and information sharing, ensuring we can move more quickly to support and protect America's animals, people and agricultural resources.

Technological developments — including unmanned aircraft systems and artificial intelligence — have transformed how we combat the screwworm fly. The U.S.-Mexico border is nearly 2,000 miles long, with terrain that makes it challenging to track every animal that might cross the border. By searching for behavior consistent with an animal that has open wounds, drones could help detect livestock susceptible to a screwworm fly infestation at or between ports of entry.

Since July 1, USDA has conducted more than 1,400 drone flights in Texas, observing over 26,000 animals across almost 700,000 acres. Hundreds of DHS drones are being used to help this effort. Drones will not fly over farm and ranch land without producers' permission.

Putting farmers and ranchers first is the Trump administration's top focus. We want to ensure that the men and women who raise cattle and put high-quality food on America's plates have the support they need to thrive.

Brooke L. Rollins is the U.S. secretary of agriculture. Markwayne Mullin is the U.S. secretary of homeland security.

WILL LEITCH

Why fans keep coming back to the coach they claim to despise

In "Lane Being Lane," John Talty's terrific, eye-opening new biography, an amazing anecdote perfectly sums up both polarizing college football coach Lane Kiffin and his sport. The book is chock-full of insight and sometimes salacious detail about its subject, who crossed into the mainstream last year when he left the University of Mississippi right before the school's team played in the College Football Playoff to coach hated rival Louisiana State University. That made him college football's foremost villain, the soulless avatar of all of the sport's failings.

Talty talked to hundreds of people in Kiffin's orbit, some of whom love him and most of whom don't. But one Ole Miss booster, one of those people who love Rebels football so much they'll give away a fortune just to see the team win, stands out. Midway through the 2022 Mississippi season, the booster, worried that Kiffin would bolt for another school (as he eventually did, as he was always eventually going to) offered the school \$500,000 to make sure he stayed. Exactly one month later, after a couple of tough losses, the booster called the school back. "I'll give that f---er \$500,000 to leave."

That's college football right there. An absurdly wealthy man is willing to drop more money to keep a coach — or to push him out — than many Americans make in a decade like it's a tip under a pint glass at a bar. I know most everyone is angry at Kiffin, and I understand why, but you tell me: Which of those two men seems saner? The one who throws a fortune at his favorite sports team on wildly fluctuating emotional whims? Or the one who takes it?

Lane Kiffin is college football's forever main character in a sport that's full of them, the guy who, no matter whether his team is winning or losing (they're usually winning), makes sure you're looking at him. This past year we've been looking at him with disdain, but just a year before he was the subject of soft-focus ESPN features about the "new," likable, more-comfortable-with-himself Kiffin. He'll anger you by exploiting vague transfer rules, but in a month he'll post something funny online, and you'll laugh. Kiffin knows he's disliked because of the way he's always leaving one school for another. But he also knows that if people are angry at him for leaving, it means, deep down, they loved him enough to wish he'd stayed.

It's ironic that such a brash character, in Talty's telling, is in fact mostly quiet, isolated and socially awkward. Talty reports that one booster told him, "If Lane had his way ... he would not talk to or engage with a single soul each day, parachute in on Saturday to coach the game, and then be left alone to mess with people on Twitter and over text and voice messages." That's not what you imagine from a coach — it's certainly not what you imagine from a coach so firmly embedded in the public consciousness — but Talty argues it's essential to the cycle of Kiffin's successes and downfalls: He is



Louisiana State University football coach Lane Kiffin in Tampa in July.

always in control, until, dramatically, he isn't. This explains Kiffin's repeated arcs: win, get restless, anger people, leave, win, get restless, anger people, leave, win again. And this also happens to be the exact cycle that college football now rewards. James Franklin pulled Penn State football out of the depths after the Joe Paterno scandal and spent a decade building it into a powerhouse — before he started the 2025 season 3-3 and was fired in a fit of short-term anger from Penn State's administration and boosters.

Franklin has been welcomed at Virginia Tech as a conquering hero — until he dares briefly disappoint it, too. College football is gloriously entertaining — I find it obsessively, almost addictively, compelling — but it is a goldfish sport if there ever were one: It is run, staffed and cheered for by people with relentlessly short-term memories. Winning only makes people happy temporarily. Then they return to their default discontent. Then it's time for a new coach.

Is there anyone more perfect for this than Kiffin? Sure, in 2025, Kiffin was the most hated man in sports. But he's reappeared in advertisements this year with a self-aware twinkle in his eye, the look of a man who knows he's only a winning season away from changing minds once more. Fans will come around to Kiffin again, as they have before, as they always do. And then they will turn on him again, and on and on and on.

Lane Kiffin is college football incarnate: slippery, shifty, in constant need of attention and utterly irresistible. I can't wait for him to leave again. It's what he does. It's what we want. It is, in fact, what we demand.

Trump’s huge Venezuela deal started with a call and a bet on an oilman

America’s backing of Betancourt already is providing benefits

BY ANTHONY FAIOLA, SAMANTHA SCHMIDT AND KAREN DEYOUNG

On a phone call in March, a Trump administration emissary made a bold pitch. How would Alejandro Betancourt, a wealthy Venezuelan oilman and influential power player in his country, feel about taking on a new business partner: the U.S. government?

Operating from his residence in Britain, Betancourt, 46, developed a reputation for a golden touch in extracting Venezuela’s challengingly thick crude, with his company ramping up production tenfold in two years. But the deal with Washington, he was warned, would have costs, according to two people with knowledge of the call.

Mauricio Claver-Carone — the former U.S. special envoy for Latin America, who placed the call — told Betancourt he would probably forfeit a percentage of his company — the second largest private oil firm in Venezuela — and its independence as the administration named new board members. In exchange, he’d gain access to vast new oil reserves and potentially become a “global player.”

“I’m all in,” Betancourt replied, according to the people familiar with the call, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss confidential negotiations.

Betancourt for years had grown wealthy off business with Venezuela’s corrupt governments. But at times he also secretly aided efforts to undermine its former strongman, Nicolás Maduro, according to Betancourt supporters and U.S. officials. In subsequent conversations with associates about the developing Trump deal, Betancourt mused about legacy — of shaping a new Venezuelan economy, according to people familiar with the discussions.

If it worked, the United States would gain a lasting foothold in a formerly adversarial country while Betancourt, a U.S.-educated entrepreneur facing international investigations, would win a formidable new backer in the form of Uncle Sam.

The extent of that backing unfolded behind the scenes. The Washington Post reported last week that soon after Maduro’s capture on Jan. 3, senior administration officials began intervening on Betancourt’s behalf with Swiss authorities who had issued a warrant for his arrest in connection with a money laundering investigation.

Betancourt’s attorney in the United States, Jon A. Sale, denied any wrongdoing by his client.

In May, Swiss authorities requested that the United States detain him. Washington did not act on the request. Instead, senior officials again intervened, granted him a multiple-entry visa and welcomed him in Washington for high-level meetings.

The result of those visits emerged Friday when President Donald Trump announced that the U.S. government was taking an ownership stake in North American Blue Energy Partners (NABEP), Betancourt’s private company, and had arranged for the Venezuelan government, led by interim president Delcy Rodríguez, to grant him the rights to 14 oil fields. The company now has three.

Industry analysts view the deal as a high-risk gamble for the U.S. and for Betancourt, who must now come up with significant financing to exploit the new oil reserves.

Initially, Trump sought a different approach, one person with knowledge of the White House discussions said. In the aftermath of the U.S. military’s capture of Maduro on Jan. 3, as he proclaimed the U.S. would “run” Venezuela, Trump had proposed taking a direct stake in PDVSA, the country’s state-owned oil giant.

That plan sparked concerns within his Cabinet, including from Energy Secretary Chris Wright, who argued that the major oil giants, as opposed to the U.S. government, should be encouraged to enter the Venezuelan oil sector. Others around Trump fretted about the legal and political hurdles of a stake in a Venezuelan state entity.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio, among others, saw Betancourt as the answer, the person with knowledge of the White House discussions said.

An Energy Department spokesman, Ben Dietterich,



Venezuela’s interim President Delcy Rodríguez, center, with U.S. Energy Secretary Chris Wright, left, at the signing of an oil agreement this week.

denied any disagreement between Trump and Wright, or any suggestion that Wright was “opposed to exploring multiple avenues to unleash Venezuela’s resource potential.” Dietterich referred questions about Trump’s initial interest in a PDVSA stake to the White House, which did not respond to a request for comment.

The State Department also did not respond to a request for comment.

This article is based on interviews with 10 people familiar with Betancourt’s history and operations, including two with detailed, direct knowledge of how the deal announced by Trump came together. They include people involved in U.S. policy on Venezuela and the Venezuelan oil industry, employees of Betancourt and other people briefed on the agreement, most of whom spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive information.

Betancourt has faced investigations in Venezuela, the U.S. and Europe, and Swiss authorities are still actively pursuing their money laundering investigation, according to people with knowledge of the matter.

Administration officials who advocated for working with him argued that while Betancourt was no saint, he had no active cases against him in the U.S., and investigations against him elsewhere were based on old allegations. His success in the oil sector, his past support for the Venezuelan opposition and clandestine assistance to the United States leading up to Maduro’s capture convinced them he was the man for the job.

“This is a proven operator,” a senior U.S. official told reporters during a briefing Tuesday on the Venezuelan deal. “I’m not nominating anyone for sainthood here. What I am telling you is that this is a person that, in the past, has been helpful to the United States government.”

In the first Trump administration, there were deep divisions between the State Department and the White House over whether and how to engage with Betancourt, who held major influence in Venezuela but faced a money laundering investigation, ultimately dismissed, over a loan deal with PDVSA.

“Trump has allied the government with the most shadowy and repellent Venezuelan businessman he could find,” former Trump official Elliott Abrams wrote in a Post op-ed this week. “We knew exactly what Betancourt stood for and kept him far away from the U.S. government. No longer.”

Others, however, have found Betancourt useful.

At the request of opposition leaders and without direct U.S. approval, he secretly flew to



Alejandro Betancourt, a wealthy Venezuelan oilman, in 2016.

Moscow in 2019 to deliver a letter from then opposition leader Juan Guaidó calling on the Kremlin to drop its support for Maduro, according to two people with direct knowledge of his efforts.

Betancourt, these people said, was also a financial backer of Guaidó, who became a cause célèbre among Trump officials later that year by challenging Maduro for Venezuela’s presidency before fizzling out.

Guaidó did not respond to a request for comment.

In 2020, he denied having any “relationship” with Betancourt. Several Venezuelan opposition supporters and people involved with U.S. policy during the first Trump administration said they were not aware that Betancourt aided the opposition, and raised questions about whether the administration was now seeking to overstate his assistance to rehabilitate his image.

“They are trying to reinvent this guy,” said Pedro Burelli, an advocate for the Venezuelan opposition and former board member of PDVSA.

In 2019, Betancourt hired Rudy Giuliani to help him contend with a Justice Department investigation in which he was not charged but appeared as an unnamed co-conspirator, The Post reported.

Rubio this week told the Miami-based Venezuelan podcaster

Sergio Novelli that Betancourt had “ended up in a very, very bad place with Maduro. Because it became known that he was supporting elements of the opposition back in 2019.”

Betancourt reestablished regular contact with the second Trump administration last year, months before Maduro’s capture. He became an increasingly valuable asset — to a point that some officials believed that without his help it would not have been possible to hold the country together after Maduro’s seizure, according to people with knowledge of Betancourt’s actions and U.S. strategy in Venezuela.

More recently, Betancourt used his extensive information network in Venezuela to secure intelligence that helped Washington interdict “ghost ships” that were seeking to smuggle sanctioned Venezuelan oil, according to two people with direct knowledge of his collaboration with U.S. officials.

On the chaotic day of Maduro’s capture in January, Betancourt emerged as Washington’s good cop. While other Trump emissaries threatened Rodríguez if she did not cooperate, Betancourt offered reassurances, including over her personal safety.

After the capture, Betancourt influenced Venezuelan government decisions, particularly on oil. He “became Venezuela’s de facto minister of economy,” said

a person supportive of Betancourt’s influence inside the Venezuelan government.

“Mr. Betancourt has a long history of supporting the United States,” Sale, his attorney, told The Post.

Even as he was rebuilding his relationship with Washington, however, Betancourt’s legal troubles were deepening. He was arrested twice in Britain in 2025, first after Spain issued a warrant in a related money laundering investigation, and in November at Switzerland’s request.

In May, the Swiss withdrew their extradition request to Britain, allowing British travel restrictions on Betancourt to be lifted. Swiss authorities then asked Washington to detain him, according to people familiar with the matter.

Instead, at the request of a senior State Department official, the U.S. Consulate in London in June issued Betancourt a one-year, multiple-entry visa.

Since then, he has traveled repeatedly to Washington. “From an intervention standpoint, we just wanted to have access to him so we could finalize this arrangement,” the senior U.S. official said.

The deal gives the U.S. 35 percent of Betancourt’s company, and calls for Venezuela to give NABEP 14 additional oil fields, putting 65 billion barrels of reserves under the company’s control. The U.S. will have a right to buy 20 percent of the oil at cost.

While many details of the deal have not been disclosed, Trump and other officials have said the U.S. would claim its stake through an office of the Pentagon that has been working with private companies to accelerate and scale investment in critical supply chain technologies.

Experts have said any significant new oil extraction from the deal could be years in the future. Oil industry officials also question how willing large firms will be to get involved.

“No publicly traded company is going to want to invest in this,” said Ed Hirs, an energy economist and consultant who advises oil and gas companies on deals. “Betancourt has been under investigation. That is close enough to the line legally that no U.S. board of directors is going to be comfortable going in alongside him.”

Hirs also said companies will be concerned about the durability of the deal once Trump leaves office. “Delcy Rodríguez negotiated this with a gun to her head,” he said.

Advocates of the alliance, however, say some of the new fields are close to NABEP’s existing ones, making it easier to ramp up some operations. They cite NABEP’s increase in output under Betancourt as evidence of what’s possible.

A person aware of Betancourt’s strategy said he is looking to finance the new venture in part by seeking up to \$10 billion in prepayments from major oil traders.

That sum would be derived from an advance on NABEP’s projected net annual revenue of \$5 billion, based on a price of \$70 a barrel, with anticipation that actual revenue in coming years would be higher as production ramps up.

NABEP officials insist there will be “meaningful” new production within two years. Already, the company has acquired or negotiated 52 additional rigs for its new operations, adding to a fleet of 65, according to an internal NABEP document obtained by The Post. To secure access to infrastructure, the company also acquired Houston-based Drilling Structures International, a rig manufacturer.

“We will be able to deploy resources immediately,” said a NABEP official who spoke on the condition of anonymity because he was not authorized to speak to the press.

The scion of a wealthy Venezuelan family, Betancourt started as an oil trader before investing in a Russian-backed oil venture in the 2010s that was later seized by the Venezuelan government.

In 2023, Betancourt reclaimed a foothold in the Venezuelan oil sector with Harry Sargeant, a Florida-based Republican donor and oilman who was deeply divisive within the Trump administration. Last month, under pressure from the administration to divest from NABEP, Sargeant sold his stake to Betancourt for \$300 million, according to three people aware of the transaction.

Now, Betancourt faces the challenge of appeasing Trump while increasing Venezuelan oil output.

Some in the industry cite Betancourt’s experience taking decrepit oil fields — or brownfields — and cleaning up the wells to get crude pumping again. The task ahead is more complex and includes developing new, largely untouched “greenfields.”

Under his existing contract, Betancourt has already tapped one greenfield, and is extracting nearly 30,000 barrels per day from the site, according to a company official.

Francisco Monaldi, director of the Latin American Energy Program at Rice University, said he doubted some of the “greenfields” will be developed soon.

“That’s the last thing you’d want to develop,” Monaldi said. “But it helps Trump claim there are 65 billion barrels in reserves. It helps NABEP claim that it has one of the largest reserves on the planet.”

Evan Halper and Helena Carpio contributed to this report.



SPORTS
Chasing fan engagement, MLB teams are turning to their furriest employees. **B7**



METRO
Tarmac talk among father, daughter pilots stirs debate on family phone plans. **B13**

The Washington Post Style

SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 5, 2026

EZ RE KK **B**

BY ANY MEANS ★★☆☆

Thriller set in civil rights era adds heft to buddy genre

BY MARK KENNEDY
Associated Press

Hollywood has given us some classic mismatched buddy cop movies, like Nick Nolte and Eddie Murphy in “48 Hrs.,” Jackie Chan and Chris Tucker in “Rush Hour” and perhaps the most iconic pair — Mel Gibson and Danny Glover in “Lethal Weapon.” Now, make room for Yahya Abdul-Mateen II and Mark Wahlberg.

The latest duo stars in “By Any Means,” an opposites-attract movie with real historical heft, set against the racial and political violence of the American South in the late 1960s and told with blood-splashing power and blunt elegance, courtesy of director Elegance Bratton.

Here we get Abdul-Mateen as a by-the-book, Southern-born, wet-behind-the-ears, Black FBI agent teamed up with Wahlberg, a jaundiced New York Mafia hit man, two characters crossing the racial, North-South and polite barriers.

Unable to crack the 1966 firebombing murder of Mississippi NAACP leader Vernon Dahmer Sr., the FBI turns to Wahlberg’s Gregory Scarpa, letting him loose off the books to solve the case. The Ku Klux Klan is everywhere, especially in law enforcement, and that means Scarpa’s got to crack some skulls, no warrant, no problem. “Nobody can know,” the pair are warned.

Bratton and scriptwriter Sascha Penn artfully straddle the various divides and historical animosities while delivering a propulsive, muscular and unvarnished action thriller, a sort of “Mississippi Burning” for a new generation. And, it must be noted, at a time when white Christian nationalism has once more reared its

SEE ‘BY ANY MEANS’ ON B2

TV REVIEW

‘Marble Hall Murders’ is killing it again in new season

BY MOIRA MACDONALD
Seattle Times

“I’m trying to solve a crime,” says one detective, testily, to another. His partner coolly replies, “In fiction, or in real life?”

It’s a perfect little exchange that sums up the appeal of “Marble Hall Murders,” the third and supposedly final installment of Anthony Horowitz’s delicious mystery series streaming on PBS starting Sunday. In each series, a present-day murder to be solved by book editor extraordinaire Susan Ryeland (played by Lesley Manville) is entwined with a Golden Age murder mystery, solved by fictional detective Atticus Pünd (Tim McMullan). Horowitz adapted his own novels for the screen, and you can sense the fun he’s having as his detectives playfully connect across time.

Credit’s due to Manville for “Marble Hall Murders,” both the book and the television series, existing at all: Horowitz, in the acknowledgments at the end of the novel, notes that he hadn’t planned on writing a third Susan Ryeland book — until Manville said, at the end of shooting the previous installment (“Moonflower Murders,” which was preceded by “Magpie Murders”), that she’d love to do another. “In that moment, this book sparked into life,” he wrote. (It’s not as if we didn’t already have plenty for which to thank the great Manville; my favorites of her performances include “Another Year,” “Phantom Thread,” “Mrs. Harris Goes to Paris,” Princess Margaret in “The Crown” and all three installments of this series.)

SEE TV REVIEW ON B2



ILLUSTRATION BY KATTY HUERTAS/THE WASHINGTON POST; ISTOCK

For those who may feel forlorn, websites offer a forum for safe self-expression

Confidential love letters for everyone to see

BY GREY BATTLE

In 2023, Gabe Szeto and his girlfriend broke up. Regardless of his friends pushing him to move on, “I couldn’t get over her,” Szeto recalls. “I had to put my memory somewhere.” A year later, he built an online map of London, which he began populating with recollections of their relationship.

“we walked along the thames and came here after Eat Tokyo. it was just us. when someone mentions golden hour I still think about this time with you,” he wrote under the handle AMOU-Starry-Sky-001 in a post located at Hammersmith Bridge. “i still remember your eyes looking towards the sunset.”

Szeto intended to store memories of only him and his ex-girlfriend on the website, which he called A Map of Us. “It was just me and her, so the world was just two people,” he says. But soon Szeto zoomed out from London and wondered, “What would it look like if the entire world had memories?” More than 300,000 users have since joined him.

A Map of Us became one of many popular repositories, like Craigslist missed connections, PostSecret.com and the Unsent Project, brimming with digital love letters. According to Google Trends, searches for A Map of Us have nearly tripled over the past year. Meanwhile, volunteer moderators struggle to keep up with the volume of love letters received.

The oldest love letter appears on a clay tablet, dating to 2029 B.C. Such an enduring tradition was bound to appear online. But the letters on websites like Szeto’s are different from their predecessors — they are posted publicly by anonymous senders, occasionally addressed to a person by name.

On Craigslist missed connections, users write about an encounter with a stranger, capturing *un*

SEE LETTERS ON B3



GABE SZETO

A shadow of Gabe Szeto and his ex-girlfriend in 2023 at Hammersmith Bridge in London. He writes about the memory on A Map of Us.

‘By Any Means’ gives buddy genre a weighty tuneup

‘BY ANY MEANS’ FROM B1

ugly head.

“By Any Means” is one of those “based on true events” movies that gives the filmmakers the chance to have their nonfiction cake and eat it fictionally, too. While it might seem historically fanciful that J. Edgar Hoover’s FBI ever called in a hit man to hunt the KKK, Scarpa was a real guy, an FBI informant enlisted amid intense pressure to solve the murders of three civil rights workers in Mississippi. It’s his FBI buddy who never existed, a “composite,” as the press materials note.

So full credit to Abdul-Mateen, who has created a complex, charismatic character from thin air, taking his agent Wayne Strider on a slow-burn trip from all tucked-in, waiting-outside respectfully to car-chasing, gun-shooting revenge-fantasy hero.

Wahlberg, meanwhile, grips every external item we know of Scarpa and holds onto them for dear life: An ever-present toothpick in mouth, a prosthetic nose, a mop of ungainly hair, a white tank top, sunglasses even at night. Wahlberg has apparently re-

watched “The Sopranos” a lot.

The movie is buoyed by an amazing supporting cast, like the terrific Nicole Beharie as Strider’s wife, LisaGay Hamilton as a key witness and Giancarlo Esposito as Dahmer. The pastel costumes and bulging, chrome cars are gorgeous. The soundtrack features Nina Simone, Ray Charles, Dinah Washington, Curtis Mayfield, and an anthemic title jam by Diane Warren, performed by the Isley Brothers and David Kushner.

It’s the interaction between the hit man and the FBI agent that’s at the heart of the movie, along with the lingering question of whether violence can ever be a corrective. The Mafia guy’s methods — smashing skulls, breaking bones with a baseball bat, putting guns into mouths — stun his partner. And while the violence gets a bit excessive, it’s kind of thrilling to see gutless KKK members beaten to a bloody pulp over and over.

Scarpa is a fascinating alien in rural Mississippi, a slab of Italian American muscle who stands outside the racial divide. He’s just there to do a job, nothing more. But when asked what he’d do if he ever faced such racial animus, he replies: “I’d kill them all, every



ELI ADE/PARAMOUNT PICTURES/AP

Mark Wahlberg, left, and Yahya Abdul-Mateen II in “By Any Means,” a “based on true events” movie set in the civil rights era.

last one of them.”

Our FBI agent isn’t impressed. He despises his Mafia partner so much that, if forced to choose between him and the KKK, he knows which way he’d lean: “At least they believe in something.”

The tension between the two men boils over into a “48 Hrs.”-style, knock-down fistfight. At this point, the movie veers off the rails a bit, culminating in a very bloody conclusion. But that doesn’t dim the introduction of a

very effective new movie cop pairing — Abdul-Mateen and Wahlberg.

R. At area theaters. Contains violence/bloody images and pervasive language. 107 minutes.



ELEVENTH HOUR FILMS/MASTERPIECE

Lesley Manville returns as Susan Ryeland in the third season of “Marble Hall Murders” on PBS.

Acting in mystery is uniformly good

TV REVIEW FROM B1

This time around, Susan is starting life over again as a freelance editor in London, after breaking up with her Greek boyfriend and getting a smart new flat and a cat named Hugo. (Of course she still has her candy-apple red MG, the equivalent of a superhero’s cape.) She’s been asked to work on an Atticus Pünd continuation novel, “Pünd’s Last Case,” written by Eliot Crace (Jamie Blackley), the troubled grandson of a legendary children’s author (Patricia Hodge). The Crace family, however, turns out to have a multitude of dark secrets, entwining Susan in a web that stretches back to the events of “Maggie Murders” — and ultimately connecting her with Detective Inspector Ian Blakeney (Danny Sapani), a cop whose true ambition is to write detective stories.

Meanwhile, in “Pünd’s Last

Case,” the gentlemanly Hercule Poirot-ish detective travels to sunny Corfu, Greece, and gets caught up in a saga involving the mysterious death of a British matriarch (also played by Hodge) with her own complicated family ties, all the while facing his own mortality. A local police officer (Zubin Varla), noting that Pünd is paler than his linen summer suit, asks what’s wrong. “It’s final,” is all Pünd will say, softly; he’s a man quietly fading away.

“Marble Hall Murders” dances elegantly between these two stories, letting us find the parallels between them (note the double-casting, which often provides a hint) and occasionally overlapping. Sometimes Susan spots Pünd, quietly watching her; sometimes a sound seems to reverberate across the decades, as when Pünd hears a cat meow and it’s actually Susan’s Hugo. Note how the Pünd story is shot in less vivid colors, as if worn away a bit

by time, and how that story occasionally feels a little awkward, as if it’s written by a less skilled writer (as, indeed, it is; Eliot’s good, but he’s no Alan Conway).

And the acting, across the board, is top-notch: I particularly appreciated Hodge’s elegant hauteur, Sapani’s aged-in-oak voice and sly chemistry with Manville (I’d quite like a prequel about D.I. Blakeney, who seems like he has a lot of stories to tell), McMullan’s wistful wisdom and of course Manville’s uncanny way of making Susan seem to operate at an ever-so-slightly quicker speed than everyone else in the room. The series ends on an exquisitely poignant, fanciful note, as two characters meet once more across time, with mutual respect. Is it the end? I hope not; I’d follow these two anywhere.

Marble Hall Murders, Season 3 (6 episodes), premieres Sunday on PBS, with new episodes dropping weekly.

News of ‘Days of Thunder’ sequel revs up cameo dreams for drivers

BY STEVE REED
Associated Press

CHARLOTTE, N.C. — Joey Logano has won 71 NASCAR races and three Cup Series championships during his illustrious career.

But the driver of the No. 22 Penske Racing Ford said nothing would make him appear cooler in the eyes of his five children than securing a cameo in the upcoming sequel to “Days of Thunder,” which will star Tom Cruise and Anne Hathaway and is set for release in 2028.

“Yeah, are you kidding me — that’s like wicked cool dad points to be in ‘Days of Thunder,’” Logano said Wednesday at the NASCAR playoff media day.

Logano isn’t the only driver pushing for a role in the follow-up to the 1990 movie starring Cruise as fictional NASCAR driver Cole Trickle.

Chase Briscoe wants in, too.

“Absolutely, I would love to be,” Briscoe said. “I would think they are going to use some of the drivers. Maybe our car will just be in it, but I would love to be in there.”

Kyle Larson thinks it would be cool to be around while the movie is in production, but joked, “I’m not an actor, so I don’t want to make the film worse.”

Filming is scheduled to begin early next year.

Logano said he has watched “Days of Thunder” numerous times, often alongside his children, who love the movie.

NASCAR drivers Richard Petty, Rusty Wallace, Neil Bonnett and Harry Gant all appeared in “Days of Thunder,” so Logano is hopeful he might be able to pull some strings and get a small part in the sequel.

“Hopefully that happens,” Logano said with a laugh. “I wouldn’t say no, that’s for sure. Absolutely I’d do it.”

Cruise surprised drivers last

weekend when he showed up for the Cup Series race at Daytona International Speedway, emerging from a black Chevy Suburban and attending the drivers’ council meeting.

He and some of the screenwriters spoke to drivers and team owners to get a feel for their routines and how the sport has changed since the original movie’s debut 36 years ago.

“It was really neat,” Briscoe said. “All of a sudden, Tom Cruise walked in and none of us knew that was happening. And he’s just sitting there and talked with us for like 20, 25 minutes about his goal of what to do with the movie and how he wants to paint us out to be.”

Briscoe described Cruise as “super nice.”

Charlotte-based Hendrick Motorsports had an instrumental role in the first movie, helping build, prepare and repair the stock cars used during the production. Trickle’s primary car included a sponsorship from City Chevrolet, a real-life car dealer-

ship owned by Rick Hendrick.

It’s unclear at this point whether Hendrick Motorsports will be involved again, but Larson is hoping it works out.

There is a good chance it will.

Four-time Cup Series champion Jeff Gordon, now vice chairman at Hendrick Motorsports, openly lobbied for Cruise to make a “Days of Thunder” sequel. Over the years, Gordon and Cruise have developed a friendship, with Cruise showing up at a 2015 NASCAR banquet to honor the retiring Gordon.

Larson said meeting Cruise was cool, and he can’t wait to learn about the moviemaking process.

“He’s a celebrity like I’ve never met before in my life,” Larson said. “You could tell he was different from the rest of us, in a cool way, like really, really cool. He kind of already knows a little bit about us, so I thought that was neat.”

Mark Long in Jacksonville, Florida, contributed to this report.



MARK LONG/AP

Tom Cruise, left, and Jerry Bruckheimer at a drivers meeting before a NASCAR race last weekend in Daytona Beach, Florida.

the

GUIDE

to the Lively Arts

SHOW NAME	DATES & TIMES	DESCRIPTION	DETAILS	PRICE	ADDITIONAL
★ FEATURED LISTING ★					
 Global Rhythms: Music, Dance & Storytelling from Around the World	Saturday, September 5, 2026 12–6pm	A FREE showcase of music, dance, and storytelling, featuring headliner Zedicus playing World Music, Hungarian dancing & music, Irish dancing, Latin music, a short film from a Benin-based director, food trucks , and more!	Learn More: https://glenechopark.org/globalrhythms	FREE	Also browse the 55th annual Labor Day Art Show in the Park’s historic Spanish Ballroom.
THEATRE					
 GARBO The Actor Who Saved the World	Sept 3 - 27 Thurs- Sat at 8 pm Sun at 2 pm	An aspiring Catalan actor created a complex network of spies that fooled the Nazi regime to become one of history’s most brilliant double agents,	GALA Theatre 3333 14th Street NW 202- 234-7174 www.galatheatre.org	\$27 - \$57	In Spanish with English surtitles

The Guide to the Lively Arts appears: • Sunday in Arts & Style. deadline: Tues., 12 noon
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Virtual mailboxes for unsent letters

LETTERS FROM B1

coup de foudre in a few words. “Every post is its own small universe,” says Ilia Blinderman, 39. He analyzed 10,000 such posts, perhaps to understand his own failures to connect, he says. There was also a voyeuristic appeal of this Craigslist section, which combined with his background in psychological research, made the promise of a large dataset too tempting to ignore.

“If you have this expansive feeling in you,” Blinderman explains, “the only way of doing right by it is sending it off somewhere.” Across genders and sexualities, Blinderman found the most common phrase used is “eye contact.” Men post far more often than women do. Although when women post, their messages tend to be longer.

Blinderman posted a couple of missed connections himself: “Girl in blue/white floral dress on N train headed uptown at 9pm Monday” and “Cute brunette girl reading who shared my table at The Bean on Monday.” In some sense, Blinderman’s baring of his excitement about another person makes him vulnerable. But the recipient does not have to reply. They may not ever see it.

The transient nature of these missives are reminiscent of Haruki Murakami’s “On Seeing the 100% Perfect Girl One Beautiful April Morning.” In the short story, there exists a girl perfect for a boy, who is perfect for her. “Without a word they passed each other, disappearing into the crowd. Forever,” wrote Murakami. “A sad story, don’t you think?”

But the beauty of Craigslist missed connections, says Blinderman, is that “there is no mechanism that would make someone self-conscious.” Users are anonymous and do not receive comments on their posts. Unlike mainstream social media channels, which are growing more regimented, Blinderman describes missed connections as freeing.

Szeto built A Map of Us to avoid feeling exposed. “I wanted a way to reach out to someone,” Szeto, now 22, recalls thinking as he formulated the site. “They would know that it was written by me, and it was written for them.” At the same time, a user could retain plausible deniability. He adds, “You can always say that you didn’t write that message.”

Shifting romantic norms

Szeto explained that digital life has shifted romantic norms toward feigned apathy. A direct message to a romantic prospect is too forward, Szeto says, and puts him at risk of being ghosted. “The alternative is you go see them in person, and that’s a no-no,” he adds.

Jennie Rosier, a professor at James Madison University, studies the evolution of communication in romantic relationships. She says the line of thinking goes, “If I said it in-person, then I would be viewed as too much.” This too-muchness risks rejection.

“Gen Xers and millennials have long thought, ‘If you feel it, say it,’” Rosier says. But for Gen Z, this instinct is trumped by a fear of discomfort. She posits helicopter parents and technology may

have raised children less accustomed to distress. The result is a generation apt to manufacture an identity of hyper-independence, while keeping their desires for closeness a secret.

This desire is reinforced by romantic relationships that demand carelessness and punish kindness. Young people find themselves lost in “situationships,” undefined relationships that reflect calculated avoidance and shield a couple from the vulnerability that commitment requires. As Lisa Wade writes in “American Hookup,” neither men nor women feel “free to love” as they once did. The prevailing culture demands pretending uninterested in romance lest seeming desperate.

That said, rejections have yet to vanish. They just take on a different character for Gen Z, as Paul Eastwick, host of the “Love Factually” podcast and professor at the University of California at Davis, explains. “If somebody went about dating throughout their young life, mostly using online tools, they would probably have a sense of being anonymously rejected by many people,” Eastwick says.

“Without the online tools, if you’re going to be rejected, it’s more visceral because it’s face to face. But you also don’t feel like you’re being rejected by thousands.”

Safety in numbers

And yet online actions feel safer, according to Gabriel Rubin, a professor at Montclair State University who studies risk aversion. This is especially true on sites already full of letters; users are made to feel sheltered by the existence of a group.

In 2015, Frank Warren hoped to provide senders the same emotional safety. He started PostSecret, a project where senders would mail him postcards divulging their deepest secret. He promised anonymity, and it worked. More than a decade later, Warren is still receiving dozens of letters each week, unaddressed to anyone in particular. In total, he’s received more than 1 million postcards from around the world. He publishes them online at PostSecret.com.

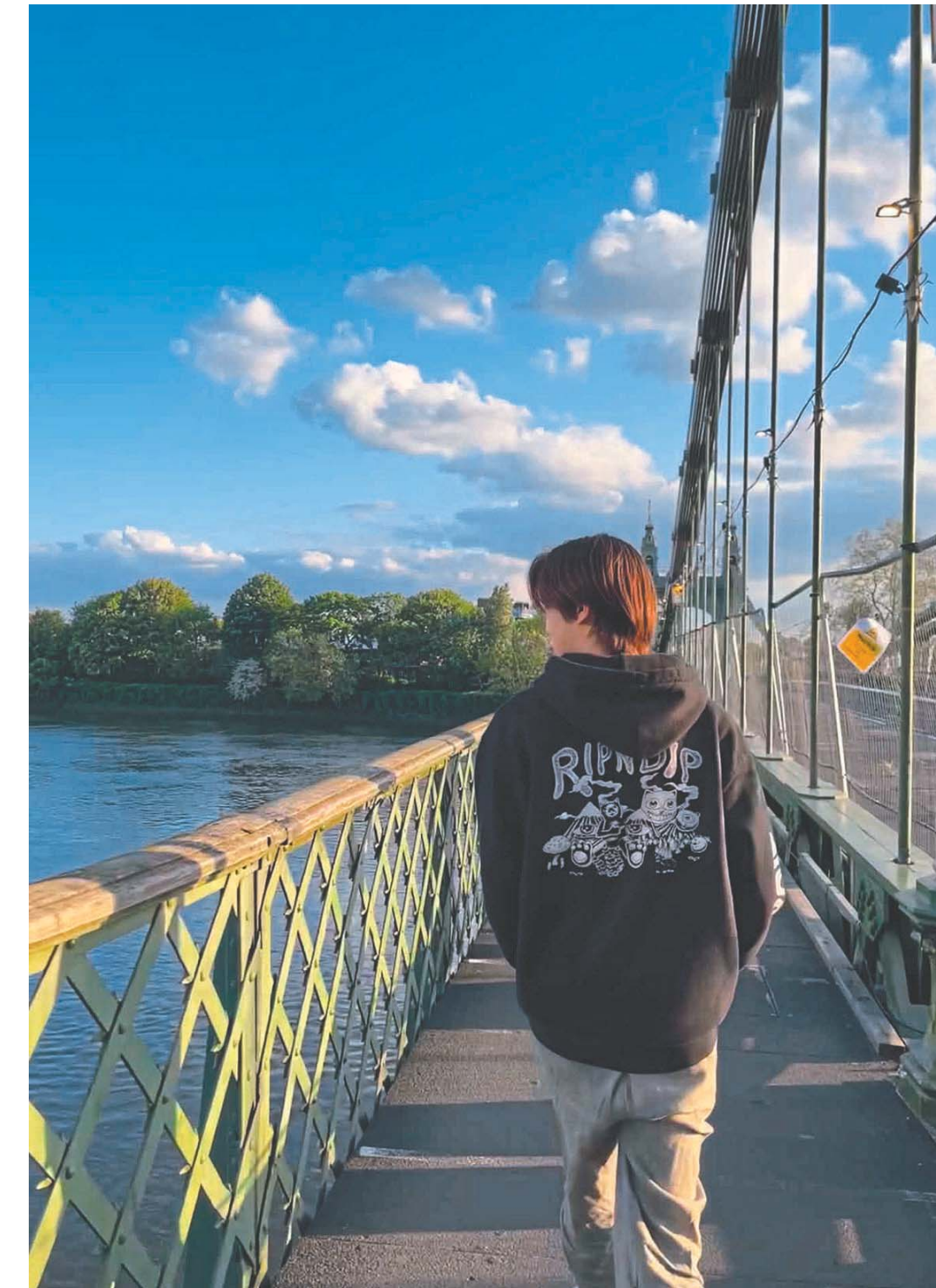
“When we think we’re keeping a secret, that secret’s actually keeping us. It could be because of embarrassment or shame, or stigma, or misunderstanding,” explains Warren, who adds that most secrets deal with intimacy and connection.

“By visiting the website, you can see so many secrets from strangers. You realize that no matter what your secret is, there’s somebody out there who’s carrying that same burden, too,” he continues. That alone, he says, can create a sense of liberation or, at the very least, relief.

Warren is also tasked with answering readers, who are convinced that a person they know sent a certain secret. Warren declines sharing the postmark on the back of the card. He tells them, “I advise you to imagine the postmark says whatever will make your life more interesting.”

Communication breakdown

It’s natural for readers to look for glimpses of themselves while perusing the internet’s love-filled



COURTESY OF GABE SZETO

postcards, missed connections, geotags and unsent letters.

Since it began in 2015, the Unsent Project has received 11 million submissions. According to founder Rora Blue, moderators approve an average of 7,000 submissions each week. Contributors can address their missives to a first or last name.

When Andrew Chan, a 27-year-old venture capitalist and content creator, came across the Unsent Project, he searched for his first name. “Andrew” pulled an overwhelming number of results, so he went for “Chan” next. “There were a couple that felt like a personal attack,” he says.

Some posts like, “I’m sorry for not communicating. I’m here if you would still have me” seemed spot-on to Chan. (Communication was one of his previous rela-

tionship’s challenges.) Others like, “Thank you for everything you did for me,” Chan remarks, are “vague, but hit just right.”

He says reading the letters is heartbreaking but, “You want to experience those emotions. You want to process them. You want to feel human.” On the Unsent Project, he could play out an alternate world, where his relationship went in the right direction.

At the same time, submitting posts to the site is a kind of letting go — a way “to take that emotion, process it, and release it into the world,” Chan says. He compared submitting posts to the emotional catharsis of slam poetry or speaking to deceased loved ones through a wind phone.

The irony, of course, is that many of these problems would be

“fixable if they were sent directly to a person,” Chan says.

“The world would be a lot better if everyone said what they needed to say,” agrees Szeto. “People are embarrassed. People are scared.”

Szeto holds that A Map Of Us was not about pining for his ex-girlfriend. “It was about me moving on, my memories, which just so happened to be with her,” he says.

But when he describes the memory he tagged to Hammersmith Bridge, he slips. A part of him hopes she visits A Map of Us, searches for the bridge and reads the letter he left. He says, “If this place did mean something to her, she would go back to this point. She would know that it was written for her, even if no one else in the world knows that it was me.”

Szeto walks on the Hammersmith Bridge in London. On his website A Map of Us, Szeto recalls a time on the bridge with his ex-girlfriend, and others across the world have added their memories to the site.

My daughter is upset that I’m not behaving like a ‘real’ mother of the bride



Carolyn Hax

Adapted from an online discussion.

Dear Carolyn: I accidentally hurt my daughter’s feelings and I want to make amends. “Lisa” is 24 and just got engaged. Personally, I think she’s a little young to settle down, but since I had her at 21, I’m not one to talk. And I like her fiancé, “John,” a lot and do think they’re a great couple, so it’s all good.

At a recent family gathering, Lisa announced to the whole family that she and John were getting married next year and told the story of the elaborate proposal he’d arranged. Later my sister asked me why I wasn’t more surprised and emotional, and I said they’d been discussing marriage for months and ring shopping, so there was nothing surprising about it. Lisa later told me she was devastated that I downplayed the very romantic proposal John had arranged for her and wished she had a “normal” mom who would be as excited as she was. I apologized, but Lisa still

seemed upset. Last night we talked it out and she asked me to be excited about her wedding and behave like a “real” mother of the bride. It’s true that I’m pretty laid-back about these sorts of things, probably because I’ve never been married or even interested in getting married. I love Lisa so much and am sorry she thinks I carped on her big announcement.

I’m paying for almost half the wedding but otherwise I’m not sure I can fake an 18-month interest in wedding details. What should I do?

— Not “Normal”

Not “Normal”: I think this is a fascinating question.

So Lisa would probably prefer a “real” advice columnist who tells you to rally for your daughter her way versus your own.

Of course I do encourage that, but only to the extent you can credibly and well, which is to say, if it feels true. And while there’s always some Lycra there — we can always learn something new about ourselves and others — you’re still you, and you will never thrill at the idea of mother-daughter facials. (Or will you?)



ILLUSTRATION BY NICK GALIFIANAKIS/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Who knows.)

So your first step is to go back to Lisa, now that some dust has settled, to say you love her, genuinely 100 percent truly are there for her, and want what is

best for her. And you think John is great and great for her (which can be true while you harbor your other, unspoken doubts). Say you never want her questioning these things about you. [This is where

you wait for her to nod or something.]

Then you point out that you can only be who you are. Which means if she wants a mother who gets genuine wedding fever (or, ugh, who fakes wedding fever for her benefit), then you will disappoint her. Possibly many times over before the I-dos are all done. Which is exactly the last thing you want for her!! So it breaks your heart that you let her down already. [Pause again for evidence of daughterly absorption.]

Then the message. Here is what you are proposing:

You will love her, and *how excited she is about this*. You will pay amply and, where it counts most, look for honest ways to be the mom she wishes you were. Maybe note here that if she has a few top priorities for your rallying, then this will set you up for success.

In return, you will ask her to behold the mother of the bride you actually are, and look for your love in what is real.

Some readers’ thoughts:

- I was that mom as well. Although happy for her and her choice of life partner, I didn’t

jump up and down and do cartwheels — that’s just not me. And then when she was planning her wedding, my kid took exception to everything I said or did, even slight facial movements or tone of my voice she deemed something negative. So I stayed neutral and in the background, and when asked for my opinion would give it, but not otherwise. Husband and I decided to give them a gift of cash they could use whatever way they chose (wedding, trip, whatever), and I would stay the heck out of my daughter’s way. And darn it if that didn’t work out just fine for all of us. Weddings can have weird effects on people. Deep breaths and it’s their upset, not yours.

- I’m planning a wedding right now and would KILL for my mom and my future mother-in-law to chill out even one iota. Will you adopt me?

Write to Carolyn Hax at tellme@washpost.com. Get her newsletter delivered to your inbox each morning at wapo.st/gethax.

Join the discussion live at noon Fridays at washingtonpost.com/live-chats.

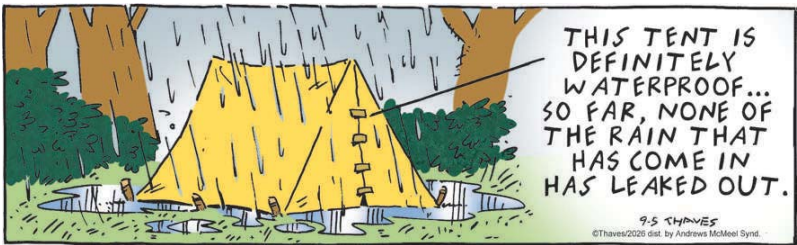
CLASSIC DOONESBURY



RED AND ROVER



FRANK AND ERNEST



CLASSIC PEANUTS



RHYMES WITH ORANGE



LIO



HAGAR THE HORRIBLE



BLONDIE



BREWSTER ROCKIT: SPACE GUY!



PEARLS BEFORE SWINE



PICKLES



AGNES



WUMO



CRABGRASS



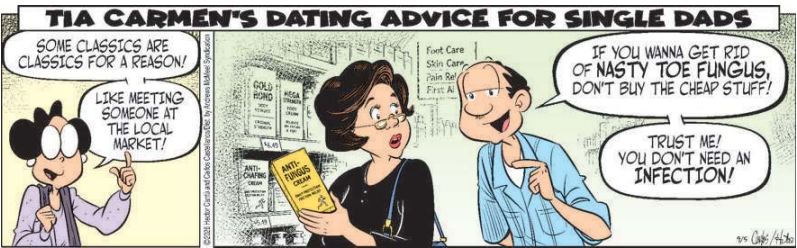
MARK TRAIL



MOTHER GOOSE & GRIMM



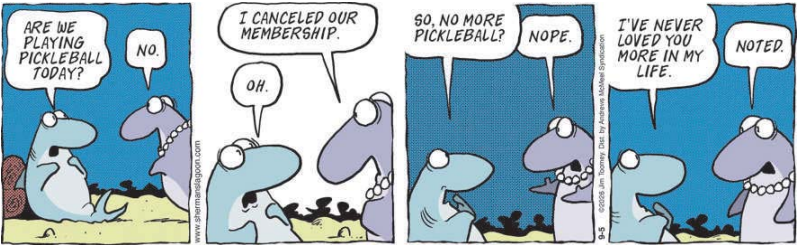
BALDO



SALLY FORTH



SHERMAN'S LAGOON



CURTIS



MUTTS

PATRICK McDONNELL

OOH, MILLIE... CANDLES... WINE...
SARDINES?... HEAVY CREAM?...
IT'S OUR ANNIVERSARY.
PURRR

ZITS

JERRY SCOTT & JIM BORGMAN

OKAY, MOM. HERE'S SOME MUSIC I PICKED OUT FOR YOUR WORKOUTS.
THANK YOU, JEREMY!
PROBLEM? I'D LIKE MY JACKSON BROWNE SONGS BACK, PLEASE.

HEART OF THE CITY

STEENZ

IT WAS GREAT TO MEET YOU, LIZ. I HAD AN AWESOME TIME.
MAYBE YOU CAN COME BACK AFTER YOU GET INTO THE SWING OF THINGS IN SEVENTH GRADE!
BY THEN I'LL HAVE TROPHIES FROM TRACK, AND I'LL HAVE RUN A YOUTH VERSION OF "HADESTOWN" AT MY SCHOOL THEATER.
AMBITIOUS! I LIKE IT!
AND SHE GETS IT ALL FROM ME.

JUDGE PARKER

FRANCESCO MARCIULIANO & MIKE MANLEY

CHARLOTTE, YOUR MOM IS HERE.
HEY, SWEETIE.
HELLO.
MARCIULIANO + MANLEY 9/5
I LOVE YOUR DRAWINGS. DO YOU MIND IF I SIT DOWN?

FRAZZ

JEFF MALLETT

SUMMER'S OVER. PRETTY SOON LEAVES ARE GOING TO START FALLING.
WHICH IS A LOT BETTER THAN BEING WHERE IT'S HURRICANE SEASON.
WHICH SHOULD MAKE ME FEEL BETTER BUT IT DOESN'T.
THE FACT THAT IT DOESN'T MAKE YOU FEEL BETTER SHOULD MAKE YOU FEEL PRETTY GOOD.

SIX CHIX

BANNERMAN, XUNISE, KONAR, LAWTON, PATRINOS & PIRO

What I wear to kindergarten on the first day could define my whole school career! I must choose carefully!
Can we be besties?
Are you a celebrity?
I hope you're in my class!
She's so cool!
Nailed it!
ELEMENTARY SCHOOL ENTRANCE

GARFIELD

JIM DAVIS

BACK ON THE FARM...
DOC BOY AND I USED TO PLAY A GAME
"NAME THAT BARN SMELL"
LET'S HEAR IT FOR THE CITY LIFE

BARNEY AND CLYDE

WEINGARTENS & CLARK

The Consumer Products Safety Commission sent us this notice.
It's a product recall.
Which product? You.
It's a "Park Outside" notice for you as a fire hazard.
But a simple software upgrade is available. Until then, you know what this means.
I protest the indignity of this display. On the bright side, you're a dangerous dog for the first time.

DUSTIN

STEVE KELLEY & JEFF PARKER

MR. K., YOU EVER TAKE A SELFIE?
OH, SURE... I DO THEM ALL THE TIME.
REALLY? THAT DOESN'T SOUND LIKE YOU.
IT'S MOSTLY BY ACCIDENT.

FLASH GORDON

DAN SCHKADE

CAN'T WE TAKE YOU SOMEWHERE, HOLLO?
DO YOU HAVE ANY FAMILYS?
THEY WOULDN'T RUN-RECOGNIZE ME NOW.
I-I'M NOT WHO THEY KNEW.
I'M SUN-SOMETHING ELSE.
SOMETHING I'M MAKING.
RUN-GOOD LUCK, FLASH GORDON.
SORRY TO LURK.
THAT SEEMED KIND OF SPECIAL AND I DIDN'T WANT TO INTERRUPT.
HEY, MISS MET.

PRICKLY CITY

MARSHALL RAMSEY

THERE'S A MOVIE OUT NOW CALLED "COYOTE VS. ACME." IS THE COYOTE RELATED?
MOM SAID HE MIGHT BE A DISTANT COUSIN.
WHY DON'T YOU CHASE ROADRUNNERS?
I KNOW HOW TO ORDER PIZZA, AND I'M NOT OBSESSED WITH FAILURE.
WHAT ABOUT YOUR OBSESSION WITH FLYING? THAT'S DIFFERENT.
HOW?
I PLEAD THE FIFTH.

LOOSE PARTS

DAVE BLAZEK

THOUGH THEY SHOULD BE ALLIES, MOST SMOKEJUMPERS LOOK ASKANCE AT THE SMOKESKIPERS

NON SEQUITUR

WILEY

YOU CAN'T JUST SAY CHECKMATE LIKE EVERYONE ELSE, CAN YOU, CHESTER...
ANOTHER DAY AT THE PENTAGON RETIREMENT HOME

BABY BLUES

RICK KIRKMAN & JERRY SCOTT

TOUGH DAY? YOU HAVE NO IDEA.
AAUGH! BEING A PARENT IS SO FRUSTRATING AND EXHAUSTING!
BUT YOU'D DO IT ALL OVER AGAIN.
IN A HEARTBEAT.

WALLACE THE BRAVE

WILL HENRY

SPUD! YOU MADE IT!
HA! SWEET FREEDOM!
AND ALL IT TOOK WAS A LITTLE HELP FROM AN OLD FRIEND!
THE UNSTOPPABLE TEAM! SPUD AND WALLACE! UNDEFEATED!
OH, I WASN'T TALKIN' ABOUT YOU. IT WAS GARY, HE'S BACK.
I WAS WONDERIN' WHY YOU SMELL LIKE GARBAGE.
YOU ARE WHAT YOU EAT

SPEED BUMP

DAVE COVERLY

WE'RE TOO LATE - HE'S ALREADY WATCHING POTTY TRAINING TUTORIALS ON YOUTUBE.

ON THE FASTTRACK

BILL HOLBROOK

PHONE'S RECHARGED.
I NEVER LET MINE GET LOW.

FAMILY CIRCUS

BIL KEANE

I DON'T HAVE ALL THE ANSWERS, BUT I DO HAVE SOME QUESTIONING.

BEETLE BAILEY

GREG, BRIAN & NEAL WALKER

DO YOU SEE WHAT'S GOING ON OUT THERE?
I DO...
THEY'RE CANOE-DING

REPLY ALL LITE

DONNA A. LEWIS

I tell all my favorite clients that they're my favorite in their particular category.

TELEVISION

	9/5/26	7:00	7:30	8:00	8:30	9:00	9:30	10:00	10:30	11:00		
4.1 WRC (NBC)		• Big Ten	• College Football	Western Michigan at Michigan (Live)						• NEWS..		
4.2 WRC (IND)		Munsters	Munsters	Movie: Columbo: Prescription: Murder (1968)				Columbo				
5.1 WTTG (Fox)		• MLB Baseball	New York Yankees at San Diego Padres (Live)									
7.1 WJLA (ABC)		• Football	• College Football	Clemson at LSU (Live)								
9.1 WUSA (CBS)		• Postga...	• Abich	• Harlan	• 48 Hours					• 48 Hours		
14.1 WFDC (UNI)		(6:30) • Fútbol	Querétaro vs. Monterrey (Live)			(6:30) • Fútbol Mexicano	América vs. Tijuana (Live)					
20.1 WDCA (MNTV)		• College Football	Edward Waters at Jackson State (Live)						• Family	• Extra		
22.1 WMPT (PBS)		• Calvin Tyler	• Foyle's War				• Surviving	• Wardrobe	• Austin			
26.1 WETA (PBS)		• Experience	• Frontline					• Billy the Kid	• Made			
32.1 WHUT (PBS)		• Black Fire Doc	• Here	• Price	• World on Fire			• Patience	• BlackFire			
50.1 WDCW (CW)		(6:30) • N..	• NASCAR O'Reilly Auto Parts Series					Fleetio 200 (Live)				
66.1 WPXW (ION)		(6:30) • NWSL Soccer	• NWSLP..		• Law & Order: SVU		• Law & Order: SVU			• Law-SVU		
A&E		Storage Wars		Storage Wars		Storage Wars		Storage Wars		Storage		
AMC		(5:00) Movie: The Fugitive ★★★ (1993)		Movie: Men in Black ★★★ (1997) A veteran and a rookie track aliens on Earth.						Movie: Men in Black II ★★		
Animal Planet		Dr. Jeff: RMV	Dr. Jeff: RMV		Dr. Jeff: RMV		Dr. Dee: Alaska Vet		Dr. Dee			
BET		The Equalizer	The Equalizer		Movie: Kill Bill: Vol. 1 ★★★ (2003)							
Bravo		Movie: Titanic ★★★★★ (1997) Two lovers fall in love on the maiden voyage of the Titanic.									Below Deck	
Cartoon Network		Burgers	Family Guy	Family Guy	Family Guy	Family Guy	Family Guy	Family Guy	Rick Morty	Rick Morty		
CNN		CNN Newsroom		Decades In 1990s		Decades In 1980s		Decades In 1970s		DecadesIn		
Comedy Central		(6:30) Movie: Waterboy (1998)		Movie: 21 Jump Street ★★★ (2012)							Movie	
Discovery		Expedition Unknown		Expedition Unknown			Expedition Unknown			Expedition		
Disney		(6:30) Movie: Cars 2 ★★ (2011)		(:25) Movie: Cars 3 ★★ (2017)						Ladybug		
E!		Movie	(:40) Movie: Horrible Bosses ★★ (2011)			(:35) Movie: Horrible Bosses 2 ★★ (2014)						
ESPN		College Football Missouri State at Texas A&M (Live)						Scorebo-ard (Live)	Football UCLA at California (Live)			
ESPN2		2026 US Open Tennis Men's & Women's Third Round (Live)									30 for 30	
Food Network		Diners	Diners	Diners	Diners	Diners	Diners	Diners	Diners	Diners		
Fox News		Weekend (Live)		Life, Liberty (Live)		My View With (Live)		Saturday Night (Live)		Gutfeld!		
Freeform		(5:45) Movie: P... (1991)	(:50) Movie: Beauty and the Beast ★★★★★				(:50) Movie: Aladdin ★★ (1992) A genie helps Baghdad thief and princess.					
FX		(6:00) Movie: Star Wars: A New Hope ★★★★★ (1977)				Movie: Star Wars: The Empire Strikes Back ★★★★★ (1980)						
Hallmark		(6:00) Movie: Missing the Boat (2026)		Movie: Haunted Harmony Mysteries: Prelude to a Wedding (2026) (P)				Movie: Love Finds You (2026)				
Hallmark M&M		(6:00) Emma Fielding Mysteries		Emma Fielding Mysteries				Murder, She Wrote		Murder ...		
HBO		(5:50) Movie: Blue Beetle ★★ (2023)		Movie: Fuze ★★ (2025) (P)			(:40) Lanterns		(:35) Conan O'	(:20) Movie: Z...		
HGTV		Hunters	Hunters	Hunters	Hunters	Hunters	Hunters	Hunters	Hunters	Hunters		
History		The UnXplained		The UnXplained		The UnXplained		(:05) The UnXplained				
Lifetime		(6:00) Movie: Abducted Off the Street: Carles...		Movie: Surviving the Silence: The Roxane Gay Story (2026) (P)				(:05) Movie: I Am Mary Jo Buttafuoco (2026)				
MASN		Baseball Boston Red Sox at Baltimore Orioles (Live)				O's Xtra		Wall to Wall Baseball				
Monumental		Caps Classics		Caps		Hometown		BeyondT... Mystics				
MSNBC		The Weekend				Connect With		Crooked on MS NOW				
MTV		Movie: Just Go With It ★★ (2011)				(:45) Movie: Pitch Perfect ★★ (2012)						
Nat'l Geographic		To Catch a Smuggler		To Catch a Smuggler		Catch a Smugler		Contraband Capture				
Nickelodeon		Movie: Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince ★★ (2009)					Big Bang					
NWSN		Batya		NewsNation (Live)		NewsNation (Live)		NewsNation (Live)				
Paramount		(6:35) Yellowst.	(:40) Yellowstone		(:40) Yellowstone		(:50) Yellowstone					
Paramount+Sho		(6:05) Movie: Dunkirk ★★ (2017)		Movie: Godzilla ★★ (2014) Godzilla and his malevolent foes battle for supremacy.				(:05) Movie: 300 ★★ (2007)				
Syfy		(5:30) Movie: The Mask ★★ (1994)		Movie: The Goonies ★★ (1985) Young misfits find a 17th-century pirate's treasure map.				Movie: The Mask ★★ (1994)				
TBS		(5:30) Movie: Blended...		Movie: Practical Magic ★★ (1998) (P)				Movie: Father of the Bride (1991)				
TCM		(6:00) Movie: A Little Romance (1979)		Movie: Fat City ★★ (1972) A washed-up prizefighter tries to make a comeback.				Movie: Inside Moves ★★ (1980)				
TLC		Double Lives		Double Lives		Double Lives		Last Resort		90 Day		
TNT		(4:00) Movie: Lord of the Rings: Fellowship of t...		All Elite Wrestling: Collision Countdown to All-In London 2026				Movie: The Accountant ★★ (2016)				
Travel		Ghost Adventures		Ghost Adventures		Ghost Adventures		Ghost Adventures		Ghost Adv		
truTV		(6:00) Movie: Central L...		Movie: Ocean's Twelve ★★ (2004)						Movie: Suicide Squa...		
TV Land		Seinfeld	Seinfeld	Seinfeld	Seinfeld	Seinfeld	Seinfeld	Seinfeld	Seinfeld	Seinfeld		
TV One		GoodTimes	GoodTimes	GoodTimes	GoodTimes	GoodTimes	GoodTim...	GoodTim...	GoodTim...	GoodTim...		
USA Network		(6:00) College Football		Wyoming at Colorado State (Live)				Football Portland State at San Diego State				
VH1		(5:30) Movie: New Jac...		Movie: I Know What You Did Last Summer ★★ (1997)						Movie: Last Night in ...		
WNC8		Abich	WorldNe..	20/20		WJLANe..		WJLANews		Attkisson		
LEGEND: Bold indicates new or live programs ♦ High Definition Movie Ratings (from TMS) ★★★★★ Excellent ★★★ Good ★★ Fair ★★ Poor No stars: not rated												

BIRTHDAY | SEPTEMBER 5:
You're concerned with the happiness of others. You're empathetic, generous and imaginative. This is a year of service, perhaps service to family. Therefore, take care of yourself so that you can be a support to others when they turn to you for guidance, comfort, solace and courage.

MOON ALERT: Avoid shopping (except for food and gas) and important decisions from 4:30 a.m. to 11 a.m. today. After that, the Moon moves from Gemini into Cancer.

ARIES
(March 21-April 19)
Today you're more sensitive about home and family, and might feel hurt if someone makes a disparaging remark. Conversations might be confusing. Someone might make an assumption. Don't agree to anything important today. Just kick back and relax.

TAURUS
(April 20-May 20)
Your imagination is activated today, which is great for those of you who are involved with artistic projects. Many of you might spend time daydreaming today or being lost in a fantasy world. In the real world, make an effort to clarify communications, because it's a "fuzzy" day!

GEMINI
(May 21-June 20)
Conversations with friends as well as groups and organizations might be a tad confusing today. You might be dealing with someone's idealism. Or perhaps you are the idealist that confounds someone else. Keep things light. This is a playful, fun-loving day.

CANCER
(June 21-July 22)
Today the Moon is in your sign at odds with fuzzy Neptune, which can induce a dreamy state of mind. It can also lend to bad decisions that require clear thinking. It might distort your view of things. Be mindful of excess today.

LEO
(July 23-Aug. 22)
Although your primary focus is on money, cash flow and your assets right now, today you might be caught up in mystical ideas or spiritual pursuits. If so, be aware that you're in a suggestible frame of mind. Things might not be as they appear. Tread carefully.

VIRGO
(Aug. 23-Sept. 22)
You are basically strong and grounded today because both the Sun and your ruler Mercury are in your sign. Nevertheless, the placement of the Moon might create confusion in your discussion with friends and groups. You might assume something or you might be misunderstood. Double-check your communications.

LIBRA
(Sept. 23-Oct. 22)
There is a curious astrological combo taking place today. In one way, you want to hide and be low-key. This is because of the placement of the Sun. But in another way, you are high-viz, whether you like it or not. (In fact, some people know personal details about your private life.) This is because of the placement of the Moon.

SCORPIO
(Oct. 23-Nov. 21)
This is a feel-good day for you! If you can travel that would be perfect because you want some adventure, something different. Go someplace

you've never been before, even if it's in your own neighborhood. Do something curious or stimulating. Younger people will interest you.

SAGITTARIUS
(Nov. 22-Dec. 21)
This is a poor day to make important financial decisions about shared property, taxes, debt, mortgages or anything jointly owned with someone else. Confusion, assumptions, misinterpretations and even deceit are possible. Postpone important financial decisions for another day.

CAPRICORN
(Dec. 22-Jan. 19)
Tread carefully today, because the Moon is opposite your sign, which is a bit challenging. Generally speaking, it means you have to go more than halfway when you're dealing with others. You have to be accommodating. Furthermore, an element of confusion exists today. Be aware.

AQUARIUS
(Jan. 20-Feb. 18)
You'll be smart to double-check your work in your job today, because confusion and misunderstandings can lead to problems. Assume nothing. Clarify all your instructions. Incidentally, this same advice will apply to your health.

PISCES
(Feb. 19-March 20)
This is a tricky day for romance. You or your partner might over idealize something. You might be disappointed because of unexpressed expectations. You might be disappointed because you had unrealistic expectations. Perhaps there's a plain old misunderstanding.

— *Georgia Nicols*
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BRIDGE

N-S VULNERABLE

NORTH

♠ J10 9
♥ 7 3
♦ K Q10 9 5
♣ 7 6 3

EAST

♠ 7
♥ J9 8 4 2
♦ A 8 7 6 4
♣ J 9

SOUTH (D)

♠ A Q 4 3
♥ A K 6
♦ J 3
♣ A Q 5 2

The bidding:

SOUTH

2 NT

Pass

Opening lead — ♠ 5

WEST

3 NT

All Pass

NORTH

Pass

EAST

All Pass

“Do you think all tricks are equal?” Cy the Cynic asked me.

“If you’re at 3NT and need nine tricks,” I shrugged, “it won’t matter whether you win the first nine or the last nine. Actually, it’s a saying that ‘a good player loses four tricks early, a poor player loses five tricks late.’”

“I think not,” said Cy. “All tricks are equal, but some are more equal than others — especially Trick One.”

Today’s West led a spade against 3NT, and dummy’s jack won. Declarer led a diamond to his jack and back to dummy’s king. East took the ace and shifted to a heart.

South won and tried leading the queen of spades, but West played low. Then South never saw dummy’s high diamonds and was lucky to go down only one.

Cy is right that the play to the first trick can be crucial, and South’s was expensive. He should win with the queen of spades. After he forces out the ace of diamonds, he can

SUDOKU

Complete the grid so that every row, column and 3x3 box contains every digit from 1 to 9 inclusively.

871369

951678

136758

395671

865371

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆★★

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PREVIOUS SUDOKU SOLUTION

8	4	3	5	6	9	2	7	1
7	2	9	4	3	1	5	6	8
5	1	6	2	7	8	4	9	3
6	9	5	1	8	2	3	4	7
1	7	4	9	5	3	8	2	6
3	8	2	6	4	7	9	1	5
2	5	1	3	9	6	7	8	4
9	3	7	8	1	4	6	5	2
4	6	8	7	2	5	1	3	9

SCRABBLE GRAMS

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A1E1T1C3N1L1C3

2nd Letter Triple

E1E1I1Y4K5P3N1

Double Word Score

I1O1O1Y4G2L1B3

Double Word Score

A1O1O1L1R1T1B3

Double Word Score

PAR SCORE 150-160

BEST SCORE 217

FOUR RACK TOTAL

TIME LIMIT: 20 MIN

DIRECTIONS: Make a 2- to 7-letter word from the letters in each row. Add points of each word, using scoring directions at right. Finally, 7-letter words get 50-point bonus. "Blanks" used as any letter have no point value. All the words are in the Official SCRABBLE® Players Dictionary, 5th Edition. SOLUTION: TOMORROW

For more information on tournaments and clubs, email NASPA - North American SCRABBLE Players Association info@scrabbleplayers.org. Visit our website - www.scrabbleplayers.org. For puzzle inquiries contact scrgams@gmail.com

09-05

PREVIOUS SCRABBLEGRAMS SOLUTION

P3O1T1H4O1L1E1

RACK 1 = 64

A1I1H1W4A1R1T1

RACK 2 = 76

T1A1B1U1L1A1R1

RACK 3 = 59

D2A1M1A1G1E1

RACK 4 = 10

PAR SCORE 145-155

TOTAL 209

JUMBLE CROSSWORDS™

by David L. Hoyt 9-5-26

CLUE ACROSS

1. ___ seed

5. Anderson

6. Educate

7. Joint

CLUE DOWN

1. Clever plan

2. Lengthen

3. London district

4. Veered

ANSWER

ESASEM

RYHRA

NTAIR

DAESRH

ANSWER

HCEMES

ETHTRCS

RYAIAFM

ETDUNR

DOUBLE BONUS

The circled letters can be unscrambled to form two different, 5-LETTER answers.

CLUE: Proof of a fact or quality

CLUE: Declaration

How to play: Complete the crossword puzzle by looking at the clues and unscrambling the answers. When the puzzle is complete, unscramble the circled letters to solve the Bonus.

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LA TIMES CROSSWORD

By Matthew Luter

ACROSS

1 Nowhere near

5 Allegro

10 Improvise

14 Podcaster's software option

16 Cricket field shape

17 Conversion that some pray will be successful?

18 Work with Python, say

19 Arise

20 Retraced one's steps, in a way

21 Light touch

24 Hybrid punctuation mark

26 Unsure where to go

28 Logical start

29 Jane in a suit?

30 Pantheon honoree

31 Cereal with a vanilla-flavored Confetti version

34 Back up

35 Kleptocracy ruler

36 "The Mystery at Lilac Inn" sleuth

38 Setting of Frank McCourt's "Angela's Ashes"

40 Hermitlike

41 Wanders in an airport?

42 Sportscaster Patrick

43 Words of warning

44 Absolute noob

48 Steered

49 Pretty penny or bad penny

50 Collection of highlights, perhaps

52 Dreamcast maker

53 Help line?

57 Kathryn of "WandaVision"

58 Strong desire for one in search of just desserts?

59 Secondary social media accounts

60 Pernod flavor

61 Headphones maker based in Milwaukee

DOWN

1 Actuarial stat

2 Quaint transmission

3 Word with pop or op

4 Like an Inverted Jenny stamp

5 Turn sharply to the right?

6 "Cancel the launch!"

7 2025 WNBA Rookie of the Year Bueckers

8 Something that may be on display while playing D&D

9 "Silent Spring" subj.

10 Informal lexicon

11 Vegetarian sushi option

12 Beggared belief

13 Fundraising promise

15 Turn into a competition, say

20 Subpar

21 Trampoline park gear

22 "We agreed on this!"

23 Bar exam setting?

25 Utah's Capitol National Park

27 Article

31 Neighborhood that may contain a paifang

32 Minute Maid brand

33 Unserious

35 Mine wagon

37 Intruder from under the surface

39 Semisoft cheese

40 Halt

41 Country star Yearwood

43 Showed up at dinner?

45 Zen riddles

46 "The Wrestler" Oscar nominee

47 Light blades

51 Alcove

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FRIDAY'S LA TIMES SOLUTION

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ANALYSIS

Nationals' historically bad bullpen demands fix

Front office neglected relief corps, and club has paid the price this season

BY DANIELLE ALLENTUCK

The Washington Nationals have offered plenty of hope that they are on the right track this season, but one area has stuck out like a sore thumb: the bullpen.

With 20 games left in the season, before the opener of a three-game road series against the Los Angeles Dodgers late Friday night, the Nationals have blown 35 saves. That's two away from tying the MLB record set by the 121-loss Chicago White Sox in 2024.

The Nationals set themselves up for this, knowingly, by not investing in the bullpen in the offseason. Instead, they poured money into technology, bringing the organization up to the same level as the rest of the league, and into their coaching and player development staff. Those investments have paid off as the Nationals surpassed their 2025 win total.

They did so, in part, because they did not expect to be as competitive as they were this season. The bullpen is typically the last thing a team invests in before truly starting to go for it.

But by not making any additions, the Nationals entered the season without a closer. The one signing, Cionel Pérez, was a minor league deal and he was gone by the first week of May.

There have been so many devastating losses at the hands of the bullpen. There was the June disaster in San Francisco, when Gus Varland, Paxton Schultz, Orlando Ribalta and Mitchell Parker combined to give up 10 runs in two innings to erase an eight-run lead. The Giants won on a walk-off grand slam.

There was also the three-game stretch at home against the Philadelphia Phillies, when Manager Blake Butera stuck with traditional matchups one day, went against analytics another and then tried not using the bullpen at all. All three tactics failed — without the talent, there is only so much that strategy can overcome.

That's how the Nationals got to this moment. The bigger question is how they solve it.

The easiest answer: signing top free agents this winter or acquiring relievers via trades. President of baseball operations Paul Toboni would not comment on the financial flexibility he'll have this offseason. It could (key word there) help that, while the Nationals still have deferred payments to Stephen Strasburg due until 2029, the majority of his seven-year, \$245 million contract will be off the books after this season.

When it comes to position players, the Nationals should be set. That should allow them to focus their money on starting pitching

SEE NATS ON B9

Nationals at Dodgers

9:10 p.m., Nationals.TV



Diamond dogs



HANNAH FOSLIEN/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

TOP: Shortstop Nasim Nuñez takes time out to greet Natty, the Nationals' team dog, with some pets before a home game in July. **ABOVE:** Nationals broadcaster Alexa Datt, left, and trainer Jacqueline Cheshire 'interview' Natty.

In search of clicks and revenue, MLB teams are turning to their furriest employees

BY NOAH WHITE

Just over a week before the trade deadline, the morning the Washington Nationals acquired Connelly Early, the team's president of baseball operations, Paul Toboni, fielded questions in the home dugout at Nationals Park.

The crowd was extensive that Sunday morning, surrounding him in every direction. There was a light buzz as the few reporters already at work for a game more than three hours away peppered him with questions.

Then came the scream. "Natty!"

It was more of a cheer — the overjoyed type a third grader might unleash after seeing their best friend for the first time since the weekend. Except it was infielder Nasim Nuñez doing the yelling. And this greeting included him rubbing his bestie's stomach. And then throwing a ball and holding a chew toy, all while carrying on a one-sided conversation.

Nuñez will tell you the Nationals' new team dog, Natty, a 6-month-old Labrador retriever mix, is, without a doubt, his "bestie." So how did this happen?

Let's start with the job title. This spring, Washington hired a dog.

Whether Natty counts toward the luxury tax is still up for debate. He's taking his salary, seemingly, in treats and baseball stadium dirt, which he samples from time to time. When he's not watering the ballpark grass or gnawing on pebbles, though, he has a job. As the Nationals' "team dog," he spends time greeting fans around the stadium. He's a social content machine, operating (stick with us) X and Instagram accounts with a combined 23,000 followers. There, he promotes the Nationals with poor spelling and inconsistent capitalization. Some of his best work to date came when

SEE BASEBALL DOGS ON B11

U.S. OPEN

Smoke doesn't waylay top seed

SABALENKA WINS IN STRAIGHT SETS

Williams sisters tumble in return to doubles

BY BRIAN MAHONEY
Associated Press

NEW YORK — Aryna Sabalenka was finally challenged at the U.S. Open — by her opponent and by the smell of marijuana. Jessica Pegula was tested as well.

Both players overcame their troubles to reach the fourth round and keep alive the chances of a third straight meeting on the final weekend.

Sabalanka beat Kamilla Rakhimova, 6-3, 6-4, on Friday. The No. 1 seed was pushed in a second set that lasted 54 minutes — a minute longer than her entire previous match.

"She played incredible tennis," Sabalenka said. "She really pushed me so hard in the second set and I love when they bring their best tennis because they really push me to improve."

Trying to become the first player to win three straight U.S. Open titles since Serena Williams from 2012-14, Sabalenka will face Taylor Townsend in the round of 16.

Two-time champion Carlos Alcaraz returned to the round of 16 by beating Wu Yibing, 6-3, 6-4, 6-1. Back for this tournament after missing four months because of a right wrist injury, Alcaraz will face No. 20 seed Tommy Paul, who edged No. 15 Alexander Bublik in five sets.

"To be honest I'm better than I thought," Alcaraz said.

The No. 2-seed Alcaraz played with Williams in mixed doubles, where they lost in the quarterfinals. He was hoping to watch her team up with Venus again following his victory.

"I think there is no better plan, you know, to watch the doubles, the Williamses, once again, while getting a treatment," he said. "I'm going to be ready for that."

Sabalenka was serving in the third game of her match in Louis Armstrong Stadium when she tossed the ball but then let it fall to the court. She did the same thing on the next point, with something clearly bothering her.

She then approached the chair umpire to ask for help because she smelled marijuana.

"I was like, guys, you can do whatever, you can smoke whatever, you can relax as much as you can, but please, to not do it around the tennis courts," Sabalenka said, when asked what she was thinking at the time. "It's a bit tricky to handle that smell while you're trying to compete at your best."

Pegula, the No. 3 seed, fought

SEE U.S. OPEN ON B11

U.S. Open, third round

11 a.m., ESPN2; 7 p.m., ESPN2

A sense of urgency greets Terrapins

BY EDWARD LEE
Baltimore Sun

Maryland sophomore quarterback Malik Washington rushed from a course in communications on campus to speak at a media availability Tuesday afternoon before the team's season opener against Hampton on Saturday at 8 p.m. at SECU Stadium.

A similar urgency lingers over the Terps as they embark on what is shaping up to be a watershed moment. After frustrating back-to-back 4-8 seasons, their results this fall could determine whether Coach Michael Locksley and his roster construction remain at least a little longer, or whether his time runs out.

That quest begins Saturday against the Pirates, who opened with a 45-0 drubbing of Virginia-Lynchburg. In the first meeting

On eve of season opener, Locksley faces a potential make-or-break campaign

between the programs, Maryland is favored by 4½ points.

Winning by that margin might reinvigorate a lethargic fan-base, but that doesn't matter to Locksley.

"Style points don't matter," he said flatly.

Locksley is probably right, as few people will remember Saturday's margin of victory by the end of the season. But a thorough, convincing win could change outside perceptions of the Terps, who were voted to finish 15th in the unofficial 18-team Big Ten preseason poll compiled by the media.

Locksley said he has three greater priorities on his mind. He said he wants to establish a ground game that ranked last in the conference in rushing yards (1,252) and second-to-last in touchdowns (nine) last season, keep the players from making undisciplined penalties, and execute on offense, defense and special teams.

"And if you do those things, all that other stuff takes care of itself," he said. "So I don't get into how we win. I get into the process, and the habits that it takes to win, and that's where we'll lie. The more we work, the more ritual it will become because those habits in creating them are the work we have to do,

SEE TERPS ON B9

Hampton at Maryland

8 p.m., Big Ten Network

Franklin, Hokies focus on the process

BY DAMIEN SORDELETT
Roanoke Times

BLACKSBURG, VA. — Benji Gosnell hasn't forgotten what happened the previous time Virginia Tech entered a college football season with plenty of hype surrounding the program.

It was two seasons ago. That 2024 team, filled to the brim with returning production, was hailed as an ACC contender and potential candidate to reach the College Football Playoff.

Expectations were undoubtedly lofty for a program that was relishing being back in the limelight.

Gosnell hears the same things again leading up to his fifth season with the Hokies. James Franklin's arrival has brought renewed expectations. Analysts are projecting an immediate improvement from last season's 3-9

Players look to block out preseason hype while new coach builds culture

record based on Franklin's past results at Vanderbilt and Penn State.

What Gosnell and 36 of his teammates from the 2024 team remember is failing to live up to the preseason expectations. That's why a tried-and-true approach is being taken this time around. It's one of avoiding the headlines, not looking ahead at what could unfold and focusing on those in the locker room.

"I think we've done a good job of kind of like trying to block external type of expectations," Gosnell said. "Obviously, it's great that we have coach here, brought

players and coaches in. I think as a team this year, it's a bit different. In 2024, we may have kind of heard those and read those and maybe kind of bought into the hype ourselves.

"I think this year we're just trying to stay together and grow, build a team and let the scoreboard and outcomes take care of themselves. For us, we're just trying to buy in as much as possible each and every day."

The Hokies' approach to the season is being set by Franklin. It's a mindset he has established in both his previous coaching stops at Vanderbilt and Penn State, and the weekly approach has proven wildly successful in developing a winning culture.

"The culture and the standard

SEE HOKIES ON B9

VMI at Virginia Tech

7:30 p.m., ACC Network

THE DAY IN SPORTS

BASKETBALL Sky owner downplays Freedom’s lawsuit

Chicago Sky owner **Michael Alter** says a lawsuit filed by former NBA center **Enes Kanter Freedom** is “meritless and frivolous.”

Freedom is alleging that his First Amendment rights were violated when he was ejected from the Sky’s WNBA game against the Indiana Fever on Aug. 23. He is seeking damages and the removal of his ban when it comes to attending games at Wintrust Arena.

The lawsuit, filed Thursday in U.S. District Court in Illinois, names Chicago Women’s Basketball Operations, LLC, which runs the Sky, the Metropolitan Pier and Exposition Authority, the corporation that owns the arena, and the city of Chicago as defendants.

“Freedom was removed for his conduct, not his speech,” Alter said Friday in a statement released by the Sky. “We look forward to the truth prevailing in court.”

The 6-foot-10, 250-pound Freedom was removed from the game after he was confronted by Sky guard **Natasha Cloud** late in the third quarter.

Freedom was sitting along the baseline wearing a black shirt that read “WOMAN noun. adult human female.” ...

Ben Simmons is making a comeback to the NBA after sitting out last season with injuries, agreeing to a one-year contract with the Sacramento Kings.

A person familiar with the deal confirmed to the Associated Press that he will sign with Sacramento. The person spoke to the AP on the condition of anonymity because the deal hadn’t been announced.

ESPN first reported the move and said Simmons would be paid \$3.5 million. ...

Saki Hayashi and Japan set records for three-pointers on the first day of the Women’s World Cup in Berlin.

Hayashi buried nine three-pointers to beat the previous record of eight as she helped Japan to a 102-97 win over Mali. Altogether, Japan sank 20 from beyond the arc to beat its shared team record from 1994.

France lived up to its billing as one of the favorites with a comprehensive 99-53 win over Hungary.

Dominique Malonga, Gabby Williams and **Marine Johannes** each scored 17 points for the Olympic silver medalist.

Awa Fam led Spain to another win over Germany, contributing 17 points in a dominant 83-53 victory.

Steph Talbot scored 19 points as Australia defeated Puerto Rico, 70-54.

Emma Meesseman had 27 points, nine rebounds and five assists to lead European champion Belgium to the 89-75 victory. She scored nine of those points in the final two minutes of the third quarter as Belgium outscored Turkey 27-9 in the third period. Turkey held a 45-44 lead at the end of the first half.

Cecilia Zandalasini led Italy to its first World Cup win upon its return to the tournament after 32 years, 63-54, over the Czech Republic.

Park Ji-hyun scored 27 points to lead South Korea to a 99-81 victory over Nigeria.

HOCKEY Canucks extend Buium for eight more seasons

The Vancouver Canucks signed defenseman **Zeev Buium** to an eight-year contract extension worth \$9.38 million per season.

The 20-year-old offensive-minded defender had three goals and nine assists in 45 games with Vancouver last season. He was acquired from Minnesota in December in the blockbuster trade that sent **Quinn Hughes** to the Wild.

Buium has six goals and 20 assists in 76 career NHL games with the Wild and Canucks. From San Diego, he was drafted 12th overall by Minnesota in 2024 after helping Denver win

SPOTLIGHT: FIBA WOMEN’S WORLD CUP



Caitlin Clark, above, finished with 14 points and 11 assists and backcourt mate Paige Bueckers scored 14 in Friday’s blowout.

Clark, Bueckers elevate U.S. in opener

BY DOUG FEINBERG

BERLIN — Caitlin Clark and Paige Bueckers made the most of their World Cup debuts to help the United States rout China in the opener of the tournament.

Clark had 14 points and 11 assists and Bueckers added another 14 points as the Americans topped China, 94-61, on Friday.

It was the first of likely many times that Clark and Bueckers will play together in the U.S. backcourt over the next decade for the senior national team.

“It’s just organic. We know how to play well off of each other,” Bueckers said. “She draws so much defensive attention, so a lot of the defense is worried about her.”

Clark loved having so many offensive options, including Bueckers. Everywhere she turned to pass there was a teammate waiting to score.

“Obviously being around so many talented players, obviously our guards are incredible and our bigs, too, but you know anybody I pass the ball to, it feels like they’re never going to miss a shot,” Clark said. “That’s one of my goals when I come into the game — to facilitate.”

Clark’s 11 assists were the most by a

UNITED STATES 94, CHINA 61

Americans stand up to Zhang, extend winning streak to 31

U.S. player since Dawn Staley had 12 against Russia in 1998, which tied her for the most ever with Teresa Edwards, who had a dozen against China in 1986.

The U.S. beat China for the gold medal in the 2022 World Cup, but that Chinese team didn’t have 7-foot-3 Zhang Ziyu. The 19-year-old had her own impressive debut in the World Cup, finishing with 13 points and hitting nine of her 10 free throws.

The towering Zhang had just two blocked shots, but made the Americans think twice about driving to the basket. Bueckers took a few foul line jumpers instead of attacking Zhang.

“I like to think I’m pretty smart. I thought that a layup over some 7-foot-3 center is probably not the best idea,” Bueckers said, smiling.

Clark agreed that Zhang presented a difficult challenge, but the U.S. front-

court of Breanna Stewart, Napheesa Collier, Aliyah Boston and Angel Reese held their own, collecting a combined 24 rebounds.

“This was a different type of basketball game that I probably ever played in my entire life,” Clark said. “I’ve never played against a woman of that size. She obviously presented some challenges for us, but you gotta give our post players a lot of credit.”

Reese and Boston also were making their World Cup debut. In total, nine of the 12 players on the American roster, which is full of WNBA all-stars, were playing in their first World Cup. They were able to keep the U.S. rolling.

The win was the 31st in a row for the Americans, who have a day off Saturday before facing Italy on Sunday and the Czech Republic on Monday.

“It was great. Obviously the first one we got to shake off our rust,” Bueckers said. “Get back into game shape. Get back into game mode. And it’s our first time playing together as a team, as a unit. So we got a couple of days of practice, but there’s nothing like getting game reps, getting game experience together.”

— Associated Press

TELEVISION AND RADIO

MLB	
4 p.m.	Chicago Cubs at Miami » MLB Network
7:05 p.m.	Boston at Baltimore » MASN, WYII (97.9 FM), WSNB (630 AM)
7:15 p.m.	New York Yankees at San Diego » WTTG (Ch. 5), WBFF (Ch. 45)
9:10 p.m.	Washington at Los Angeles Dodgers » Nationals.TV, WJFK (106.7 FM)
COLLEGE FOOTBALL	
Noon	Liberty at James Madison » ESPNU
Noon	North Texas at Indiana » WTTG (Ch. 5), WBFF (Ch. 45)
Noon	East Carolina at Alabama » WJLA (Ch. 7), WMAR (Ch. 2)
Noon	Coastal Carolina at West Virginia » TNT
Noon	Oregon State at Houston » ESPN
Noon	New Hampshire at Syracuse » ACC Network
Noon	Ohio at Nebraska » Fox Sports 1
Noon	Bryant at Army » CBS Sports Network
12:30 p.m.	Miami (Ohio) at Pittsburgh » WDCW (Ch. 50), WNUV (Ch. 54)
12:30 p.m.	Ball State at Ohio State » Big Ten Network
12:45 p.m.	Kent State at South Carolina » SEC Network
3:30 p.m.	Towson at Navy » CBS Sports Network, WFED (1500 AM)
3:30 p.m.	Boston College at Cincinnati » WTTG (Ch. 5), WBFF (Ch. 45)
3:30 p.m.	Baylor vs. Auburn » WJLA (Ch. 7), WMAR (Ch. 2)
3:30 p.m.	Boise State at Oregon » WUSA (Ch. 9), WJZ (Ch. 13)
3:30 p.m.	Texas State at Texas » ESPN
3:30 p.m.	Tulane at Duke » ACC Network
3:30 p.m.	Marshall at Penn State » Fox Sports 1
3:45 p.m.	Oklahoma State at Tulsa » ESPNU
4:15 p.m.	North Alabama at Arkansas » SEC Network
4:15 p.m.	Northern Illinois at Iowa » Big Ten Network
6 p.m.	Wyoming at Colorado State » USA Network
7 p.m.	Missouri State at Texas A&M » ESPN
7 p.m.	Abilene Christian at Texas Tech » Fox Sports 1
7 p.m.	Idaho State at Utah State » CBS Sports Network
7:30 p.m.	VMI at Virginia Tech » ACC Network
7:30 p.m.	Western Michigan at Michigan » WRC (Ch. 4), WBAL (Ch. 11)
7:30 p.m.	Clemson at LSU » WJLA (Ch. 7), WMAR (Ch. 2)
7:30 p.m.	Louisiana Monroe at Mississippi State » ESPNU
7:45 p.m.	Florida Atlantic at Florida » SEC Network
8 p.m.	Hampton at Maryland » Big Ten Network, WJZ (105.7 FM), WTEM (980 AM)
8 p.m.	South Dakota State at Northwestern » Big Ten Network (overflow)
9:30 p.m.	Portland State at San Diego State » USA Network
10 p.m.	UNLV at Hawaii » WDCW (Ch. 50), WNUV (Ch. 54)
10:30 p.m.	
UCLA at California » ESPN	
10:30 p.m.	
Western Kentucky at Nevada » CBS Sports Network	
AUTO RACING	
1 p.m.	IndyCar: Grand Prix of Monterey, practice » Fox Sports 2
3 p.m.	Indy NXT: Grand Prix of Monterey, qualifying » Fox Sports 2
4 p.m.	NASCAR Cup Series: Southern 500, practice and qualifying » TruTV
4:30 p.m.	IndyCar: Grand Prix of Monterey, qualifying » Fox Sports 2
6:30 p.m.	Indy NXT: Grand Prix of Monterey, first race » Fox Sports 2
7:30 p.m.	NASCAR O'Reilly Auto Parts Series: Fleetit 200 » WDCW (Ch. 50), WNUV (Ch. 54)
GOLF	
9 a.m.	Walker Cup, first day » Golf Channel
3 a.m. (Sunday)	Walker Cup, final day » Golf Channel
SOCCER	
7:30 a.m.	English Premier League: Bournemouth at Newcastle » USA Network
9 a.m.	FIFA U-20 Women's World Cup, group stage: Argentina vs. Poland » Fox Sports 2
10 a.m.	English Premier League: Coventry City at Manchester City » USA Network
10 a.m.	English League Championship: Bristol City at Burnley » CBS Sports Network
11:15 a.m.	French Ligue 1: Lorient at Lens » BeIN Sports
Noon	Italian Serie A: Napoli at Internazionale » WUSA (Ch. 9), WJZ (Ch. 13)
12:30 p.m.	English Premier League: Aston Villa at Hull City » WRC (Ch. 4), WBAL (Ch. 11)
12:30 p.m.	German Bundesliga: Bayern Munich at Schalke 04 » USA Network
2:45 p.m.	French Ligue 1: Le Mans at Nice » BeIN Sports
6:30 p.m.	NWSL: Angel City at Louisville » Ion
7:30 p.m.	MLS: D.C. United at Cincinnati » Apple TV
TENNIS	
11 a.m.	U.S. Open, third round » ESPN2
7 p.m.	U.S. Open, third round » ESPN2
HORSE RACING	
4 p.m.	Nashville Derby (post time 5:36 p.m.) » WRC (Ch. 4), WBAL (Ch. 11)

the NCAA championship that year. ...

The Toronto Maple Leafs announced the signing of forward **Brendan Brisson** to a one-year contract.

Terms were not disclosed, but multiple reports indicated it is a two-way deal worth \$850,000 at the NHL level.

Brisson, 24, was a first-round pick (29th overall) by the Vegas Golden Knights in the 2020 NHL draft.

SOCCER Madrid, PSG lose their first league matches

Real Madrid and Paris Saint-Germain were dealt their first losses in their domestic leagues when **Kylian Mbappé** had an injury time penalty saved in the Spanish league and PSG coughed up a lead in the French Ligue 1.

Madrid fell at Real Betis, 1-0, for its first defeat since the return of Coach **Jose Mourinho**.

PSG fell at home to Monaco, 2-1, on the same day that Coach **Luis Enrique** agreed to stay at the European champion through 2030.

Enrique, 56, has steered PSG to back-to-back Champions League titles and three French league titles. The Spaniard’s previous contract was set to expire next summer. ...

Alexander Isak scored twice and **Bradley Barcola** debuted as Liverpool got its first win in the English Premier League under its new coach after beating Ipswich, 2-0, away.

Liverpool had been held to a pair of 2-2s against Newcastle and Nottingham Forest in **Andoni Iraola**’s first games in charge.

But Liverpool got clicking right from kickoff at Ipswich as Isak struck twice in the opening minutes from a pair of assists by **Cody Gakpo**. ...

Liverpool has signed teenage forward **Dijlilan N’Guessan** from French side Saint-Etienne, the Premier League club said.

The 18-year-old is set to join Liverpool on a permanent deal in January, the club said. Financial details were not given. Liverpool added that N’Guessan will play the rest of the season on loan at Brest in Ligue 1. ...

U.S. striker **Folarin Balogun** has been left out of Monaco’s squad for the Conference League amid uncertainty over his future after the collapse of his proposed transfer to Everton this week.

He hasn’t featured in any of the team’s four games.

MISC. Van Aert takes latest stage at Spanish Vuelta

Wout van Aert won his fourth career stage at the Spanish Vuelta amid scorching heat while **Enric Mas** kept the red jersey.

On a hot and sunny day in southern Spain, van Aert beat fellow breakthrough rider **Valentin Paret-Peintre** to claim the hilly 119-mile jaunt from Almuñécar to Loja.

The elite Belgian rider stopped the clock at 4½ hours. It was Van Aert’s first win of this edition after he won three stages in 2024. It added to his long list of triumphs, which includes 10 stages of the Tour de France and several one-day classics.

Riders had to handle more heat as thermometers reached 97 degrees in Loja, where the stage finished. ...

Pierre Gasly lost the podium to **Isack Hadjar** for the second time after penalties from the Monaco Grand Prix were reinstated following a successful appeal by two Formula One teams.

As a result, Alpine’s Gasly dropped from third to seventh place in the June 7 race after a pair of five-second penalties were applied. Initially, the penalties for speeding infractions had been rescinded one week after the race.

McLaren and Red Bull appealed to the FIA’s International Court of Appeal, with a hearing held in Paris on Aug. 25. The decision to reinstate the original finish order was announced Friday

— From news services

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washingtonpost.com/recipes

The Washington Post



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NFL NOTES

Hall of Fame is overhauling its selection process in wake of Belichick’s snub

FROM NEWS SERVICES

The Pro Football Hall of Fame is overhauling the selection process by eliminating a separate category for senior players, cutting the selection committee nearly in half and returning to in-person meetings.

The new procedures were approved by the Hall of Fame board following discussions with Hall of Fame staff, members and people on the selection committee. The changes that were announced Friday will be in place for the Class of 2027 and come after the voting process came under heavy scrutiny for the most recent class, when six-time Super Bowl winning coach Bill Belichick failed to get enough support for induction.

“The Hall of Fame’s selection process has always been guided by integrity, thoughtful deliberation and a commitment to honoring those most deserving of football’s highest individual honor,”

Hall of Fame President Jim Porter said. “We believe these changes both augment what has worked well while addressing opportunities to further strengthen a tradition that means so much to the game and everyone who loves it.”

The Hall is cutting the size of the selection committee from 50 people to 28, with 25 of them eligible to vote each year and the other three only able to participate in the discussion of each candidate. The three nonvoters will rotate each year. Instead of a panel that had one representative for each of the 32 teams, 17 at-large voters — including Hall of Famers Bill Polian, Tony Dungy, Dan Fouts and James Lofton — and one representative of the Pro Football Writers of America, there will be 27 at-large members, including some of those Hall of Famers, and one PFWA representative.

•**PACKERS:** Green Bay running back Josh Jacobs’ initial

court appearance on two misdemeanor charges stemming from a May altercation with his girlfriend has been moved up two months and now will take place next week.

Jacobs’ hearing originally was scheduled for Nov. 17. The hearing now is set for Thursday, three days before the Packers open the season at Minnesota.

The NFL has placed Jacobs on the commissioner’s exempt list, which prevents the three-time Pro Bowl running back from playing or practicing but allows him to keep receiving a paycheck. The NFL made that move Sunday, three days after Brown County (Wisconsin) District Attorney David Lasee announced that Jacobs was being charged with battery and criminal damage to property.

The NFL is investigating Jacobs’s situation and he could be suspended by the league. Any games he misses while on the exempt list would count toward

his suspension, but he would have to repay the money he earned during that time.

Jacobs was arrested May 26, three days after Hobart-Lawrence police officers came to his home to investigate a disturbance. Police said Jacobs’ girlfriend told them she had a lump on her head as a result of Jacobs’ actions.

According to police, the woman said she had been looking through Jacobs’ phone and saw he was talking to other women, and that she threw the phone in anger without breaking it. She told police that Jacobs had her phone and she told him he could look through it.

Police said the woman indicated she tried to retrieve her phone from Jacobs, but he grabbed her arm and began a struggle that lasted several minutes. They left the home in separate vehicles before eventually returning.

According to police, the woman was trying to exit a garage door

when Jacobs grabbed her and threw her to the ground, causing her to hit her head. Police said Jacobs also took the phone from her while she was on the ground. The criminal complaint says surveillance footage from the camera system in the garage backed up the woman’s statement.

•**49ERS:** San Francisco arrived in Melbourne for its season-opener against the Los Angeles Rams at the Melbourne Cricket Ground on Sept. 11.

It is expected to be the first of many regular season NFL games in front of a growing Australian fan base.

The 49ers’ 200-member traveling party touched down Friday morning after a 15-hour chartered Qantas flight and will spend a week acclimatizing before facing the Rams in front of an expected sold-out crowd at the MCG.

The 49ers arrived with injured stars George Kittle and Nick Bosa,

who both returned to practice and are hoping to play in the game. San Francisco will be without defensive end Sam Okuyinonu, who injured his foot in practice this week. Okuyinonu was ruled out for the game. He had three sacks last season.

The Rams are scheduled to arrive Thursday, only about 24 hours before the game.

•**FALCONS:** Atlanta will induct John Abraham and the late Bill Fallic into the franchise’s Ring of Honor this season, the team announced.

Abraham, a defensive end who recorded 68.5 sacks in seven seasons with Atlanta (2006-12), will be honored during the Week 5 Sunday night game against the Baltimore Ravens on Oct. 11.

Fallic, a right guard who started 115 of his 116 games with the Falcons from 1985-92, will be inducted posthumously at the Week 16 game against the Tampa Bay Buccaneers.



Erik Tolman, who had yet to allow a run in 6⅓ innings entering Friday, gives the Nats’ bullpen hope.

ANALYSIS

Nats’ No. 1 priority is fixing the bullpen

NATS FROM B7

and the bullpen this winter, but spending hasn’t been a given for ownership as of late. Case in point: Washington started this season with the fourth-lowest payroll in MLB.

One of Toboni’s biggest takeaways from the bullpen’s failures this year is the value of having homegrown relievers. Those players are more affordable, and they can stay in the system for years.

“We’ve taken a lot of chances in turning over the bullpen, right?” Toboni said. “One can argue how effective that’s been. I think just the general takeaway of doing that is a good thing. Whether it’s calling players up from Triple A or claiming players on waivers, I think it just gives us more shots to uncover a guy who can help us in future years.”

Aiding their internal options by adding controllable arms was the goal at the trade deadline, and some of the new bullpen addi-

tions have fared well. Will Dion, acquired from the Cleveland Guardians in the Foster Griffin trade, has a 2.04 ERA in 17⅓ innings with the Nationals. Ben Grable, acquired from the New York Yankees in exchange for Luis García Jr., has allowed just one run in 10⅓ innings in the Nationals organization. He was elevated to Class AAA last week.

The Nationals have also had success, in small sample sizes, from arms they already had in their system. Erik Tolman has yet to allow a run in 6⅓ innings, earning his first save Monday against the Miami Marlins. Eddy Yean has also shown glimpses in his 10 innings, allowing just two earned runs before he was optioned back to Class AAA in early August.

Clayton Beeter and Ribalta have set themselves up to be key parts of the bullpen next season. So has Brad Lord in a multi-inning role. The rest is up for grabs. The past few weeks of the season

will help the team narrow down who else they want to stick around. Beyond that, it’ll be up to the front office to fill in the pieces if they don’t want a repeat of this season.

NATIONALS ON DECK			
at Los Angeles Dodgers			
Saturday	9:10	Nationals.TV	
Sunday	10:10	Nationals.TV	
at San Diego Padres			
Monday	5:10	Nationals.TV	
Tuesday	9:40	Nationals.TV	
Wednesday	4:10	Nationals.TV	
vs. Los Angeles Angels			
Friday	6:45	Nationals.TV	
Sept. 12	4:05	Nationals.TV	
Sept. 13	1:35	Nationals.TV	
Radio: WJFK (106.7 FM), WDCN (87.7 FM)			

Locksley faces a make-or-break season

TERPS FROM B7

and if we sit around and talk about winning and talk about how much we win by or all those things, it doesn’t help us.”

That sentiment was echoed by Washington, who is looking to build on a first-year campaign during which he set the pace among all NCAA Football Bowl Subdivision freshman passers by throwing for 2,963 yards.

“It’s really not so much what people think about our team as how we think about ourselves and how we view ourselves that motivates us and keeps us moving forward,” the Glen Burnie native said. “The energy in the locker room, the energy on the field and practice, that’s what pushes our team. Not so much of the outside noise.”

Saturday’s game might answer

a few questions about certain units. Will a dependable starter emerge from the four-headed running back corps? How will the defense overcome the season-ending injury to standout sophomore outside linebacker Zahir Mathis?

Despite those issues and others, Locksley said he remains optimistic about the team’s potential.

“My perspective has been really consistent, and that’s a by-product of the consistency that it’s still a young team,” he said. “But we’re no longer inexperienced. We’ve gained experience with how and what we’ve gone through. And so my perspective hasn’t changed. I felt pretty strongly that we have a good team, but at the end of the day, our work is going to have to be louder than our words, and

they’ve done the work so far.”

Maryland will carry a 15-game winning streak in season openers against non-Big Ten opponents, which ranks third in the league behind Ohio State’s 25-game run and Michigan’s 16-game streak. Reminded of that success, Locksley went to a familiar refrain.

“Nothing from our past will dictate our future,” he said. “So nothing that we’ve done here [before] the first game will have any bearing on what we do this weekend other than how we’ve prepared ourselves.”

Saturday’s game looms as a first step toward regaining some semblance of respect for the Terps. Washington declined to offer certain benchmarks for what that would look like, but did provide one clue.

“Just winning games,” he said.

HOKIES FROM B7

is everything to us, and we’re constantly going to try to build it each and every day,” nickelback Isaiah Brown-Murray said. “If you don’t have a culture or a standard, you’re not going to be able to win football games. We’re just trying to build that. That’s not a spring thing or a summer thing; that’s a whole year thing to try and build that culture and a standard, and once guys buy in, it’s going to happen.”

Franklin allowed last season’s Penn State team to deviate from the normal preseason routine. A loaded Nittany Lions roster that experienced what it took to reach the CFP semifinals was allowed to embrace the season’s lofty expectations and set a goal of playing for the national championship.

The change didn’t work. An overtime loss at home to Oregon cascaded into setbacks at UCLA and against Northwestern, and Penn State’s season took a drastic turn with Franklin’s firing.

He’s returned to his roots this season. He presented the Hokies’ history against VMI during Tuesday’s team meeting to reinforce the mentality of focusing on each week.

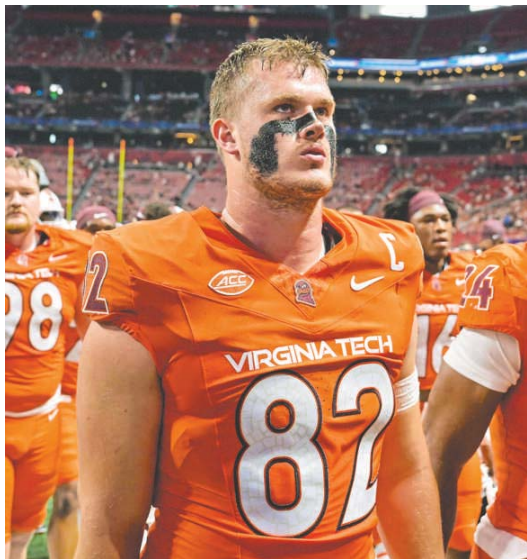
Linebacker Keon Wylie is one of 12 former Penn State players who followed Franklin to Virginia Tech. Wylie noticed the return to normalcy as the Hokies turned their attention to VMI instead of looking at what could unfold this season.

“He was trying to emphasize the importance of the game and no game is bigger than the first game,” Wylie said. “So just keeping present-minded. I was in the locker rooms last year with all the expectations. It’s hard not to look ahead, but you know, he does a good job of keeping us centered.”

Franklin told reporters at ACC football media days that the Hokies won the offseason. He didn’t stop there. He continued by saying the results on the field needed to back up the gains made off the field, and the coaching staff made sure the focus during training camp was finishing.

The wins won’t follow if the players don’t finish every play.

“I think that’s a part of it. Those tiny details are what you need and what are essential to winning. I think finishing is just a part of the process that leads to winning. You have to start fast. You can’t say,



“I think we’ve done a good job of trying to block external type of expectations,” fifth-year Virginia Tech tight end Benji Gosnell said.

‘Oh, I’m going to wait to turn it on until the end.’” safety Tyson Flowers said. “Coach [Anthony] Midget reminds us of that all the time because Coach Midget was a safety or corner here when they went to the national championship and played Florida State. He reminds us from one of the first times he got here, he said we didn’t start fast and we tried to turn it on but it was too little, too late.

“You have to start fast, too, because you also have to finish strong and play well in between. I think all of that goes into helping create wins on the field.”

The Hokies struggled in last season’s 3-9 campaign. The idea of finishing each play and handling individual responsibilities is allowing the players to appreciate the details of what it takes to win games.

“I think it’s very important. If 11 guys, if they make one mistake, you as yourself might not think it’s bad, but if there’s 11 mistakes in the game, that’s how you lose football games,” defensive tackle Kemari Copeland said. “He’s just harping on that. That’s the key. We have to be a detailed-oriented team. In big games, like when we play Miami, it’s going to come down to one thing. That one thing

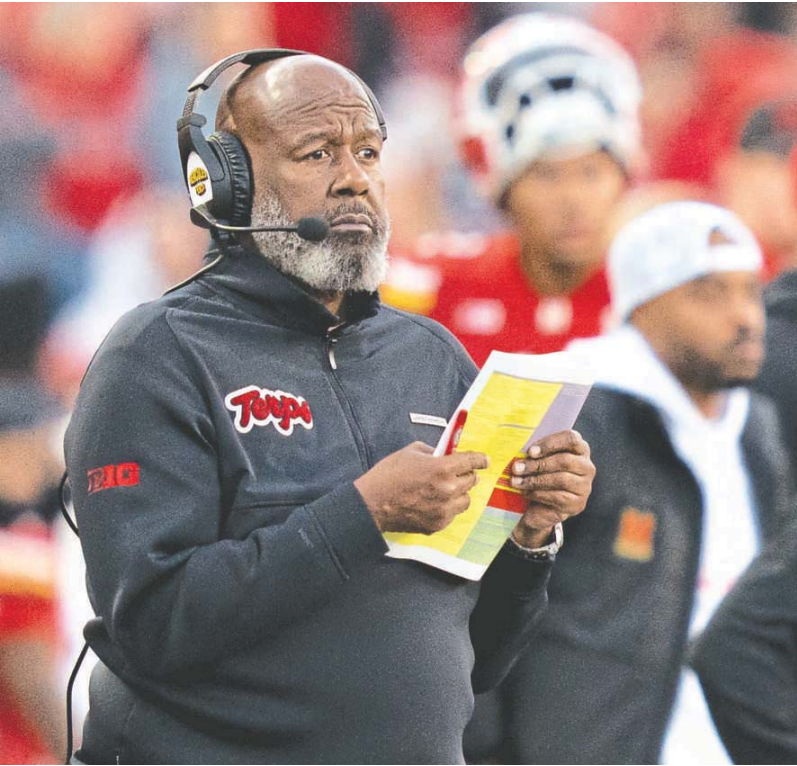
is going to be a detail. Am I in my A-gap? Am I in the B-gap? Am I doing my right job? If everybody does that, that’s how you win games.”

Copeland, Flowers, Brown-Murray and Gosnell return as key pieces for a team that hopes to rebound from a three-win campaign and finish the regular season with more than six wins for the first time since 2019.

Franklin retooled the roster. He brought a dozen of his former Penn State players with him, highlighted by quarterback Ethan Grunkemeyer. He flipped a recruiting class that restocked key positions.

A new coaching staff. Revamped roster. Position battles across the board. Franklin’s goal is re-establishing the Virginia Tech football brand that was on the national stage for a two-decade stretch.

“It’s Frank Beamer in Charlotte watching a TV and he looks and he goes, ‘That’s what it’s supposed to look like,’” Franklin said. “Bud Foster, he’s seen it in practice and he feels good, but he’s watching the games and saying, ‘That’s what it looks like. This is how it’s supposed to look. This is how it’s supposed to feel.’”



After frustrating back-to-back 4-8 records, Maryland Coach Michael Locksley could be facing the most important season of his tenure in College Park. Having sophomore QB Malik Washington should help.

BASEBALL

National League														American League																											
EAST	W	L	PCT	GB	L10	STR	CENTRAL	W	L	PCT	GB	L10	STR	WEST	W	L	PCT	GB	L10	STR	EAST	W	L	PCT	GB	L10	STR	CENTRAL	W	L	PCT	GB	L10	STR	WEST	W	L	PCT	GB	L10	STR
Atlanta	84	57	.596	—	8-2	W-2	Milwaukee	88	54	.620	—	7-3	W-1	x-Los Angeles	83	57	.593	—	4-6	W-1	x-Tampa Bay	83	57	.593	—	6-4	L-2	Chicago	74	67	.525	—	6-4	W-1	Houston	73	69	.514	—	7-3	W-3
Philadelphia	79	62	.560	5	6-4	L-2	Chicago	80	62	.563	8	4-6	W-2	Arizona	74	68	.521	10	5-5	L-1	x-New York	80	60	.571	3	6-4	W-2	Cleveland	72	70	.507	2½	6-4	W-2	x-Texas	70	71	.496	2½	5-5	W-1
Miami	71	71	.500	13½	4-6	L-2	x-St. Louis	70	71	.496	17½	4-6	L-1	x-San Diego	73	67	.521	10	3-7	L-2	Boston	77	65	.542	7	4-6	W-2	Minnesota	67	74	.475	7	4-6	L-2	x-Seattle	66	75	.468	6½	4-6	L-1
x-Washington	67	75	.472	17½	6-4	L-1	Pittsburgh	70	72	.493	18	7-3	W-2	San Francisco	58	84	.408	26	4-6	L-2	Toronto	71	71	.500	13	7-3	W-3	Detroit	64	77	.454	10	3-7	L-2	x-Athletics	55	86	.390	17½	4-6	W-2
New York	64	77	.454	20	5-5	W-2	Cincinnati	67	74	.475	20½	5-5	L-1	x-Colorado	54	86	.386	29	4-6	W-2	Baltimore	69	73	.486	15	5-5	L-4	Kansas City	63	79	.444	11½	5-5	L-1	Los Angeles	53	88	.376	19½	1-9	L-3

NATIONALS' LEADERS

Entering Friday's game.

BATTERS	AVG	HR	RBI	BB	SO	SB
Morales	.500	1	1	0	3	0
Wiemer	.286	3	12	12	29	1
Garcia	.283	23	76	16	61	4
Ruiz	.282	9	45	16	35	2
Pinckney	.273	1	2	1	8	1
Abrams	.267	29	94	50	138	27
Wood	.265	30	73	90	154	17
De La	.254	20	80	38	110	14
Mead	.254	17	48	39	62	6
Young	.249	10	44	30	71	17
Chaparro	.247	9	34	21	40	0
Vivas	.242	3	25	36	41	2
House	.242	10	41	22	80	2
Tena	.227	7	22	26	82	4
Crews	.216	10	34	26	88	8
Núñez	.214	1	35	45	94	44
Ortiz	.202	5	10	5	23	0
Ford	.200	3	8	11	22	2
Mills	.185	2	11	14	37	0

PITCHERS	W	L	ERA	IP	ER	BB	SO
Tolman	0	0	0.00	6.2	0	2	8
Waldron	0	0	0.00	5.2	0	1	2
Simpson	1	0	0.00	3	0	0	3
Yean	0	1	1.80	10	2	2	6
Dion	1	1	2.04	17.2	4	7	17
Fernández	0	0	2.25	6.1	3	7	6
Williams	0	0	2.65	17	5	6	22
Poulin	3	0	2.70	36.2	11	21	25
Griffith	12	3	3.06	129.1	40	116	
Cavalli	12	3	3.12	152.5	36	177	
Bird	0	0	3.24	8.1	3	2	10
Alvarez	2	6	3.47	90.2	35	41	86
Lord	5	2	3.58	77	29	29	70
Ribalta	2	5	3.77	45	18	18	42
Lovelady	1	3	3.91	23	10	17	21
Beeter	5	4	3.97	45.1	20	30	45
Lawrence	0	0	4.26	6.1	3	7	6
Littell	7	8	4.97	112.6	35	70	
Irvin	2	8	5.57	85.2	53	40	87
J Kent	1	2	5.59	19.1	12	15	17
Mikolas	3	9	5.82	116	75	23	58
Cornello	2	2	5.96	22.2	15	21	23
Pérez	2	3	6.19	16.0	11	11	9
DeShultz	2	4	6.40	32.1	23	12	32
Parlier	3	5	6.58	39.2	29	13	34
Z Kent	0	0	6.75	10.2	8	2	9
Waldchuk	0	0	6.75	9.1	7	6	8
Variano	1	2	6.82	31.2	15	30	
Cosgrove	1	2	7.71	16.1	14	14	14
Palquist	0	2	7.71	16.1	14	15	14
Krook	0	2	7.71	16.1	14	15	14
Krivanec	0	2	7.90	15.2	12	17	15
Tena	0	0	9.00	1	1	1	0
Kranick	0	1	9.33	18.1	19	13	11
Granillo	0	0	9.64	9.1	10	8	3
Cruz	0	1	11.25	4	5	4	4
Vivas	0	0	13.50	4	6	1	0
Peraltes	0	0	21.00	3	7	4	5

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Ruiz	.282	9	45	16	35	2
Pinckney	.273	1	2	1	8	1
Abrams	.267	29	94	50	138	27
Wood	.265	30	73	90	154	17
De La	.254	20	80	38	110	14
Mead	.254	17	48	39	62	6
Young	.249	10	44	30	71	17
Chaparro	.247	9	34	21	40	0
Vivas	.242	3	25	36	41	2
House	.242	10	41	22	80	2
Tena	.227	7	22	26	82	4
Crews	.216	10	34	26	88	8
Núñez	.214	1	35	45	94	44
Ortiz	.202	5	10	5	23	0
Ford	.200	3	8	11	22	2
Mills	.185	2	11	14	37	0

PITCHERS	W	L	ERA	IP	ER	BB	SO
Tolman	0	0	0.00	6.2	0	2	8
Waldron	0	0	0.00	5.2	0	1	2
Simpson	1	0	0.00	3	0	0	3
Yean	0	1	1.80	10	2	2	6
Dion	1	1	2.04	17.2	4	7	17
Fernández	0	0	2.25	6.1	3	7	6
Williams	0	0	2.65	17	5	6	22
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Variano	1	2	6.82	31.2	15	30	
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Palquist	0	2	7.71	16.1	14	15	14
Krook	0	2	7.71	16.1	14	15	14
Krivanec	0	2	7.90	15.2	12	17	15
Tena	0	0	9.00	1	1	1	0
Kranick	0	1	9.33	18.1	19	13	11
Granillo	0	0	9.64	9.1	10	8	3
Cruz	0	1	11.25	4	5	4	4
Vivas	0	0	13.50	4	6	1	0
Peraltes	0	0	21.00	3	7	4	5

Braves 5, Phillies 2

Atlanta's Chris Sale out-

dued Cristopher Sánchez

in a matchup of two of

baseball's best pitchers,

and the Braves beat Phila-

delphia to extend its lead

in the National League

East to five games.

Ronald Acuña had three

hits and drove in a run for

the Braves.

BRVES	AB	R	H	BI	BB	SO	AVG
Acuña rf	5	0	3	1	0	0	.249
Baldwin dh	5	0	1	0	0	1	.275
Albies 2b	5	0	1	0	0	1	.254
Olson 1b	4	0	1	0	0	1	.252
Thomas lf	4	1	0	0	0	1	.226
Yastrzemski ph-lf	0	1	0	0	0	1	.225
Dubón cf-ss	4	2	2	2	0	0	.268
Murphy c	2	0	0	0	2	1	.234
Riley 3b	4	1	1	1	0	1	.223
Kim ss	2	0	0	1	0	0	.117
Harris ph-cf	2	0	0	0	0	0	.294
TOTALS	35	5	8	4	6	—	

PHILLIES	AB	R	H	BI	BB	SO	AVG
Schwarber dh	4	0	0	0	0	1	.238
Turner ss	4	0	1	0	0	0	.239
Harper cf	4	0	0	0	0	2	.273
Brahm 2b	4	1	2	0	0	0	.316
Bohm 1b	4	1	2	0	0	1	.248
Sosa 3b	3	0	0	0	0	2	.239
De La Cruz lf	3	0	0	0	0	2	.333
Marsh ph	1	0	0	0	0	0	.268
Realuto c	2	0	0	0	1	1	.221
Hill cf	2	0	0	0	0	0	.240
Crawford ph-cf	1	0	0	0	0	1	.265
TOTALS	32	2	6	2	1	—	

ATLANTA

030 000 020 — 2 1 0

PHILA.....010 010 000 — 2 6 1

E: Harper (5), Lito: Atlanta 7, Philadel-

phia 5, 2B: Acuña (14), Albies (25),

Bohm (24), Turner (24), Arraez (29),

HR: Dubón (11), off Kerkering; Bohm

(15), off Sale.

BRVES	IP	H	R	ER	BB	SO	ERA
Sale	6	6	2	2	1	7	2.10
Fuentes	2	0	0	0	0	1	2.27
Iglesias	1	0	0	0	0	2	2.77

PHILLIES	IP	H	R	ER	BB	SO	ERA
Féderich	6	6	2	2	1	7	2.68

PHILLIES

IP H R ER BB SO ERA

Féderich 6 6 2 2 1 7 2.68

BRVES

IP H R ER BB SO ERA

Sale 6 6 2 2 1 7 2.10

Fuentes 2 0 0 0 0 1 2.27

Iglesias 1 0 0 0 0 2 2.77

Pirates 1, Angels 0

Jared Jones pitched six

strong innings, Jake Mang-

um had an RBI double in

the second inning, and

Pittsburgh beat skidding

Los Angeles.

The MLB-worst Angels

lost for the 10th time in

11 games. The Pirates have

won five of six games.

Jones blanked the

Angels on three hits to win

for the first time since July 18.

ANGELS	AB	R	H	BI	BB	SO	AVG
Neto ss	4	0	0	0	0	3	.234
Trout cf	4	0	1	0	0	1	.239
Meckler rf-lf	4	0	1	0	0	0	.296
Grisson 1b	3	0	1	0	1	0	.249
Ballesteros c	2	0	1	0	1	0	.209
Heineman c	0	0	0	0	0	0	.178
d'Arnaud ph	1	0	0	0	0	0	.164
Moore 2b	3	0	0	0	0	0	.172
Siri lf	1	0	0	0	0	0	.122
J Lowe ph-rf	1	0	0	0	0	0	.209
Frazier dh	3	0	0	0	3	239	
Peraza 3b	3	0	0	0	2	222	
TOTALS	30	4	0	2	12	—	

PIRATES	AB	R	H	BI	BB	SO	AVG
Horwitz 1b	2	0	0	2	2	246	
B Lowe 2b	4	0	1	0	0	254	
Reynolds rf	4	0	0	0	0	1	.263
Gonzales dh	3	0	0	0	0	1	.308
Cruz cf	3	0	0	1	2	267	
Griffin ss	3	1	0	0	1	272	
Mangum lf	3	0	1	0	0	288	
Gonzalez 3b	0	1	0	0	0	225	
Triolo 3b	0	0	0	0	0	242	
Davis c	2	0	0	0	0	167	
TOTALS	27	1	5	1	3	10	—

LA.....000 000 000 — 0 4 0

LOS: Los Angeles 5, Pittsburgh 7, 2B:

Mangum (17), Reynolds (34).

ANGELS	IP	H	R	ER	BB	SO	ERA
Johnson	6	4	1	2	6	517	
Fermin	1	0	0	0	0	2321	
Natera	1	1	0	1	1	2251	

PIRATES	IP	H	R	ER	BB	SO	ERA
---------	----	---	---	----	----	----	-----

PERSONNEL DEPT.

Cardinals: Reinstated

RHP Andre Pallante from

the 15-day injured list

and optioned RHP Ryan

Fernandez to Class AAA

Memphis.

Nationals: Selected the

contract of RHP Jack

Sinclair from Class AAA

Rochester, designated

RHP Max Kranick for

assignment and sent

LHP Tom Cosgrove

outright to Rochester.

Pirates: Reinstated SS

Konnor Griffin from the

60-day IL, designated C

Christian Bethancourt for

assignment and optioned

LHP Brandon Eisert to

Class AAA Indianapolis.

Rangers: Sent C Kyle

Higashioka on a rehab

assignment to Class AAA

Round Rock.

Rays: Reinstated RHP

Jameson Taillon from the

15-day IL and optioned

LHP Ricky Tiedemann to

Class AAA Buffalo.

White Sox: Reinstated C

Kyle Teel from the 10-day

NOTES

Engelbert to retire as WNBA commissioner at year’s end

BY DOUG FEINBERG
Associated Press

WNBA Commissioner Cathy Engelbert is retiring at the end of the year, bringing to a close her seven-plus years at the helm of the league and a stewardship that has been transformative and at times tumultuous.

Engelbert is the second-longest tenured WNBA president or commissioner, and she helped negotiate a lucrative collective bargaining agreement this past spring that resulted in the league's first set of million-dollar player salaries.

"Cathy has presided over the WNBA through the most significant period of growth in the league's 30-year history," NBA Commissioner Adam Silver said Friday when announcing Engelbert's decision. "We are grateful for Cathy's leadership and unwavering commitment to the advancement of women's basketball."

Engelbert, who turns 62 in November, told the Associated Press that she has been thinking about retiring for months.

"When I first came to the league I intended to do this for 3½ years," she said in a phone interview. "The 7½ years exceeded that time. This is a really good time given the financial transformation journey we've been on. Getting the collective bargaining agreement done, getting a long-

term media rights deal done, getting expansion done."

Engelbert insists that the decision to leave was solely her own and that she did not feel any pressure to step down from NBA or WNBA stakeholders.

Potential successors

The commissioner said she has been working on a succession plan over the past few years. While she didn't give any specifics on who might be considered for the position, Engelbert did say there are both internal and external candidates on the league's radar.

"It's a good time to hand it off to the next leader to take the 'W' into a better phase," she said. "I'm proud of the team we built and everything we accomplished. A leader knows when it's time to drop the mic and move on after building a powerhouse team in the league office."

Engelbert said she has mixed emotions about leaving.

"I love women's basketball and am not going anywhere yet. We'll run a real succession process in the remaining four months. If we don't find someone I'll stay on," she said. "I had no transition. I walked in the door and I was by myself as no one transitioned me into this role."

"Hopefully I can help this next leader transition in especially considering the elevation of this league."



Cathy Engelbert has led the WNBA through an unprecedented but often turbulent era of growth during her tenure as commissioner.

The WNBA has grown at an exponential rate during Engelbert's tenure as commissioner, with record television ratings, strong attendance, a new long-term media rights deal and expansion to 18 teams by the end of the decade.

"I was brought in as a business leader to transform the business," she said. "I look at revenue and merchandise, viewership and at-

tendence," she said, noting how they've all improved. "A great leader senses when it's time for someone else to come in. When I came in, this league was facing questions about our long-term viability and sustainability."

A tumultuous tenure

Engelbert said the growth of the league has "blown away her expectations" since she stepped

into her role after leaving her previous position as president of Deloitte in 2019.

Besides the new CBA, the list of things she is most proud of includes getting charter travel for players, keeping the league going during the coronavirus pandemic, the historic media rights deal and exponential increase in the value of WNBA franchises. In 2019, the average value of a WNBA franchise was \$10 million; in 2026, it is about \$460 million.

Along with the financial gains, however, turmoil and tension have accompanied the WNBA's growth.

Players say they have seen more social media vitriol directed toward them over the past few years and some don't feel the league has done enough to ensure their safety. The league also has been at the center of discussions about transgender athletes playing in the league.

Engelbert has repeatedly said the online attacks of players are unacceptable and she backs league initiatives to protect them. She also said there should be no confusion on the transgender question.

"We have no current eligibility issues in the WNBA," Engelbert said, adding that "if we did, we would have a thoughtful policy discussion with the [players' association] and the players."

While there was a strained partnership between the com-

missioner and players during the recent CBA negotiations, Engelbert insists she has a good relationship with them.

Talks between the commissioner and players have been complicated.

New York Liberty forward Breanna Stewart, vice president of the WNBA players' union executive committee, said before the All-Star Game that there is a respect for Engelbert among the players, just not much of a relationship.

The next steps

Engelbert said she is ready to do what most retirees plan: spend more time with family.

She also admitted that the on-line hate she receives has affected her family as well, though she did not share details of the impact.

"There have been some hard parts of that on my family with the vitriol and hate I get online," Engelbert said.

Her retirement will make her mother happy.

"My mom is turning 90 this year, and she said that 'it would be good if you were retired to spend more time with me,'" Engelbert said, laughing. "I have two children, one I barely see."

"I'm one of eight kids [and I] have five brothers. They always say, 'Can you retire so you can spend more time with us?'"

Come Jan. 1, her family will get its wish.

U.S. OPEN

Sabalenka cruises; Williams sisters fall

U.S. OPEN FROM B7

back to beat 2021 runner-up Leylah Fernandez, 1-6, 6-4, 6-3. Pegula, who lost to Sabalenka in the 2024 final and again last year in the semifinals, had a dismal start in which she put only 5 of 16 first serves in during the first set.

Fernandez hadn't won a Grand Slam singles match this year until getting to New York and was trying to reach the fourth round at the U.S. Open for the first time since falling to Emma Raducanu in the final five years ago. Pegula handled her easily in their only meeting this year but said Fernandez showed her different looks that gave her trouble.

"I didn't start off very well. It was tough," Pegula said. "I had to dig deep there in the second to turn that around, and it very well could have not turned around."

Pegula advanced to face Sorana Cirstea, the 36-year-old from Romania who is contemplating retirement after this season. She

will have at least one more Grand Slam match after the No. 16 seed beat No. 19 Jasmine Paolini, 6-3, 6-3.

Townsend reached the round of 16 for the second straight year by knocking off No. 15 seed Diana Shnaider, 6-2, 6-7 (7-3), 6-3, and seemed eager for the matchup with Sabalenka.

"I'm so excited. I feel like I thrive in these moments," the American said. "I'm built for these moments and so now is my time, I'm ready to take it. I'm ready to go."

Wimbledon champion Linda Noskova and Marta Kostyuk, the No. 11 seed, advanced, setting up a rematch of their semifinal match at the All England Club. No. 7 seed Karolina Muchova, who lost in that final, was ousted by No. 26 Emma Navarro.

Daniil Medvedev, the 2021 champion, became the first man into the fourth round when he beat Arthur Rinderknech, 6-4, 6-4, 6-4. The No. 7 seed will face

either No. 11 Frances Tiafoe or No. 22 Valentin Vacherot.

Williams sisters fall

Serena and Venus Williams are out of the women's doubles after losing in a match tiebreaker.

The sisters blew a 5-0 lead in the 10-point tiebreaker and lost, 6-3, 6-7 (8-6), 7-6 (10-7), to Hao-Ching Chan and Maya Joint.

It was the first U.S. Open match since 2022 at the Grand Slam tournament the sisters won twice. They pulled out the second set in a tiebreaker, battled back from 4-1 down in the third set to tie it, but then faltered late.

Serena came back to tennis this year at 44. Venus has continued to play on tour at 46.

Perhaps it was their ages, could have been Serena's long layoff, or maybe it was nerves. But both double-faulted during the tiebreaker after they had played so brilliantly late in the third set and then in the first few points of the tiebreaker.



Serena, left, and Venus Williams fell, 6-3, 6-7 (8-6), 7-6 (10-7), to Hao-Ching Chan and Maya Joint.

In search of fan engagement, MLB teams are counting on dog days of summer

BASEBALL DOGS FROM B7

pumping all-star voting for James Wood and CJ Abrams.

But Natty's main job appears to be hanging with Nationals players. He's around on certain game days, sitting through clubhouse speeches and helping with batting practice (which is to say, rolling in the grass and eating dirt). No matter what he's up to, he's a certified vibe lifter.

"That's his job, really," Nuñez said. "He just makes everyone feel lighter. Like, this is a stressful, exhausting thing, you know? You have games almost every day. You show up tired. And then there's a dog."

"He's everyone's best friend."

This position isn't unique to the Nationals. At least six MLB teams have had official affiliations with dogs, and dozens of minor league teams have a clubhouse pooch.

Canine roles differ depending on the employer. Some teams have them fetch bats, some employ trained therapy dogs and others, like the Nationals, just hire a pretty face.

Either way, this is all quite new. A decade ago, groundskeepers occasionally brought their furry buddies to work. But in a sports ecosystem in which more eyes brew more cash, the interest among teams in hiring a four-legged social media employee is rapidly expanding. Every team is looking for an edge on social platforms, anything to attract more brand deals and the possible new fan.

"It's great, positive attention," said Dan Mason, general manager of the Nationals' Class AAA affiliate Rochester Red Wings. The Upstate New York team hired a bat-retrieving dog back in 2019, well before the fad. "We just thought it would bring positivity to everything," Mason said. "Baseball is stressful, so giving fans and players something light can never

hurt."

The idea in Rochester came about when an executive looked at a stick, then at a bat, then back at a stick, this time in a dog's mouth. When a player is done swinging a bat, it simply makes sense for that to become a game of fetch. At which point: so long, batboy.

"At first, I wasn't quite sure if the concept of a bat dog would even work," said Josh Snyder, a dog trainer and the owner of Rochester's current dog, Bruce. "But they were really open about just wanting to see what was possible."

He started training his then-3-year-old golden retriever, Milo, and soon they were on the field. For all team dogs, fans' cheers can be a big distraction. Milo also would wander off track toward a kid's giggle or the smell of popcorn. "It took some time," Snyder said. But they found their rhythm.

Seven years later, now with his second bat dog, Bruce, Snyder and his companion are a staple in the Rochester community. Bruce has an avid social media following, his face is plastered on merchandise and he hosts meet-and-greets with fans. "He gets more attention than we do," said former Rochester first baseman Abimelec Ortiz, now with the Nationals. "The dog is the attraction. I'm not sure why there aren't more MLB teams with them."

Alex Mayer, the Seattle Mariners' communications director, had a guess: "Everyone in the front office will be able to bring their dog to work."

He and a team executive came across a promotion for a minor league team's dog during the 2022 all-star break. Acting on impulse, they drove to a central Washington dog shelter and picked up a yellow Lab mix soon to be known as Tucker. "We fell in love with him, played fetch with him on a hot summer day," he said dreamily. With few plans, they brought



Reliever Clayton Beeter bonds with Natty, a 6-month-old Labrador retriever mix. Natty will eventually head off to service dog boot camp.

him to Seattle and set him off into the clubhouse. The first official MLB dog was born.

Tucker drifts between mascot and support spokesman, sidling up to players, as he's allowed to roam around T-Mobile Park for every home game. He and first baseman Josh Naylor have developed a particular bond. Tucker's known to add some weight during spring training, wandering be-

tween the minor league and major league sides of the team's Arizona facility, doubling up on treats.

"He's actually peeing on the warning track right now. Honest to God, I'm staring out at him," Mayer said before an August game against the Detroit Tigers. "We wanted him to be, you know, an actual clubhouse dog for the players and the other uniform personnel. But who doesn't love a

gold Lab?"

He's living the good life. And he's the inspiration for most other teams' recent initiatives, having amassed more than 20,000 Instagram followers within days of his arrival.

The Nationals' approach is slightly different, more akin to one the Pittsburgh Pirates pioneered. In conjunction with Canine Companions, which trains

and places service dogs, Natty will be with the Nationals until he's roughly 18 months old. Then he'll head off to service dog boot camp with the line of duty right around the corner. (Nuñez was distraught when he learned this, kicking the cleats sitting in front of his locker.)

For an MLB team, that sort of partnership makes sense. A host family trains the dog, taking it to games and events to provide social stimulation. The team gets to promote its new expert ballpark grass inspector, drawing sponsorships and social media traction. Often, via their least-tenured employee, teams reach viewers who might not necessarily be baseball inclined. But don't we all like videos of puppies? A new fan might show up to Nationals Park just to see a game promoting Natty, the thinking goes.

"It's just about as good a deal as you can imagine," Mason said. "And, again, the players love the dogs. People love dogs — that's a scientific thing. So why wouldn't you want this?"

No baseball team The Washington Post spoke with cited any specific science behind its dog hire. This was a social move.

"Athletes love dogs for the same reasons people love dogs: They're friendly, calming and loving," said Steven Feldman, president of the Human Animal Bond Research Institute. "It's definitely feasible that they have a positive effect — calming, stress-relieving — on athletes, too."

Nuñez was spending some quality time with his bestie in mid-July when the baseball dog worlds collided.

"Who is that?" he asked. The Nationals called Bruce up to the majors for the day. He and Natty, related in some native way, were tugging at a plush bat.

"That was my dream," Nuñez said. "Honestly, I think I played better that day."

If that's the case, the dog days have only begun.

SCOREBOARD

PRO FOOTBALL

NFL			
WEEK 1			
WEDNESDAY'S GAME			
New England at Seattle, 8:20			
THURSDAY'S GAME			
San Francisco at L.A. Rams, 8:35			
SUNDAY, SEPT. 13			
Washington at Philadelphia, 4:25			
New Orleans at Detroit, 10			
Buffalo at Albany 17			
Chicago at Carolina, 1			
Tampa Bay at Cincinnati, 1			
Green Bay at Minnesota, 4:25			
Buffalo at Houston, 1			
Cleveland at Jaguars, 1			
Atlanta at Pittsburgh, 1			
N.Y. Jets at Tennessee, 1			
Arizona at L.A. Chargers, 4:25			
Miami at Las Vegas, 4:25			
Green Bay at Minnesota, 4:25			
Dallas at N.Y. Giants, 8:20			
MONDAY, SEPT. 14			
Denver at Kansas City, 8:15			

PRO BASKETBALL

WNBA			
EAST			
y-Atlanta	W	L	Pct
y-Atlanta	26	14	.650
y-Indiana	26	14	.650
y-New York	24	16	.600
y-Washington	24	16	.600
Chicago	24	16	.600
Toronto	11	29	.275
Connecticut	10	30	.250

WEST			
y-Minnesota	W	L	Pct
y-Golden State	29	11	.725
y-Las Vegas	27	13	.675
y-Dallas	24	16	.600
Portland	16	15	.515
Los Angeles	15	25	.375
Phoenix	14	26	.350
Seattle	8	32	.200

Y-Chinled playoff spot			
THURSDAY SEPT.17			
Washington at Chicago, 8			
Connecticut at Atlanta, 7:30			
Los Angeles at Dallas, 8			
Portland at Portland, 10			
Las Vegas at Seattle, 10			

FRIDAY'S SEPT. 18			
Indiana at Toronto, 7:30			
New York at Minnesota, 7:30			
Portland at Golden State, 10			

MYSTICS' NEXT THREE

at Chicago Sky			
Sept. 17	8	Monumental	

at Indiana Fever			
Sept. 20	4	Monumental	

vs. Connecticut Sun			
Sept. 22	7:30	Monumental	

BASKETBALL

FIBA Women's World Cup

In Berlin			
GROUP A			
FRIDAY'S RESULTS			
Japan 102, Mali 97			
Spain 83, Germany 53			
SATURDAY'S GAMES			
Mali vs. Spain, 5:30 a.m.			
Germany vs. Japan, noon			
MONDAY'S GAMES			
Japan vs. Spain, 11:50 a.m.			
Germany vs. Mali, 11:50 a.m.			

GROUP B			
FRIDAY'S RESULTS			
Korea 99, Nigeria 81			
France 99, Hungary 53			
SATURDAY'S GAMES			
Nigeria vs. Hungary, 8:15 a.m.			
France vs. Korea, 2:45			
MONDAY'S GAMES			
Hungary vs. Korea, 8:30 a.m.			
Nigeria vs. France, 8:30 a.m.			

GROUP C			
FRIDAY'S RESULTS			
Australia 70, Puerto Rico 54			
Belgium 89, Turkey 75			
SUNDAY'S GAMES			
Turkey vs. Australia, 5:30 a.m.			
Puerto Rico vs. Belgium, 11:45 a.m.			
MONDAY'S GAMES			
Belgium vs. Australia, 5:30 a.m.			
Puerto Rico vs. Turkey, 5:30 a.m.			

GROUP D			
FRIDAY'S RESULTS			
Italy 63, Czech Republic 54			
SUNDAY'S GAMES			
China vs. Czech Republic, 8:30 a.m.			
Italy vs. United States, 2:45			
MONDAY'S GAMES			
United States vs. Czech Republic, 2:45			
Italy vs. China, 2:45			

QUALIFICATION TO QUARTERFINALS			
TUESDAY'S GAMES			
2nd Group A vs. 3rd Group B, TBD			
2nd Group B vs. 3rd Group A, TBD			
WEDNESDAY'S GAMES			
3rd Group D vs. 2nd Group C, TBD			
3rd Group C vs. 2nd Group D, TBD			

QUARTERFINALS			
THURSDAY'S GAMES			
3rd Group D/2nd Group C winner vs. 1st Group A, TBD			
2nd Group D/1st Group B winner vs. 1st Group B, TBD			
2nd Group B/3rd Group A winner vs. 1st Group A, TBD			
2nd Group A/3rd Group B winner vs. 1st Group B, TBD			
SEMIFINALS			
SATURDAY, SEPT. 12			
Quarterfinal winners, TBD			
SUNDAY, SEPT. 13			
Quarterfinal losers, TBD			
FINAL			
Semifinal winners, TBD			

HIGH SCHOOLS

FRIDAY'S RESULTS			
FOOTBALL			
MARYLAND			
Annapolis 39, Queen Anne's County 0			
Blair 39, Wheaton 21			
Broadneck 29, St. Mary's (Annapolis) 27			
Calvert 27, Leonardtown 15			
Crofton 44, Southern 0			
Damascus 55, Richard Montgomery 18			
Glen Burnie 48, Ferry Hall 22			
Howard 63, Mt. Hebron 0			
North County 6, Kenwood 6			
Northwest 29, Blake 14			
Old Mill 32, Meade 8			
Patuxent 12, Westlake 6			
Quince Orchard 28, Plant Branch 0			
Seneca Valley 38, Clarksburg 0			
Severna Park 54, Wide Lake 8			
Severn School 36, Severna Park 10			
Sherwood 57, Magruder 0			
South River 14, Randallstown 10			
Springbrook 14, Einstein 12			
St. Charles 30, Lackerby 0			
Thomas Stone 33, La Plata 21			
Walter Johnson 20, Gaithersburg 19			
Wootton 47, Rockville 0			
PRIVATE			
Archbishop Carroll 30, Friendship Collegiate 24			
Bishop O'Connell 41, John Paul The Great 0			
Episcopal 20, Paul VI 8			
Good Counsel 41, Bergen Catholic 39			
John Carroll 56, Annapolis Area Christian School 14			
Mar 14, Penn Wood 0			
Mount Carmel 42, Bishop Ireton 0			
Riverview Baptist 54, North East 6			
St. Albans 21, St. Paul's 12			
BOYS' SOCCER			
MARYLAND			
Clarksburg 3, Sherwood 2 (OT)			
Severna Park 2, Oakdale 0			

GIRLS' VOLLEYBALL			
MARYLAND			
Einstein 3, Blake 2			

BOYS' TENNIS			
PRIVATE			
Bishop Ireton 9, John Paul The Great 0			

NCAA

WEEK 1			
THURSDAY'S RESULTS			
Massachusetts 37, at Rutgers 21			
at Delaware 42, Merrimack 1			
at Stony Brook 36, Lindenwood 32			
at Buffalo 21, Albany 17			
SOUTH			
at Morehead State 75, Kentucky Christian 24			
at Wake Forest 38, Akron 16			
at UCF 73, Bethune-Cookman 6			
Southern Illinois 22, at Samford 18			
at Kennesaw State 47, West Georgia 0			
Colorado 14, at Georgia Tech 13			
MIDWEST			
at Missouri 54, Arkansas Pine Bluff 14			
at Minnesota 59, Eastern Illinois 7			
at Illinois 42, Alabama Birmingham 23			
WEST			
at Missouri 54, Idaho 14			

FRIDAY'S RESULTS			
EAST			
at Marist 27, Franklin Pierce 18			
SOUTH			
at Georgia State 29, North Carolina A&T 10			
MIDWEST			
San José State 27, at Eastern Michigan 21			
at Purdue 44, Indiana State 19			
Long Island at Kansas, late			
Toledo at Michigan State, late			
SOUTHWEST			
UTEP at Oklahoma, late			
WEST			
Fresno State at USC, late			
Miami at Stanford, late			

SATURDAY'S GAMES			
EAST			
Lehigh at Georgetown, 12:30			
Townson at Navy, 3:30			
Richmond at Howard, 6			
Hampton at Maryland, 8			
Southern Connecticut at Wagner, noon			
Lafayette at Connecticut, noon			
New Hampshire at Syracuse, noon			
Stonehill at New Haven, noon			
Bryant at Army, noon			
Coastal Carolina at West Virginia, noon			
Miami (Ohio) at Pittsburgh, 12:30			
Holy Cross at Colgate, 1			
Rhode Island at Temple, 2			
Sacred Heart at Monmouth, 2			
Marshall at Penn State, 3:30			
West Virginia State at Robert Morris, 6			

Trump officials: Work will start on triumphal arch

BY DAN DIAMOND

Administration officials Thursday announced that they would soon begin work to build President Donald Trump's planned 250-foot-tall triumphal arch, his most significant change to Washington's skyline.

"We are preparing to start, over the next two-week period, the excavation work necessary," Interior Secretary Doug Burgum wrote on X.

The announcement comes three days after the Supreme

Court allowed Trump to keep building his planned White House ballroom, with a 5-4 ruling that historical preservationists who sought to block that project lacked legal standing to bring their case to court.

That decision created new hurdles to other court challenges of Trump's projects, legal experts warned, and Justice Department lawyers invoked it Thursday as they sought to dismiss a legal challenge to the arch.

The administration plans to build the arch in Memorial Circle,

CONSTRUCTION ON 250-FOOT STRUCTURE

Controversial edifice is planned near cemetery

a traffic roundabout tucked inside Washington's boundaries near Arlington National Cemetery. Trump has said that the arch will honor the nation's 250th anniversary, vowing that it will be the largest triumphal arch in the world — about 86 feet taller than France's famed Arc de Triomphe.

Historical preservationists, Democratic lawmakers and some Washington residents have opposed the project, calling it an oversize and inappropriate structure that will disrupt the historically solemn corridor between the military cemetery and the Lincoln Memorial.

It is also the subject of a lawsuit brought by several military veterans who say the towering structure would alter their experience when visiting the nearby military cemetery.

Administration lawyers Thursday asked a federal court to throw out the military veterans' challenge to the arch, citing the Supreme Court ruling on the ballroom as precedent.

"Plaintiffs' distaste for the perceived symbolism of the proposed arch does not establish a concrete and particularized inju-

ry," Justice Department lawyers wrote.

Administration officials have laid out an aggressive timeline to potentially complete the arch within two to three years, saying that crews would work 20 hours per day, year-round. Trump and his deputies also contend that they do not need approval from Congress because lawmakers authorized a somewhat similar project a century ago that was never built.

"It was meant to be built for
SEE ARCH ON B15



PETER W. STEVENSON/THE WASHINGTON POST

September storm packed a punch

Intense overnight activity resulted in downed trees and other damage; Prince George's closed schools

Tens of thousands of residents across the D.C. region are without power, and crews are working to clear downed trees after a powerful storm ripped through the area overnight.

As of 12:30 p.m. Friday, Pepco's website reported more than 800 active outages in D.C. and Maryland with nearly 36,000 customers affected. Dominion Energy, located in Richmond, reported that more than 20,000 homes and businesses across Virginia are without power, including more than 9,000 in Fairfax County.

In Prince George's County, Pepco said more than 26,000 customers were affected by outages. Prince George's County Public Schools said all its schools would be closed because a large number of schools and offices were without power, and it said downed trees and power lines were

BY OMARI DANIELS

A downed tree blocks westbound lanes on Massachusetts Avenue and 11th Street NW on Friday morning after overnight storms wreaked havoc on the region.

impacting cleanup efforts.

In D.C., officials were also responding to calls about downed wires and trees after the storm.

The District's Fire and Emergency Medical Services Department warned residents to assume that all downed lines are live and to not try to move downed power lines.

D.C. Council member Charles Allen (D-Ward 6) posted on social media that he saw "a LOT of downed trees & damage," including a tree that came down on Fifth and F streets NE, crushing a car, and blocking roads and sidewalks.

City agencies advised residents to place fallen branches and debris from their property or vehicle at a trash collection point — not in roads, bike lanes or sidewalks.

SEE STORM ON B14

Tarmac talk among dad, daughter stirs debate on family plans

Spontaneous banter that went viral sparked questions on adulthood

BY LIAM SCOTT

The voice of Kenny Katnik's father is the first one she heard over an airplane radio. That's because he taught her how to fly in a two-seat plane, about a decade ago.

Now a professional pilot herself, Katnik wasn't expecting to hear that voice while on the tarmac at Washington Dulles International Airport this week.

"When he and I were in the airplane a long time ago, his voice

was there. And so I just feel like there was something in my brain that was like, 'I know this voice,'" the 24-year-old told The Washington Post.

The two-minute radio conversation, captured on air traffic control recordings on ATC.com, is a heartwarming one — between a father and a daughter who followed in his footsteps. On social media, it has also led to an unexpected flare-up in the long-standing debate over how old is too old for children to stay on their parents' cellphone plans.

The pair had breakfast together Tuesday morning, but neither said they were expecting their impromptu tarmac reunion.

"Pops?" Kenny, whose legal name is Margaret, asked after hearing him on the radio.



KENNY KATNIK

Pilots Kenny and Kent Katnik, right, created a debate online.

Kent Katnik, 58, replied in typical understated dad fashion: "Hello. Where are you at?"

"About to depart 1R," Kenny replied, referring to the runway. "Safe travels."

Kenny, who works for Commute Air, was flying a United Express jet to Syracuse, New York. Kent, a pilot for more than 20 years, including more than a decade with United, was flying to Munich. "Bye-bye," he said to his daughter.

At this point, an air traffic controller piped up. "That's your daughter?" he asked.

"Apparently," Kent responded dryly.

"So your daughter's a pilot. Aren't you proud, Papa?" the controller said. "Sort of," Kent said

SEE PILOT FAMILY ON B15

TODAY'S WEATHER

			
8 a.m.	Noon	4 p.m.	8 p.m.
76°	80°	83°	78°

High today at approx. 3 p.m.: **83°**
Precip: **25%** Wind: **NNW 6-12 mph**

For weather news, go to **B18**

VIRGINIA

Amazon withdraws its groundwater permit in King George County. **B15**

OBITUARIES

George Joseph, 104, was a pioneering insurance force in California. **B16**



D.C. FIRE AND EMS



PETER W. STEVENSON/THE WASHINGTON POST



FINN GOMEZ/GETTY IMAGES

Early September storm packs a punch in region

STORM FROM B13

Metrorail said customers would experience delays in both directions on the Orange, Blue and Silver lines. Damage was reported at some rail stations, including a piece of fallen concrete on a rail just outside Stadium-Armory and an obstruction blocking part of a track at Franconia-Springfield.

The National Weather Service for Baltimore/Washington said more scattered thunderstorms were likely on Friday afternoon and evening as a strong cold front moves through the region.

CLOCKWISE FROM TOP: A large tree fell on a rowhouse in Southeast Washington; a downed tree blocks westbound lanes on Massachusetts Avenue NW downtown Friday; and workers drain storm water out of the Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool following a strong overnight storm that had an impact, closing Prince George's County Schools before the holiday.



FINN GOMEZ/GETTY IMAGES

VIRGINIA

University of Virginia forecast predicts loss of 18,050 jobs in state this year

BY MICHAEL MARTZ
Richmond Times-Dispatch

Virginia is likely to lose 18,050 jobs this year as the state's labor supply continues to shrink, even though the unemployment rate has stayed relatively steady, according to a new report by the University of Virginia's Weldon Cooper Center for Public Service.

The new quarterly forecast shows modest improvement in the outlook for economic productivity, driven by investments in artificial intelligence and the data centers to support it, but it also sees "a substantial contraction in Virginia's labor force." The labor force declined by 68,000 jobs from the beginning of last year through June, the report said. Last month, the federal government estimated that Virginia lost 48,000 jobs in the 12 months through July.

The state's labor participation rate sits at 63.1 percent, an all-time low, but it's still two

percentage points higher than the national rate. Reduced labor participation, paradoxically, has limited the rise in unemployment because fewer people are actively looking for work. The state's unemployment rate was 3.7 percent in July, slightly below where it has been for most of this year, although about a half-percent higher than a year ago.

"When someone retires, becomes discouraged and stops searching, or otherwise withdraws from labor-force participation, that person is no longer counted as unemployed," the center said Wednesday. "Similarly, when workers move to another state, they leave Virginia's workforce even if they remain economically active elsewhere."

The report suggests that most of the job losses came earlier this year, "with conditions becoming more stable as 2026 progresses."

Virginia's tax revenue continues to exceed expectations, but Secretary of Finance Mark Sick-

les remains concerned about the job market and the economic reliance on artificial intelligence spending in the face of a public backlash against data centers.

"The bottom line is that people don't know where this economy is going," Sickles said Wednesday.

A new report by the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics shows a similar trend in labor participation statewide and in metropolitan areas, including Richmond. Virginia lost nearly 67,000 jobs during the 12 months through

July, even though it picked up about 12,000 jobs since June. Unemployment also rose for the year by about 8,500 people but declined by about 6,700 from June to July.

The Richmond area lost about 10,400 jobs in the 12 months through July, even though it picked up about 5,900 from the previous month.

Weldon Cooper now expects Virginia's economy to grow by about a half-percent this year, instead of the decline that the center predicted in its last quarterly forecast in May. But those gains are not likely to add jobs because the state remains reliant on government employment and spending, which President Donald Trump (R) has cut substantially since returning to the White House last year.

The effects are most apparent in professional and business services, which include federal contractors, and direct federal employment, where losses are part-

ly offset by gains in local and state government jobs.

"That continues to be the great question in Virginia," said Joao Ferreira, acting director of the Center for Economic and Policy Studies at Weldon Cooper.

Virginia relies on tax collections from high-paying jobs in professional and business services, which lost about 17,000 jobs last year and an additional 9,500 in the first half of this year. However, Weldon Cooper expects a total reduction of 5,200 jobs this year in that sector, which it said "suggests that some stabilization is expected in the second half, but the sector is not yet forecast to return to growth."

The report projects about 9,500 fewer jobs in manufacturing this year, which already lost about 4,400 jobs in the first six months. Jobs in administrative support are also declining, with a projected loss of 5,700 jobs this year. It predicts slight gains in government employment, pri-

marily local; transportation and warehousing; and wholesale and retail services.

Construction, which has been a stable source of jobs, now expects to lose about 1,700 through the end of this year. Health care, one of the strongest sectors, added about 2,800 jobs in the first six months, and Weldon Cooper expects a net gain of 4,400 jobs through the end of the year. That would be less than half of the 9,100 jobs that the health-care sector added in Virginia last year, as the industry faces significant future cuts in federal Medicaid spending under the tax cut package that Trump signed into law last year.

"You're going to see that erode significantly in the next 12 to 18 months because of" the tax cut package, predicted former Secretary of Finance Aubrey Layne, executive vice president and chief administrative officer at Sentara Health in Norfolk.

Viral family exchange on phone sparks chat

PILOT FAMILY FROM B13

with a whiff of sarcasm.

“Is she still living in your house?” the controller asked.

“Oh no, but she is on my cellphone plan,” Kent replied.

The controller said she shouldn’t have to leave the plan until marriage. “I was on my mama’s cellphone plan till I got married,” he said.

“I am single,” Kenny interjected.

“Well, see, you’ve got to stay on Daddy’s cellphone plan,” the controller said.

About three-quarters of Americans say that coming off a parent’s plan is one of the “ultimate signs” of adulthood, according to a 2025 survey of over 2,000 adults by AT&T.

In an interview, Kenny quipped that she forgot you have to pay for a cellphone plan. “I’ve just been on it forever,” she said. “I guess I’ll stay on it until he kicks me off. But I think I’m nice enough that he won’t kick me off.”

Kenny’s two older siblings — a 26-year-old sister and a 28-year-old brother, who’s also a pilot — are still on the family plan, too, she said. “Once they’re off, I’ll consider leaving, too. But until then, it’s fair that we’re all on it,” Kenny said.

On social media, the interaction sparked a spirited back-and-forth over how long is too long for children to mooch off their parents.

“My sisters been married 16 years and is still on the family cell plan lol,” one Instagram user wrote.

“Tried to stay on mine but my daddy kicked me off once I got married,” wrote another.

Kent, who is based in Denver, said he has no plans to kick any of them off anytime soon.

“I feel like they will make their own decisions when they feel it’s appropriate, and it’s the responsible decision to make. But I’m happy to assist them. It’s a privilege,” he said.

“The nice thing is I know when she or her siblings are traveling because they get those extra charges on the cellphone bill,” he added.

When pilots are taxiing, Kent said they have to pay attention to all external factors that might be a possible threat.

“But in this very spontaneous situation,” he said, “I couldn’t not say anything.”

“I have a little bit of a dry sense of humor, and I think sometimes the obvious things don’t need to be said,” Kent added. “Of course I’m proud. That would be just the obvious answer.”

Growing up, Kenny said her dad wanted to teach all his kids to fly, but she never expected to make a career of it.

“I’ve been super fortunate and super privileged to be able to follow in his footsteps and be able to, like, live my dream,” she said. “I’m hoping to get on with United as soon as I can, and I hope to fly with my dad soon.”

About three-quarters of Americans say that coming off a parent’s plan is one of the “ultimate signs” of adulthood, according to a 2025 survey of over 2,000 adults by AT&T.



ALEX WONG/Getty Images

Construction on Trump edifice will continue

ARCH FROM B13

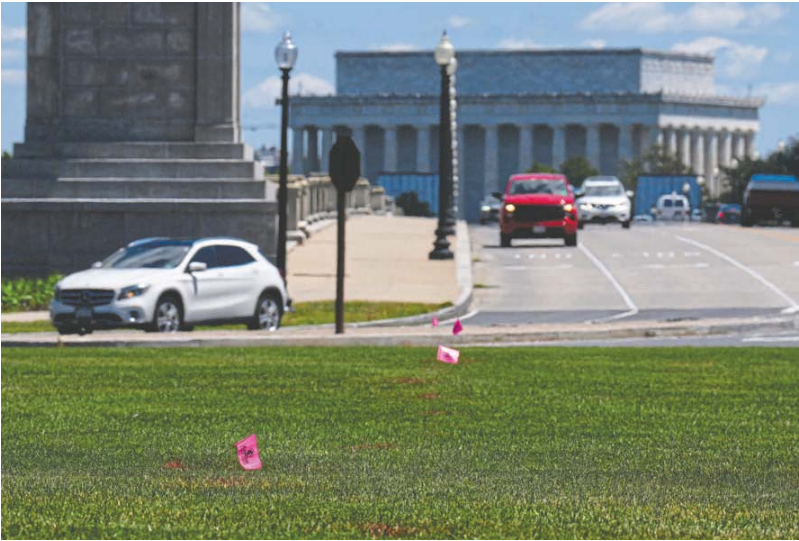
many years,” Trump said in the Oval Office in May. “The land is owned by secretary, by the Interior Department. We don’t need anything from Congress.”

The project already has received approval from the Commission of Fine Arts, a federal panel that reviews local design projects. The National Capital Planning Commission, a second federal panel that has been reviewing the project, has yet to issue final approval.

Democratic lawmakers have said that the arch must go through congressional review.

Rep. Don Beyer (D-Virginia), who represents the district that includes Arlington National Cemetery, said Thursday that the administration was speeding the project ahead of the midterm elections. He cited the possibility of Democrats retaking control of a chamber of Congress and creating new barriers to the president’s projects.

“They believe, I hope correctly, that the project will be endangered by a new Democratic majority that actually stands up to Trump,” Beyer said in a statement. “This project is not even close to being ready for prime time.”



Jacquelyn Martin/AP

“Plaintiffs’ distaste for the perceived symbolism of the proposed arch does not establish a concrete and particularized injury,” Justice Department lawyers wrote.

Lawyers for Public Citizen, a watchdog group that is representing the military veterans, have urged a federal judge to halt the project, too.

“Frankly, I’m befuddled as to what sort of legal authority the

administration thinks it has behind it,” Nicolas Sansone, Public Citizen’s lead attorney on the case, said Thursday, citing the lack of final approval from the National Capital Planning Commission.

A White House official told The Washington Post on Thursday that administration officials do not believe they need approval for their planned work at the arch site, which they characterized as different from construction.

“We will of course continue on our path of seeking final approval from all applicable entities,” said the official, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss planned construction.

Trump administration lawyers had told the judge that the project should not be halted because it had not officially begun. Officials also told the judge that they would provide the public at least 14 days’ notice before beginning construction.

Fifty-two percent of Americans are against the planned arch, compared with 21 percent who favor it, according to a Washington Post-ABC-Ipsos poll conducted in April.

Trump has prioritized construction of the arch, along with the ballroom and other Washington-area projects.

“When completed, it will be, without question, the Greatest Arch of them all!” the president wrote on his Truth Social platform in June.

VIRGINIA

Amazon withdraws groundwater permit in rural part of state

Controversy has surrounded planned data center in the area

BY DAVE RESS
Richmond Times-Dispatch

Amazon has withdrawn a controversial bid for a permit to draw groundwater for a proposed data center campus in King George County.

That request to the state Department of Environmental Quality had stirred strong opposition from the county’s water utility and the state senator representing the area, since groundwater

in nearby areas of the aquifer was already severely depleted.

Amazon Web Services withdrew the request in an email two days after the Times-Dispatch reported on a controversy that erupted after Department of Environmental Quality published a public notice disclosing the permit.

“AWS is aware of the public concerns raised regarding this permit. We take concerns of the community seriously, and after careful consideration, have decided to withdraw the application,” the company said.

“It is AWS’s intent to work closely with VDEQ and other relevant agencies to identify alternative sources for potable water service to the future campus,” the

email said.

Amazon had asked the DEQ for permission to draw up to 6.4 million gallons a year for a data center campus it wants to build on the site of a shuttered power plant.

DEQ staff had determined that Amazon’s request “satisfies the technical evaluation criteria for permit issuance,” department records show.

But public notice of Amazon’s permit request came 10 days before DEQ told the county it was rejecting its request for permission to draw 3.25 million more gallons of water from the same aquifer for its Fairview Beach/Potomac Landing well, to supply new housing and a hoped-for medical facility.

Amazon’s request would have allowed it to draw water even as the county water authority is under state orders to eventually cut the amount its largest well draws by 33.6 million gallons per year to slow depletion of the Potomac aquifer.

That means turning to the Rappahannock River for drinking water.

That in turn means a major expense — \$75 million to \$100 million — to build a water treatment plant, pipes and pumps, as well as buying land, securing rights of way and getting a DEQ permit.

“Having delivered that directive, the department now proposes to hand a fresh allocation of 6.4 million gallons per year from

the same aquifer in the same county to one of the largest corporations on Earth. That is indefensible,” state Sen. Richard Stuart, R-King George, said in a letter to the DEQ after it disclosed Amazon’s permit request.

Amazon has proposed a data center campus on the property with up to eight data center buildings and ancillary buildings to maintain and support the campus.

The county and Amazon have been battling in court over an agreement for the data center campus that the board of supervisors approved in late 2023, but that a newly elected board rescinded the following January. At issue as well is a dispute over the rezoning of the site.



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OBITUARIES



George Joseph, shown in 2012, was chairman of Mercury General and a strident free-market advocate with respect to consumer options.

George Joseph, 104

Pioneering insurance magnate’s career spanned multiple decades

BY LAURENCE DARMIENTO
Los Angeles Times

George Joseph came of age during the Great Depression, a calamity that left with him with a stated desire to always have plenty of work to do.

The billionaire insurance executive was busy enough during a career that lasted more than 70 years, highlighted by his founding of Mercury General Corp., which became one of California’s largest property and casualty carriers.

But the unyielding free market advocate likely became just as well known for his opposition to Proposition 103, the landmark 1988 insurance initiative that regulated the industry following a period of skyrocketing auto premiums.

Mr. Joseph died Aug. 26 at age 104. He was still chairperson of Mercury General, which is publicly traded and operates in 11 states. Forbes estimated Joseph’s net worth at \$2.6 billion.

“George Joseph was a lion of the industry,” said Brian Sullivan, executive editor of Risk Information. “He believed that good companies would make money. Bad companies would fail. And consumers would get fair prices from fierce competition.”

Details of Mr. Joseph’s death were not released. Company chief executive Gabriel Tirador was named to succeed him as chairperson.

He was born on Sept. 11, 1921, to Lebanese immigrant parents and raised in Beckley, W. Va., a coal town where his father worked as a storekeeper and miner. He volunteered for military service during World War II and, with an affinity for math, served

as a navigator on a B-17 bomber that saw heavy action.

Mr. Joseph attended Harvard University on the GI Bill and completed majors in math and physics in just three years. He got a job as an actuary working for a life insurer and later became a sales agent and broker.

In 1962, he started Mercury — named after the Roman god of speed and commerce — with \$2 million in capital he raised, six employees and 90 agents. His business model was to offer coverage to all drivers, who would pay different rates based on their risk profile, an unusual idea at a time when insurers specialized in one end of the market or another.

“My thought was, there must be a proper rate for all these exposures — why not all in one company?” he explained to the Los Angeles Times in a 2006 profile. The company went public in 1985.

Mr. Joseph settled on the use of Zip codes as a primary predictor of risk, setting the stage for a series of battles with consumer advocates that began amid the rising premium rates in the 1980s and California’s 1988’s passage of Proposition 103.

The ballot measure requires a motorist’s driving record, years behind the wheel and annual miles driven to be the primary factors in setting rates, relegating residency to a relatively minor role — which advocates said is only a matter of fairness.

The measure, which also established an elected insurance commissioner with the authority to review rates, passed with 51 percent of the vote. A competing industry measure supported by Mr. Joseph that would have established a no-fault auto insurance regime with limits on damage claims failed by a large margin.

In 2006, Mr. Joseph pursued ballot measures that would have amended Proposition 103 amid an effort by John Garamendi, the insurance commissioner at the time, to tighten the Zip code regulations established by his predecessor.

However, Mr. Joseph withdrew the measures after the author of 103, attorney Harvey Rosenfield, threatened to put a counter measure on the ballot.

“He was committed to overturning Prop. 103 and never was able to do so. But he put more into it than any other insurance company,” said Rosenfield, founder of Los Angeles advocacy group Consumer Watchdog, the proposition’s leading defender.

Mr. Joseph’s free market approach inevitably was at odds with Rosenfield’s advocacy of a state-regulated industry, Sullivan said. “The two of them spent the better part of several decades sparring,” he said.

Mr. Joseph also was known as an executive who liked to get into the weeds.

In a 2010 interview with Times columnist Steve Lopez — when he

was bankrolling yet another proposition that would have amended California’s insurance laws — his office was described as crammed full of knee-high stacks of documents he would check to prove his points.

“You can’t debate it in the newspaper,” Mr. Joseph was quoted as saying, acknowledging that insurance can be technical and complicated.

Mr. Joseph’s tenacity could come back to haunt his company, which clashed with California regulators over how it handled claims and other issues.

In 2019, Mercury ended a two-decade battle with the state about fees of up to \$150 customers were charged from 1999 to 2004, on top of their premiums. The company maintained the fees were legal because they were charged by independent brokers, but regulators said the brokers operated as company agents and the fees amounted to premiums, with customers thinking the policies were cheaper than they actually were.

The \$41.2-million settlement — the largest in state history with an insurer — came after the state Supreme Court declined to hear an appeal of a lower-court decision, which Mercury called “poorly reasoned.”

Mr. Joseph had stepped down as the company’s chief executive in 2006 but maintained involvement in Mercury for two more decades as chairman.

“At 85, I thought it was time for a younger person to take the baton,” Joseph dryly told the Times regarding his departure.

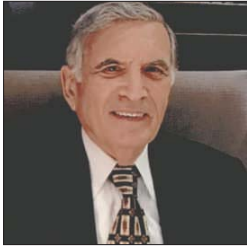
He is survived by his wife, five children and 10 grandchildren. His son, Victor Joseph, is Mercury’s president and chief operating officer.

Mr. Joseph believed “good companies would make money. And consumers would get fair prices.”

Brian Sullivan, executive editor of Risk Information

DEATH NOTICE

CHMAR



WILLIAM CHMAR (Age 82)
Dr. William Chmar, of Brookeville, MD, passed away on Thursday, September 3rd, at the age of 82. He is survived by his devoted wife, Ellen Chmar (nee' Glass), his loving

children, Karen (Steven) London and Allyson (Benjamin) Geber; caring brother-and sister-in-law, Susan and Barry Yaffe; cherished granddaughters, Sidney and Charlotte London; and his treasured nieces and nephews, Susan and Michael Stein, Michael and Amy Chmar, Joey and Andrea Yaffe, and Lisa Yaffe. He was predeceased by his adored parents, Phillip and Mollie Chmar; and his loving sister, Deborah Yaffe.

Known to many as “Dr. Billy,” he was an outstanding husband, father, and dentist. He was loved by his patients for his dedication and artistry.

Service will be at Sol Levinson’s Chapel on Sunday, September 6th at 3:30 PM. Interment will follow at Beth Jacob Cemetery in Finksburg, MD. Please omit flowers. Contributions in his memory may be sent to Alzheimer’s Association, P.O. Box 96011, Washington, DC 20090-6011 or U.S. Holocaust Memorial Museum, 100 Raoul Wallenberg Place SW, Washington, DC 20024.
www.sollevinson.com

PERRY



VERA ROSS PERRY (Age 98)
Vera Ross Perry (née Vera Mae Ross), a trailblazing computer programmer, dedicated civil servant, and activist, passed away peacefully on August 30, 2026.

Born on August 13, 1928, in McCalla, Alabama, Vera was one of ten children born to Joe and Lela Ross. Raised in the Uniontown, Pennsylvania area alongside her five brothers and four sisters, she displayed an extraordinary gift for mathematics early in life—a talent that paved the way for a remarkable and fulfilling career.

As a young woman, Vera relocated to Washington, D.C., beginning her professional journey as a clerk at Howard University in the office of President Mordecai Johnson. Her mathematical acumen quickly propelled her into high-impact roles across the federal government and private sector, where she served as a true “hidden figure.” She worked for the U.S. Census Bureau and later for the Bureau of Labor Statistics, where she was part of the pivotal team that calculated the Consumer Price Index by hand.

Vera went on to attend IBM school, breaking barriers as one of the nation’s first Black women computer programmers. Her technical expertise led to key roles with Utica Mutual Insurance, the Federal Reserve Bank of Richmond, and Blue Cross Blue Shield. She ultimately retired as a Systems Analyst from the Department of Labor, culminating 25 years of federal service marked by numerous commendations for exceptional achievement.

Deeply committed to civil rights and community activism, Vera held a lifelong skepticism toward traditions and institutions that fostered inequality. While volunteering for the NAACP in Washington, D.C., she met Vincent Perry. They married, relocated to Utica, New York, and welcomed their daughter, Vanessa Gail Perry.

Vera found immense joy in life’s simple pleasures. She cherished family gatherings, loved shopping trips, never turned down ice cream or a good dessert, and was an avid fan of both the Washington Redskins and the Pittsburgh Steelers.

Vera was preceded in death by her parents, Joe and Lela Ross; her four sisters, Ida Ross Theadford, Lenora Jean Watson, Cornelia Sorrell, and Betty Jo Lewis; and her five brothers, Benjamin, Cleophus, Matthew, George Earl, and Thomas Edward Ross.

She leaves to cherish her memory her husband of over 60 years, Vincent Perry; her daughter, Vanessa Gail Perry; and a host of extended family members, nieces, nephews, and friends.

At Vera’s request, no traditional services will take place. In lieu of flowers, the family would appreciate donations made in her honor to the NAACP at <https://naacp.org/ways-give/honor-someone-special>.

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1002 Happy Days

NOVENA TO THE BLESSED VIRGIN
OH, MOST BEAUTIFUL FLOWER OF MOUNT CARMEL, FRUITFUL VINE, SPLENDOR OF HEAVEN, GOD, IMMACULATE VIRGIN, ASSIST ME IN MY NECESSITY OH, STAR OF THE SEA, HELP ME, SHOW ME HEREIN YOU ARE MY MOTHER. OH, HOLY MARY MOTHER OF GOD, QUEEN OF HEAVEN AND EARTH, HUMBLY BESEECH YOU FROM THE BOTTOM OF MY HEART TO SUCCOUR ME IN THIS NECESSITY. THERE ARE NONE THAT CAN WITHSTAND YOUR POWER. OH, SHOW ME HEREIN YOU ARE MY MOTHER. OH, MARY CONCEIVED WITHOUT ORIGINAL SIN, PRAY FOR US WHO HAVE RECOURSE TO THEE (SAY THIS THREE TIMES) HOLY MOTHER, PLACE THIS CAUSE IN YOUR HANDS (SAY THIS THREE TIMES). HOLY SPIRIT, YOU WHO SOLVE ALL PROBLEMS, LIGHT ALL ROADS SO THAT ALL CAN ATTAIN MY GOAL. YOU WHO GAVE ME THE GIFT OF LIFE, GIFT TO FORGET AND FORGIVE ALL EVIL AGAINST ME AND THAT IN ALL INSTANCES IN MY LIFE ARE WITH ME. I WANT IN THIS SHORT PRAYER TO THANK YOU FOR ALL THINGS AS YOU CONFIRM ONCE AGAIN THAT I NEVER WANT TO BE SEPARATED FROM YOU IN ETERNAL GLORY. THANK YOU FOR YOUR TOWARD ME AND MINE.

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